

IMMUNITY TO CHANGE

COACH'S GUIDE

LISA LASKOW LAHEY
DEBORAH HELSING
ROBERT KEGAN

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Volume I

Lisa Laskow Lahey
Deborah Helsing
Robert Kegan

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Introduction

Let's start with a great old joke. A guy asks the waiter, "How do you prepare the chicken in this restaurant?" and the waiter replies, "We just tell them straight out: 'You're going to die!'" The purpose of this introduction is to prepare you, in a variety of ways, to make the best use of this *Guide to Immunity-to-Change*TM coaching. So, with the same "straight out" spirit (but a happier message): Welcome to the most satisfying way of helping people change their lives we have experienced in our professional careers!

As satisfying as it has been to help our coachees, it is an especially generative experience to help accomplished coaches learn to skillfully integrate the Immunity-to-Change (ITC) approach into their repertoires, in a way that is both fitting to their distinctive and differing styles, while commonly preserving the signature features of this work.

Since our Coach Certification Program puts participants in both roles – ITC coachee and coach — their written reflections often speak to both of these satisfactions. For example, one person wrote:

In working on my own ITC with [my CCP coach], I made some big steps forward. I thought I had already done the heavy lifting of separating from my "feelings-are-self-indulgent" upbringing, and embracing the fact that perfection is a ridiculous standard. I had long since figured out that to love other people well I first had to learn to love myself. I thought I was doing pretty well. Then I wrote out my own map and was chastened to see how much remained and what a pull certain assumptions still had on me even when I had intellectually put them to bed long ago. Above all, I could see the standards I imposed on myself that I would never hold another person to, and which held me back from fully throwing myself into my ambitions. I wanted to promote my business fearlessly in the for-profit sector (my Column One goal) yet I was doing anything but focus on that one priority, taking on too many distracting commitments for others, and telling myself all sorts of stories about how corporations would judge my time out of the workforce.

[My CCP coach] was a model – listening deeply, probing gently, accepting me where I was but wanting more for me at the same time. It felt both humbling and empowering to have someone in my camp, really seeing and empathizing with the conflict in me but not letting me swallow my own stories without asking some really hard questions first. In part it was her, in part it was the process, and in part it was me taking the time to really tease something apart without shrinking from hard realities that helped me to move forward. I think I just got tired of my own story and seeing it down on paper, realized that I didn't want to live my life like that anymore. So now I'm out there doing my fearless thing and it feels great! I feel liberated from a great weight.

And this same person wrote:

The experience of being coached and breaking free from my own tether makes me all the more energized about continuing to bring the same possibilities to my clients. In other forms of coaching, I have found it takes longer for the client to start “going deep.” I typically use assessments and 360 interviews near the start of a coaching assignment which help bring the client to a different level of self-understanding but they are time consuming (and costly). Using ITC, I know a client will have some valuable insights during the first 90 minutes of the mapping process and that these nuggets will be built upon, added to, and refined throughout the coaching arc. The fact that the client is “telling on himself” rather than receiving feedback that represents “someone else telling on him” helps keep defenses at a minimum. So a quick start and depth of insight both set ITC apart as a coaching approach.

I also find that ITC allows the coach and client to follow a very specific thread linked to a very specific goal, allowing visible progress to be made on an issue of real importance to the client in a relatively short period of time. That focus doesn't prevent the client from getting value across a broader set of goals because the key BA's often underlie a range of issues. Personally, I need to hone my ability to keep the client on target because I tend to be expansive and to not want to confine myself to an overly-narrow focus. It is a skill to find what is simple in what is complex.

If these words give you a flavor for why this work is so satisfying, they also give us the chance to tell you “straight out” what this Guide is **not**: It is not an account of such satisfactions. It is not a written version of the meaningfulness of the ITC coaching journey. If ITC coaching is a special kind of journey, the Guide is **not** a “travelogue;” it is more like a map. If ITC coaching is a finely tuned sports car, the Guide is **not** the ride, or a written way of enabling you to vicariously experience the ride; the Guide is the operator's manual. It is not meant to be an “interesting read,” any more than an operator's manual makes for “interesting reading.” It is meant to be very useful. It is, in short, a **tool**.

This Guide is, in fact, just one of five publications we presume are in the possession of a coach who wants to make use of the ITC approach. These publications are:

1. The book, *Immunity to Change* (Harvard Business School Press, 2010), by Kegan and Lahey. We assume readers of the Coach's Guide have already read this book, and thus have a familiarity with ITC concepts, the adult-developmental theory on which the approach rests, and the varied contexts, purposes, and forms of its delivery.
2. The guide, *Facilitator's Guide to ITC Map-Making* (Minds at Work, 2002; updated, 2011). We assume readers of the *Coach's Guide* are familiar with the *Facilitator's Guide*, and thus know how to help coachees develop a powerful "map," the diagnostic foundation for ITC coaching.
3. The workbook, *The ITC Coachee's Workbook* (Minds at Work, 2011), an accompanying aid you can give each of your coachees to help them structure and capture their learning. We assume readers of the present *Coach's Guide*, being coached themselves, already have some familiarity with this workbook.
4. The workbook, *The ITC Coach's Tracking Book* (Minds at Work, 2011), a kind of "teacher's guide" version of *The ITC Coachee's Workbook*, which you can use, and re-use, to structure and capture your work with each of your coachees.
5. This guide, *The ITC Coach's Guide* (Minds at Work, 2011), intended to teach coaches how to deliver each exercise in the ITC coaching journey.

This Guide is meant to provide you a kind of "archive" of instruction and support to *all* the phases and activities of the ITC coachee's journey. Not every journey involves all of these activities. There may be more here than you will ever need. There are suggestions for responding to snags and challenges here which may never arise for you. When you are just beginning to learn this approach you may follow the Guide to the letter, putting yourself (and your coachee) "in its hands." As you come to integrate the moves into your own coaching "metabolism" you will render them in ways that feel more like "yours" than "ours." As you become more experienced, you may come back to this Guide after a time as a way to refresh yourself and make sure you have not lost your edge. If you are preparing a new portfolio for re-certification, you may find it useful to again use it as a "co-investigator." If you find yourself in an unaccustomed rut with a coachee, or facing an unfamiliar challenge, you might go back and see what the Guide has to say about this one specific thing, exactly the way you might use a car's manual when a surprising problem appears.

This Guide is meant to provide you a kind of "archive" of instruction and support to all the phases and activities of the ITC coachee's journey.

In saying this Guide is more like an operator's manual than the written re-creation of the ride, we also have the chance to warn you away from a mistaken impression the Guide can give you, especially as you read through it (or "work your way" through it, while working with a "practice coachee"). Take another look at the description of the Guide, in #5 above.

It says it will teach you “how to deliver each exercise in the ITC coaching journey.” Exactly. But there is a huge difference between “delivering each exercise in the ITC journey” and “coaching a person using the ITC approach.”

The Ferrari operator’s manual tells you how to fuel the car, how to start it, how to handle a variety of problems that can come up, how to take good care of it, and so on. But the actual ride in the Ferrari would not be well-described as this series of activities. A musi-

The ITC coaching activities are novel figures on the much bigger ground of a relationship focused on the feelings, thoughts, and behaviors of the client.

cal score tells you what beat to keep, when to grow softer or louder, how long to hold a note. But when the piece is performed by a skilled musician she is doing something quite different than “working her way through this series of activities.” The ITC coaching activities are novel figures on the much bigger ground

of a relationship focused on the feelings, thoughts, and behaviors of the client. Without your continuous attention to (and expression of) this relationship, “ITC coaching” will be reduced to “putting your clients through their paces.”

This point is very important, so let’s elaborate on it a bit. In the Guide (and in our Coach Certification Program) we frequently talk about the necessity of “wearing two hats” — the “empathic listener’s” hat; and the “ITC” hat. Both of these hats are absolutely indispensable. But because we are working with experienced helpers, we assume the first hat (while it can always benefit from further practice and enhancement) is familiar. We do have some original ideas about how to enhance this hat (the 1-5 “listening scale;” the way constructive-developmental theory can refine our listening instrument), but, the truth is, the primary “value add” of our program is to teach experienced coaches how to wear the ITC hat. This is what is not familiar. This is what is new. The vast majority of the “air time” in our program — and 95% of the “air time” in this Guide — is oriented to enhancing your ability to wear the ITC hat.

But, if you created a written record of all the speech of an experienced ITC coach’s work with a client over a typical 4-6 month coaching journey, and you put in ALL CAPS only that speech which directly relates to the exercises in this Guide, a *minority* of the words will be in all caps. Much of the time we are listening to (“hearing out”) the stories and accounts — feelings, thoughts, behaviors — the coachee wants to tell us. It’s true, the experienced ITC coach **will** eventually bring the import of many of these stories and accounts back to their implications for the coachee’s self-protective mindset, **but** much of what makes these connections so powerful is the richness of the stories and accounts in the first place, *which is evoked through the coachee’s experience of a relationship with the coach.*

It is completely understandable that, when a coach is first learning the new moves of ITC work, he or she is going to over-focus on the ITC activities, just like the Guide over-focuses on these moves. But this is not masterful ITC coaching (it is not even good ITC coaching). The coachee (and even the coach) are going to experience “ITC fatigue”: the coachee is going to feel like “I am just filling out a lot of forms” or (even if they rarely articulate it this way), “the process is more important to my coach than I am.”

This Guide will teach you the “ITC melody,” and you must know the melody to make ITC music. But ITC coaching is more like improvisational jazz; it is much more than the melody. If you only play the melody you are unlikely to create for people the kind of experiences the person at the beginning of this introduction was referring to. Let’s take a look again at her second paragraph:

[My CCP coach] was a model – listening deeply, probing gently, accepting me where I was but wanting more for me at the same time. It felt both humbling and empowering to have someone in my camp, really seeing and empathizing with the conflict in me but not letting me swallow my own stories without asking some really hard questions first. In part it was her, in part it was the process, and in part it was me taking the time to really tease something apart without shrinking from hard realities that helped me to move forward.

This reflects masterful ITC coaching, but look how little in this account is directly related to the ITC hat: those “really hard questions” and “the process” come from ITC, to be sure, but they are delivered in the context of a relationship that is absolutely indispensable to the experience. We assume accomplished coaches know a great deal about building and sustaining such relationships with their clients, and while this is not the focus of this Guide, no one should take away the message that we intend for you to do this any less than you are accustomed to. We are not suggesting you *trade* these skills for the new ones you learn in this guide; we invite you to *add* one to the other.

Now let’s look at her last paragraph:

I find that ITC allows the coach and client to follow a very specific thread linked to a very specific goal, allowing visible progress to be made on an issue of real importance to the client in a relatively short period of time. That focus doesn’t prevent the client from getting value across a broader set of goals because the key Big Assumptions often underlie a range of issues. Personally, I need to hone my ability to keep the client on target because I tend to be expansive and to not want to confine myself to an overly-narrow focus. It is a skill to find what is simple in what is complex.

This is what the Guide *is* trying to teach you. It is all about skillfully wearing the ITC hat. But here too it is important not to lose the forest for the trees. We have been saying that one kind of forest which we don’t want to lose — one kind of “whole” — is the client’s “personal narrative” and our human connection to it, our recognition of it. But this is not the only “whole” we are in danger of losing if we think of the work as a series of exercises (however various the sequence of exercises may be). There is also a

There is also a kind of “cognitive whole” that we don’t want to lose — how each exercise helps us with the single coherent enterprise of helping our clients to unearth and modify core principles of self-protection which they may no longer need.

kind of “cognitive whole” that we don’t want to lose — how each exercise helps us with the *single coherent enterprise* of helping our clients to unearth and modify core principles of self-protection which they may no longer need. In teaching you each ITC exercise on its own, the Guide could inadvertently take your attention away from this whole in which each exercise should be anchored. You can “do” an exercise perfectly, but without keeping this connection to the whole the “lesson” can get lost. You can do an exercise with your coachee quite imperfectly, but so long as you have this whole in mind, it can still deliver a lot of value.

Now read the new ITC coach’s last paragraph one last time:

I find that ITC allows the coach and client to follow a very specific thread linked to a very specific goal, allowing visible progress to be made on an issue of real importance to the client in a relatively short period of time. That focus doesn’t prevent the client from getting value across a broader set of goals because the key Big Assumptions often underlie a range of issues. Personally, I need to hone my ability to keep the client on target because I tend to be expansive and to not want to confine myself to an overly-narrow focus. It is a skill to find what is simple in what is complex.

Notice that she is talking here, not just about **how** this kind of coaching is effective, but **why** it is. She is aware there are a variety of moves or exercises, but she subordinates these to “a very specific thread,” a single “focus,” a sense of what is or is not “on target.” It is clear her picture of mastery is not merely the ability to do a “bunch o’ things” but to do a single thing, over time, which the exercises enable. The exercises are merely the means; they are not themselves the “target.”

Staying focused on this ITC **whole** means asking yourself throughout the coaching journey, “Is my client having the chance to alter certain core beliefs, principles, or assumptions – and is her behavior changing in desired directions as a result?” Staying focused on this “ITC whole” does **not** mean “having to do the whole thing,” i.e., having to do all the exercises or steps you will learn about in this Guide. You do not need to do each of these exercises to be true to the ITC melody.

The metaphor of improvisation means that you have a lot of latitude as to which exercises to use, when to use them, in what order, and in what fashion.

The metaphor of **improvisation** means that you have a lot of latitude as to which exercises to use, when to use them, in what order, and in what fashion. Some version of a map *is* indispensable; it helps people see how they simultaneously have “one foot on the gas and one foot on the brakes,” and it surfaces the Big

Assumptions which will be the focus of experiments. Some version of experimenting, or “running tests,” and looking at the implications of the results for the Big Assumption, is also indispensable; this is the means by which we change mindsets and not just behavior.

But beyond these two you have a lot of leeway. And even the fashion in which you will deliver these two can be quite various. The *reasons* you will make the choices you do will come from many sources: your personal style, your coachee's personal preferences, constraints of the particular context in which a given coaching journey will go on.

One big source of how you will decide to “play the music” will have to do with the way you, and especially your client, feel about *writing things down*. This is another important, orienting point worth lingering on for a moment here, before you jump into this Guide.

When you start to look through the chapters of this Guide you are likely to come away with the impression that ITC coaching involves a lot of writing and “memo exchanging.” The Map is written down, and often literally revised and rewritten. The Continuum of Progress is a written document. Many versions of the Biography exercise involve a written account. There is a written form for checking whether you have designed a good test, and another for structuring your consideration of the results of that test. And it doesn't stop there. “My goodness,” you or your client might say, “I thought coaching was about a series of more-or-less spontaneous, rich, impactful conversations. This looks very concrete [or “cut and dried” or “too much like school, with lots of papers and due dates”].”

There is a fast answer to this concern: You *could* deliver a powerful ITC coaching cycle without your client ever writing down a single word. Have any of the authors of this Guide ever done so? Yes, but, to be honest, in such cases the coach wrote (at least a few indispensable) things down, and the coachee had them for reference, and made use of them in many of the coaching conversations. If both you and your client are absolutely allergic to ever writing *anything* down, ITC coaching may not be your cup of tea. But the most important thing to say here is that (although you may not always get this impression from reading the Guide) we do recognize that many clients are highly action-oriented and not prone to reflecting in writing. We have also learned that this does not necessarily mean that such people are not prone to, capable of, or even highly interested in, reflection. We have had many classic, type-A, go-go, multi-tasking clients (not all of them men, not all of them from the business sector), who have had extremely powerful and productive ITC experiences. They didn't, on their own, do much writing, but they did engage in some version of many of the exercises in this Guide.

So, know that the spirit of improvisation includes the room for you to be creative about how you handle the “writing” aspect of this work. We have also had many clients who frankly told us they didn't much like this aspect of the work at first, but they were surprised and impressed by how valuable it turned out to be. So we wouldn't suggest you too quickly take over these functions, or truncate them, but we do understand that different clients are different, and we have the evidence that a wide variety of clients can be well-served by this approach.

To improvise well, however, requires practicing and knowing the core elements deeply. If you are reading/

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using this Guide in conjunction with your participation in the Coach Certification Program, we *do* want you to practice each of the exercises and demonstrate you can deliver them. Serving people well—to return to our opening words—is an extraordinarily rewarding experience. We hope this Guide helps you to integrate this approach into your coaching repertoire so that you may share in this experience, and those you help may become more of whom they were meant to be.

How this Guide is Organized

The Nine Chapters

We have structured this Guide (and the *Participant Workbook*) in the sequence depicted in the ITC Coaching Journey visual (page 2.) The first several chapters delve into the “Opening Moves,” all of which set the stage for clients to clarify their goal, its importance to themselves and others, as well as the Big Assumption(s) that currently are limiting their ability to achieve that goal. The second phase, the “Middle Game,” includes all the exercises that enable a client to develop and then apply the muscles necessary to test the accuracy of her Big Assumption(s.) The last phase, the “End Game,” consists of exercises designed to help a client consolidate all that he has learned so that he knows how to augment and sustain this progress.

We list these exercises below along with a simple statement of the purpose of each.

Opening Moves: Setting the Stage

Honing a Map: Your client revises his immunity map as needed, so that it feels powerful to him and he has a testable Big Assumption(s.)

Initial Survey: Your client receives external input on the importance and value of her column 1 goal, and creates a baseline of how well she is doing on the goal at the start of the coaching process.

Middle Game: Digging into the Work

Continuum of Progress: Your client envisions what full success looks like in achieving his column 1 goal as he imagines no longer being captive of his Big Assumption(s). This begins the process of paying attention to thoughts, feelings, behaviors and their interconnection, and can increase client motivation to change.

Self-observations: Your client tunes in to her Big Assumptions in action and stays alert to counterexamples. She recognizes when and where her Big Assumptions are activated, and when they are inaccurate. In doing so, she builds the muscles necessary to look at her Big Assumptions, rather than *through* them. She learns about her Big Assumptions and her accompanying experience of being captive and not captive of them.

Biography of the Big Assumption: Your client asks about his Big Assumption(s), when did it get started? What is its history? What is its current validity? By looking back with his current capabilities as an adult on the origin of his Big Assumption, your client's reflections can lead him to develop a more objective relationship to his Big Assumption.

Testing the Big Assumption: Your client intentionally behaves counter to how his Big Assumption would have him act, sees what happens, and then reflects on what those results tell him about the certainty of his assumption. He does this process several times, running tests of bigger scope each time. This exercise is at the heart of the ITC coaching process and serves as the biggest lever to overturn an immune system.

End Game: Consolidating Your Learning

Running and Interpreting Tests of the Big Assumption: Your client gets input (from the same people who completed his initial survey) on his column 1 goal. He compares his self-assessment of progress with what they see and he learns about the effect of his changes on others.

Identifying Hooks and Releases: Your client takes stock of the current status of her Big Assumption(s); considers how to maintain progress, how to guard against future slippage (the “hooks”), and how to recover when she does (the “releases”).

Future Progress: Once your client is “unconsciously released” from his current Big Assumption(s), he may want to reengage the immunities process, especially around any unmet goals or areas in which he currently feels stuck or discouraged.

When you look at the ITC Coaching Journey visual, you'll notice that in addition to the exercises, there are many arrows; some arrows point in one direction, others are bi-directional, one is dotted, and one has two arrows which together form a type of circle. It's a very busy picture indeed! By the time you have completed your reading of the Guide and put its contents into practice with your first coachee, we hope you will better understand the meaning of these various arrows. For now, we want them to signal that while the ITC coaching process has a logical sequence, just as no two clients or immune systems are alike, there is no one way (nor one “standard sequence”) to overturn an immune system. Not everyone needs to do every one of the ITC exercises (notice the dotted lined arrow from “Map” to “Testing” to “Hooks and Releases” in the ITC Coaching Journey graphic) or in the order provided to be successful (this is what the bi-directional arrows are meant to convey.)

In the last chapter, “Putting the Pieces Together,” we show how a coach thinks about and guides her clients' work when bringing to life the non-linear spirit and nature of how an immune system gets overturned. The chapter helps coaches to keep an overall picture in mind, by illustrating how a client may actually be moving “forward” and “backward” during the overturning process.

The Structure of the Chapters

All of the chapters are structured in a similar way, as follows:

Context for this Exercise: Where does the exercise fit in the ITC coaching journey?

At a Glance: A thumbnail description of the exercise, along with its purpose and benefits.

General Points: Key ideas to have in mind as you engage your client in the particular exercise.

Brief Example: What does a completed exercise look like?

Engaging your Client in the Exercise: Emphasizes the importance of you explaining to your client the context and purpose for the particular exercise.

Tips: A description of common ways clients don't engage in an exercise as intended and concrete suggestions for how to help them do so.

Tips and Pitfalls: A thumbnail description of tips for improving a client's experience with the exercise, along with common pitfalls for coaches and coachees.

In-depth Examples: There are two cases that appear in every chapter (Jackson and Amanda) so that you can follow what happens with clients over the course of the ITC process.

Practice Time: Examples of the exercise for you to try out what you've learned from the chapter. At the end of this section, we provide our responses to the examples. In addition, there are opportunities throughout each chapter to reflect and write responses to questions we pose along the way.

Almost all of the chapters have materials that you can use with your client. These are found at the end of each chapter in the Appendix section.

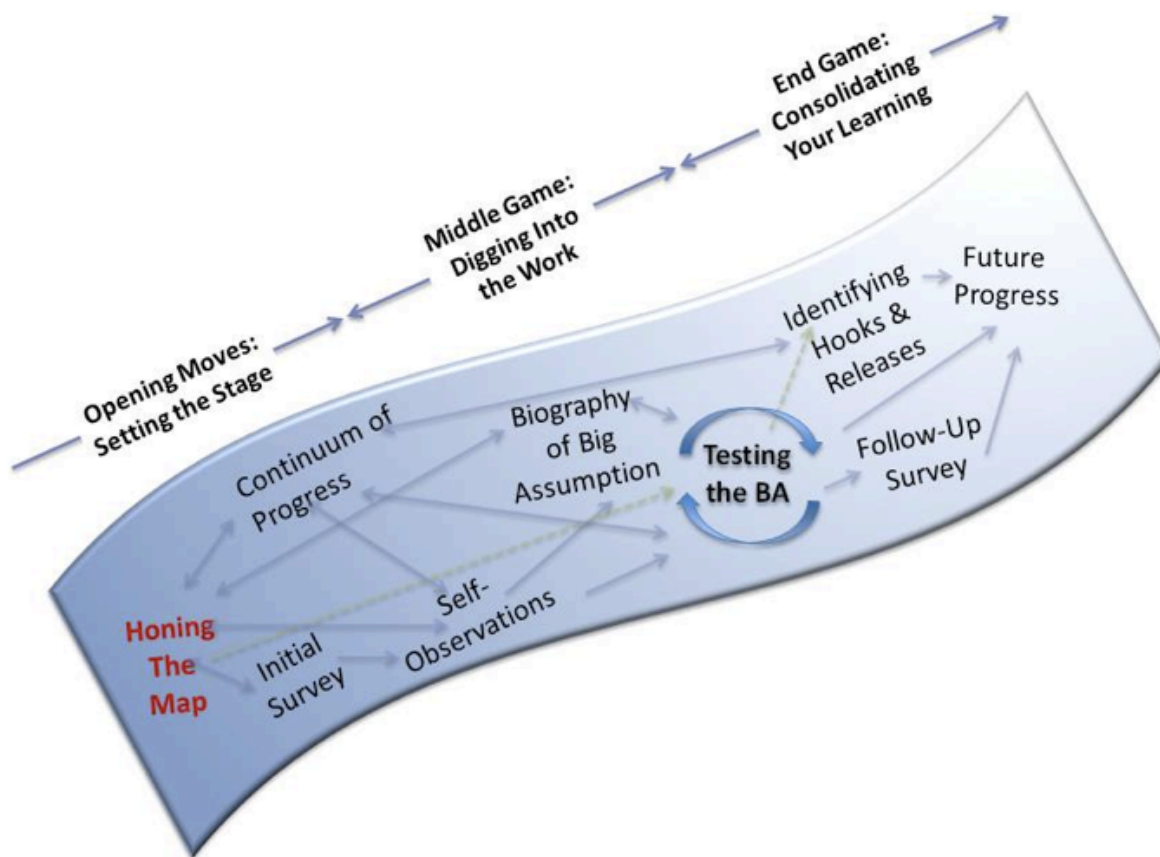
We view the Guide, like ITC coaching itself, as an evolving form, enhanced through the sharing of our collective experience. We welcome your participation in this growing community of practice. Do let us know your thoughts about how this “operator's manual,” and all of our materials, might be improved. You can reach us through: www.mindsatwork.com or directly at office@mindsatwork.com.

Chapter I

Honing the Immunity Map

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Context for this Exercise

The starting point to overcoming an immunity to change is having a 4-Column map that intrigues your client. Whether she suddenly understands why she has been unable to make progress (or maintain it) on an important goal, or she is reminded of an insight from long ago and now sees how it is actually show-

ing up and restricting her current life, the person should feel motivated to move forward and work on overcoming their immunity. [Please note, any gender-specific pronoun henceforth should not be taken as such and is meant to indicate both male and female genders.]

As a way of moving forward, you may need to help your client sharpen his first draft of a map so that he has a sufficiently “juicy” map. You know he has crossed this threshold when the whole map feels compelling to him: he understands the apparent contradiction across the first three columns (the “immune system”), and he has at least one Big Assumption that sustains it. Sometimes, a client produces this level of clarity in a first draft. More typically, a map needs further work to cross the threshold. Note that “honing a map” is the first opening move to set the stage for the immunity-to-change journey. This chapter focuses on what you, as coach, need to know and be able to do to help your client develop a powerful map.

Overview

The intent of honing a 4-Column map is for your client to develop as sharp and deep (insightful) a picture of her immune system and accompanying Big Assumption(s) as possible in a second draft. If she has already decided that she wants to accomplish her important goal by overcoming her immunity, the key is now to make sure that she has a map that feels personally meaningful, coheres well conceptually (i.e., it meets all of the criteria in each column and as such, shows a system at work along with Big Assumptions that anchor it), and continues to feel powerful to her. She should also have a testable Big Assumption. Sometimes a powerful and tight system is created in the first draft, in which case it is not necessary to hone the map. More often, a client needs to tighten the map so that potential “leaks” (which can diminish energy and motivation, as well as focus) are closed.

This second draft need not be the “end-all, be-all.” There are plenty of opportunities for your client to add to her map, and to hone her Big Assumptions so that they are fully testable, as she engages the future exercises, all of which allow you to dig deeper into every one of the columns.

Purpose and Benefits

- ✓ To ensure that each column entry in the map meets the appropriate criteria.
- ✓ To ensure that the map, as a whole, coheres (i.e., you and your client can see the immune system, with one foot on the gas pedal and the other foot on the brake, and can see the assumption set that is keeping that system intact).
- ✓ To ensure that both coach and client have a shared understanding of what the client’s personal immunity-to-change curriculum is.
- ✓ To have a solid idea of the one or two Big Assumptions that are most influential in keeping the immune system going.
- ✓ To develop a reasonably *testable* Big Assumption.
- ✓ To maintain (even increase) your client’s motivation to overcome her immunity.

Five General Points about Honing a 4-Column Map

1. Not all maps need to be honed. How likely is it that your client's map will need honing? It depends. Were you the person who facilitated the initial map? Did you do it one-on-one, or were you working with a group, where you don't get to see each map as it develops? If one-on-one and you could catch when your client wasn't answering each column appropriately in the first draft, then the likelihood is high that you were able to help him there in the moment.

That said, he also needs to do his share. If he was open to the exercise, was willing to look at himself in the mirror, and can access what he thinks and feels, then he is apt to develop a solid map the first time. Having a solid map also depends on whether you had enough time to do the map; in general, it takes between 60-90 minutes to do the map exercise in the one-to-one format. Sometimes, however, having the time in one sitting isn't going to make the difference. Expect that there will be occasions when someone needs "to sleep on" what he's surfacing in the first draft.

2. A well-honed map meets all the 4-Column criteria and intrigues your client. When you are deciding whether your client's map needs honing, ask yourself the following questions:

- Do you see how the entries in each column meet the column criteria?
- Do you understand each response, starting with the goal?
- Do you see how each column entry is connected to the next, and how the first three columns collectively show an immune system?
- Do you see the tension, the conflicting relationship, between the 1st and 3rd columns? Are the key Column 2 behaviors accounted for in Column 3?
- Do the fears stay present in the Column 3 commitments?
- What about the Big Assumptions: do they follow from key Column 3 commitments?
- Can you work backwards from the Big Assumption to see, first, how it sustains the immune system? More specifically, can you follow the pathway from Column 4 all the way to Column 1 (e.g., how if your client assumed X, he would protect himself as noted in Column 3, and how if he protected himself that way, he would behave as he named in Column 2 and how Column 2 works against Column 1)?
- Is there at least one Big Assumption written in the "if, then" format (more on this later)? Are there testable assumptions, or do they all have such dire outcomes that there would be no safe way to test them in their current form?

Assume you can answer all of the above questions affirmatively. Then you need to know that

your client “gets it” too. Most important is that the map continues to feel important to him. Sometimes a client is quite clear that his map is powerful, but the reality is that you don’t see that the map coheres. This is an important point, since we want the power to come from your client seeing the immune system at work, and that it is not, more simply, just surfacing unrelated insights. The whole point of the 4-Column map is to see the relationship of the various Columns to each other, including the reality of being stuck relative to accomplishing an important goal, and the power of Big Assumptions relative to that immune system.

3. Plan to spend no more than one session honing. Think first about what most needs to be sharpened in your client’s map. If your client did not develop his map in a one-to-one session with you (e.g., you ran a small ITC seminar and are now meeting individually with each participant), take it as a given that you won’t know what he meant by many of his entries. In that case, clarifying questions may be what’s most needed, and the ensuing conversation may reveal that his entries all make a lot of sense and his map becomes more coherent to you. Or, you may find that just one aspect of the map needs further honing (e.g., if none of the Big Assumptions are in testable form). If, however, you see that there is a shortcoming in Columns 1, 2 or 3, you will need to take time to see the implications of that for the later columns.

If you need one more session to complete honing a map, that’s fine. That happens. But even then, be aware of the risks of spending too much time on honing a map:

- The client may be using “talk” as a defensive device to avoid doing the uncomfortable work ahead.
- The client is unaware of, or loses track of, what you and he are really up to and mistakes the work as more about “thinking” about his immunity than working to overcome it.
- Your client becomes antsy to get going, feels he is being held back, and begins to lose motivation.
- You will reach the end of your contracted number of sessions (typically 8-10) and realize that you have focused too much on diagnosing the immunity and not enough on overturning it.

You may also need to spend more than one session honing if you have to start again and develop a whole map from scratch.

4. Maps typically evolve throughout the coaching engagement. Remember that once your client gets going with the other exercises, he will likely continue to hone his map based on his ongoing learning. If your client’s map is basically sound, it is probably a good idea to move on to the next exercises, remaining vigilant to any insights that emerge in the process and have implications for the map.

5. Honing a map marks the end of “diagnosing” one’s immunity to change and sets the stage for the “overturning” work to come. That doesn’t mean that we are leaving the map behind and turning with fresh eyes to the next step. If we have stayed true to the map-making and map-honing process, we have developed some very useful and powerful information, and this information should anchor us in each of the exercises to follow. In our minds, if you cannot link each of the “overturning” steps directly back to your client’s map, you have gone off-track. We work so hard to overturn *not just anything* but the Big Assumptions that prevent us from reaching our prized first column goals. As such, it is good practice in ITC coaching to revisit your client’s map at the start and/or end of *each* session, to remind you both of the immune system you are targeting.

Brief Examples of Honing a Map

Getting a Testable Assumption

Our first example is one where the honing focused on clarifying the person’s Big Assumption, since it was not testable in its original form. This was the only focus, as the rest of the map was well constructed and still meaningful.

Sue’s original Big Assumption was this: *“If I am not accepted, then people wouldn’t like me and I wouldn’t have value.”* As is, this is not a testable assumption. Why? Because in order to test it, Sue would need to design a test that first fulfilled her ‘if’ conditions (‘If I am not accepted’). Such a test would require her to not be accepted, which clearly is not safe.

Yet her Big Assumption has assumptions embedded within it (as almost all Big Assumptions do). The easiest way to identify those is to look for assumptions within the “if” part of the Big Assumption. Here, that means asking Sue what she imagines could lead to her not being accepted. She easily answered that question: “If I say ‘no,’ then others will see me as cold and uncaring.” “People see me as caring and supportive only when I let them vent and join them in their conflict.” “The only way for people to accept me is for me to care for and support them.” “I assume I couldn’t feel secure in my relationship during conflict.” “The relationship will not remain if I disagree.” Any one of these is eminently testable. The “then” part of her original Big Assumption has not been eliminated, it’s just that there is now a prior “if... then” that Sue needs first to explore.

Making a Map More Powerful

In this second example, the mapmaker rated his map a 3.5 on a 1-5 point interest scale, which means he found it a little more interesting than “OK”. Take a moment to read it and as you do, consider why this person doesn’t experience his map as powerful.

1. Commitment/ Improvement Goal	2. Doing/NotDoing	3. Hidden Counter- Commitment	4. Big Assumptions
I am committed to managing my time/my priorities more actively in order to be more effective as a leader, set clear priorities, delegate more, stop procrastinating, get a better balance in my life. This goal is extremely important (4.5) to me.	I make plans but don’t stick to them – something else always “comes up”. Procrastinate. Don’t set limits for myself. Don’t delegate enough. Don’t say no. Will work on things I have the most energy or enthusiasm for at the moment rather than on the most urgent things.	I am committed to doing my job very well. I am committed to not complaining, to giving to others.	If I do not do my job well, I will not be respected in my role. If I don’t give to others, I show I am not committed to them.

If you haven’t thought about the column criteria as you read his map, do so now and assess where you suspect his entries may be off track. (If you want to check your recall of the criteria for all 4 columns, see Appendix A.) Jot down your thoughts in the space below.

Assess the quality of this person’s map using the 4-Column criteria:

In honing his map, we focused on the last three columns and when we were done, he rated it “a 4 or a 5.” In discussing Column 2, we noticed that the first bullet has an external focus (“something always comes up”). This is a “reason” for a behavior. The Column 2 criteria say we aren’t going into reasons; however, *reactions* can be behaviors. In this case, we

can (and did) ask him what he does/how he *reacts* when things come up. The third bullet needed clarification: what kind of limits are we talking about here? We also offered the observation that perhaps he is not prioritizing and asked whether that resonated with him as true. Moving on to Column 3, we suggested that he add a fear box. The fear box can be the most effective way for some clients to get to their hidden commitments, so we suggest that each client starts their 3rd column by creating one. It's no surprise his map wasn't currently that interesting to him given his 3rd column entries. They aren't "self-protective"; they don't name a danger he is committed to protecting himself from. We also saw that the first commitment listed in the third column seemed too "noble" and explored it further with the client. The second commitment, while ripe with potential, seemed to be two separate ideas that need to be explored further. Next, we uncovered additional Column 3 commitments from the fears in the fear box. Once we honed the 2nd and 3rd columns, the client felt the 4th column went from adequate to enlightening. Let's see what happened.

1. Commitment/ Improvement Goal	2. Doing/NotDoing	3. Hidden Counter- Commitment	4. Big Assumptions
I am committed to managing my time/my priorities more actively in order to be more effective as a leader, to stick to clear priorities, delegate more, get a better balance in my life.	I make plans but don't stick to them. I get distracted when something else always "comes up." Procrastinate. Will often be a little late on deadlines. Don't adhere to the time limits for myself. Don't delegate enough. Don't say no – I agree to things when asked. Even when I realize I'm too busy I don't go back and refuse. I don't prioritize.	Fears: I'll be seen negatively – as being uncommitted, imperfect, a complainer, asking for too much. I am committed to: Being perfect. Not complaining. Giving to others, even at my expense. Being seen as committed (to others' needs, to the organization's needs). Not asking for too much, overestimating my needs/value, to not being seen as arrogant or haughty. Underestimating myself, being modest, asking for less than what others do, not making demands, not expecting rewards.	If I am not perfect and strong... I will not be respected in my role. If I am not perfect, then I must work extra hours to feel better. If I were very efficient (e.g., keeping work limited from 9-5), I wouldn't be very committed. If I value myself higher than the others, I will be seen as not being committed. If I ask for too much, overestimate myself, appear arrogant or haughty and fail, then I will be at fault and the failure is deserved. And everyone will laugh. If I don't ask for too much, I can't be blamed if the results aren't great. I won't be disappointed or disappoint others.

Engaging your Client in this Exercise

Help your client understand the context for the assignment.

This move is a natural follow-up to a first draft of a 4-Column map. You can cast this as an opportunity to refresh yourselves on your client's draftmap, or as a chance to see if anything new has emerged since he drafted it. Or you can be explicit that you want to check how powerful the map feels for him. This is a good time to explain to your client that motivation is a key driver for change and that his energy for the work ahead will be more accessible the more he understands, at this point, how his immune system is holding him back from accomplishing his goal. Feel free to refer to the "Immunity-to-Change Journey" chart to show your client where you are in the process (see Appendix B).

Hear where your client is. Before turning to the particulars of the map, it's useful to get a general pulse on how meaningful the map is for the person. Hearing these "gut" reactions, first off, may provide you with a quick read on how energized your client is by her map (and whether you will need to hone it), as well as potential issues to address should you need to hone the map. Participants' reactions can range from having a big "ah ha," feeling liberated or unstuck to feeling very unsettled, angry or agitated. If she hasn't found a compelling assumption, she may feel puzzled or confused and unsure of what the whole point is.

You can ask a question like, "When you step back from what you've created there, how significant or important is what you've uncovered? Let's use a 5-point scale, like what you used when you created this, where 1 means 'not significant at all' and 5 means 'extremely significant'." Another option is to ask an open-ended question, like, "How did that go for you?" or "What stands out to you about your map?" If you ask these types of questions, it will still be important for you to get a read on how intrigued your client is with whatever stands out for her. Momentum in overturning an immune system is fueled by the mapmakers' motivation, so you need a clear reading of how energized your client is by what she sees in her map.

If your client feels excited, and you see how the map meets all the criteria, you can invite her to talk you through how she makes sense of the whole thing (especially what her immune system is, and how her Big Assumption sustains it). The more your client "gets" the concept, the easier it will be to partner with her in the coaching journey.

If, by contrast, your client tells you that the map isn't quite there yet (e.g., a "3" or less on our 5-point scale), then your next steps are about discerning where things are off for her. Before we discuss possible ways to strengthen a map, we want to take a moment for you to think this through yourself:

1. Conceptually, where can a map go off track?

2. In practice, what might you actually say to your client to learn what's off and/or to address what's off?

Tips for Improving a Map

Column 1

What to do if you or your client thinks Column 1 isn't quite right:

Check to see whether your client's goal meets the Column 1 criteria. Does his goal focus on what *he* needs to improve on? For some people, it takes time to get the first column right, especially one that implicates them in the goal. "Leakage" happens if that goal focuses more on others' change than on one's own.

Is his goal still important to him? (A goal that is important will likely also cover the other criteria, "true about me" and "needs improvement".) His goal may have felt important or very important when he started his map, but sometimes the importance fades over time or after one has seen a hidden commitment. It can be useful to ask, "What are two or three reasons why this is important?" and to have your client enter these under the goal in Column 1.

If the goal meets all the criteria but still doesn't feel right to your client, consider the following:

- *The framing of the goal:* sometimes a goal stated affirmatively or negatively can be more satisfying when flipped (e.g., "to live a healthy lifestyle" might feel more meaningful stated as "stop overeating and overdrinking," or "stop avoiding conflict" can feel more important stated as "get better at having difficult conversations").
- *The level of specificity of the goal:* this can work in either direction, where the goal works better when it is more specific (e.g., "be more active and get at least 7 hours of sleep" can feel more powerful than "to live a healthy lifestyle") or more general. A goal that is too wordy or roundabout may be clear enough to feel important.

Please note: If a goal doesn't feel really worthwhile to your client, ask him whether he wants to start a new map. One obvious source of material for generating a goal is if he has done a 360-degree feedback assessment or received feedback or an evaluation from a supervisor. Alternatively, you can see whether there is a goal he has been pursuing unsuccessfully that continues to be important (perhaps he outright failed, or made minimal progress or backslid).

What about this? Your client has already told you that he has a great goal, but that the reason his map isn't powerful is because of the 3rd column. He explains, "That was no surprise in the 3rd column; I already knew that about myself!" How might you respond to that?

Stating the reason his map wasn't powerful, the person says "*I already knew that about myself.*" What might you say? (After you've answered this yourself below, you can read our answer in the next section.)

The Immune System

If your client's original goal is in great shape, then turn to the relationship between Column 1 and 3, and see whether a clear "immune system" appears to your client (and you). Does she see her foot on the gas and on the brake at the same time? Does she see a clear pathway as to how the third column creates the behaviors of the second, and the second prevents progress on the first? If so, does this feel powerful? (These questions can also help the client mentioned on the previous page who wasn't surprised by his 3rd column commitment, since his map is likely to not feel powerful because he hasn't yet connected the dots of the immune system. His Column 3 material may be old news, but the surprise is in seeing how that self-protective commitment is currently impacting his life, i.e., it is limiting his ability to accomplish an important goal).

If she does not have a powerful picture of this system, then focus on Column 3 to see if she can get to a more essential form of self-protection. Return to the second column behaviors and ask, "What are the worst things that could happen to you if you were to do the opposite of these?" or "How would doing the opposite damage the way you **most** like to see yourself or be seen?" or "How would doing the opposite cause you to see yourself or be seen the way you would **least** like?" You'll be helped here if you first ask your client which of the Column 2 behaviors (or lack of behavior) she believes is the most significant counter to her Column 1 goal. Use that one as your starting place for generating material for the fear box. This is especially important if your client has generated a long list of "doing and not doing" (which can sometimes obfuscate the essential counter-productive in/actions).

Additional consideration for developing a more powerful immunity map:

Did the "danger" to the self get lost or weaker when moving from the "fear box" to the 3rd column commitment? This happens either when the mapmaker misunderstands how the word "commitment" is being used (and so she generates a noble commitment) or because the words she chooses don't capture the worry or need to self-protect (e.g., "I worry I'll be seen as inadequate for the job" becomes "I am committed to being competent" or even "...to being seen as competent." Keeping the fear "baked in" to the commitment will make for a more powerful version: "I am committed to not being seen as incompetent, or not up to the task" or, "I am committed to not having people develop second thoughts about me" or, "I am committed to not having people re-evaluate their high opinion of my capabilities").

Would different wording for the 3rd column commitment make it more powerful? See whether the commitment would feel more powerful if re-stated in its opposite (e.g., it feels more compelling to a client when she flips the commitment "to always being right" to "never being wrong"). See whether it works better to state the commitment in a more extreme form (e.g., "always being right" becomes "being superior"). One way to initiate this is by saying something along the lines of, "You're saying that this speaks to you but is not really powerful; sometimes consid-

ering it from a different angle can get at the root of it... (provide reworded example)
...does that resonate with you?"

If your client is at a loss for identifying a compelling commitment even though she identified powerful fears, invite her to consider whether she might worry if she:

- Felt or appeared like someone in her life; or
- Let down a historically important person; or
- Brought dishonor to her family or people.

People sometimes spontaneously get to this place when you ask them progressive "What would be the worst about that?" or "Why?" questions (as mentioned above). Other times, you can probe for whether there is some loyalty or avoidance at stake. A recent example of this occurred when a client said she was committed to not hurting others, and she felt that while that was the case, there was something else going on there. Asked, "Might this be reminding you of someone?" she immediately put her finger on not wanting to be like her father (who hurt her and other people she loved). We have found that the fear of disappointing or even disgracing ones family or "people" is often a central counter-commitment for non-Western clients.

If none of this works to improve Column 3, then return to Column 2 and see whether there are any additional behaviors, including self-talk, that your client has not yet mentioned. Occasionally, someone can overlook the most obvious Column 2 behaviors. The opposites of these new behaviors can then generate new fears.

Big Assumptions Checkpoint I: Having a Meaningful Big Assumption

Let's assume here that your client has a powerful picture of his immune system (either because of honing it, or because his original map was strong up to this point). If you and your client have honed his map, you'll need to explore which, if any, of his Big Assumptions from the first draft still apply. If needed, remind him how to identify Big Assumptions.

The Big Assumption column might, alternatively, be the place where the map fizzled out for him. Expect that at some point, some client will say to you something like, "Column 3 was a big surprise and that's all good, but the Big Assumption feels like a letdown." Take a moment to think about how you would respond to that comment and use the space below to capture your work.

How would you respond to the comment, “*My Big Assumption feels like a letdown*”?

Our first impulse is to ask an open-ended question or make a request for more information. Until we know what the person means by his comment, there is no “immunity to change” informed response to make. Over time, we have discovered that people tend to mean one of three things by this comment:

- It’s a let down because the Big Assumption *is* true;
- It’s a let down because they know it’s *not* true; or
- It’s a let down because, “So what? It isn’t very interesting or earth-shattering.”

Each of these meanings warrants a different response beyond conveying that we hear the affective dimension of their comments.

What might you say in response to these different meanings?

... it **is** true

... I know it's **not** true

... this isn't very interesting

When a client says

“My Big Assumption is true, or I know it's not true.”

In these instances, the focus is on how correct or incorrect the Big Assumption is. While that is surely the direction the follow-up work entails, at this point in the process, such a focus isn't the point. The point is—no matter how accurate our Big Assumptions are in reality, we are operating *as if* they are true when we have no current data to inform our certainty either way. It could well be that our assumptions are 100% true or never true; in both cases, we are subject to the tacit belief that our assumptions are true whether we believe we are or not.

For a client to insist that his Big Assumption is true can reflect how mighty a hold the Big Assumption can have on that person (i.e., “I don't just *assume* my boss will hate me if I disagree with her openly, I *know* she will!”). It may also reflect how unsafe it feels to imagine otherwise – a point we will get to in the next section when we discuss testable assumptions. Any ITC coach can respond to these type of “it is true” statements by highlighting the self-sealing nature of our Big Assumptions and how that biases what we see and how we interpret it. See Appendix C for a comical cartoon that can exemplify this notion. Feel free to keep it in your repertoire if you are looking for a way to explain the idea of subjectivity to Big Assumptions (i.e., being had by them rather than having them) to your clients.

The client who insists that his Big Assumption *isn't* true is making an intellectual, logical comment or observation (i.e., “I assume that if I disagree openly with my boss, she will hate me. In reality, I know that she won't hate me.”). An ITC coach can point out that because

this Big Assumption emerged through the process of developing the map, this suggests that the client has been *acting as if it were true* (otherwise, his Column 2 in/actions would not be listed as they are). In other words, it can be useful to suggest your client is saying, “Even though I **know**, intellectually, that this is not necessarily true, I still act somehow as if it is.” If he agrees, it is a chance to emphasize that this is the nature of Big Assumptions. They can have power over us even if they do not hold up to “rational analysis.”

When a client says

“My Big Assumption isn’t very interesting.”

When someone doesn’t find his Big Assumption interesting, that’s a different matter. That might be a consequence of his having had a big “ah ha” in the 3rd column and his Big Assumption, by contrast, seems, well, like no big deal. That reaction also may be fueled by the fact that we, as facilitators, go to lengths to say that the Big Assumption is the lever for change, and that may create expectations that whatever the person discovers in Column 4 will be momentous.

There are different ways to respond to this:

- Simply acknowledge his experience and see whether there are other Big Assumptions he has named that *are* interesting to him. It is usually in a client’s best interests to have more than one Big Assumption to choose from when he sets out on the path of overcoming his immune system. In the best cases, he can choose the one assumption that he believes is most getting in his way – in other words, the one assumption, that if altered, would free up his need to protect himself as he does.
- Another response follows from the fact that a person’s Big Assumption doesn’t need to be cataclysmic in order for him to make progress overcoming his immune system. The Big Assumption should be a belief, however, which gives rise to the need in Column 3 to protect himself as he does, and he must see that connection. Can your client trace the line from the Big Assumption to his competing commitment? If he can work backwards from the Big Assumption to see, first, how it sustains the immune system, and then follow the pathway from Column 4 all the way to Column 1, (e.g., how if he assumed X, he would protect himself as noted in Column 3, and how that self-protection leads to his Column 2 behaviors and how Column 2 works against Column 1), he may become more interested in his assumption. In other words, if your client wants to make progress on his Column 1 goal, he will need to deal with his Big Assumption.
- Sometimes people can better appreciate their Big Assumptions, including the power of them, as they get to better know them through their self-observations. It can be helpful to ask your client to walk through how he sees his Big Assumption as limiting his ability to achieve his Column 1 goal. For example, you may say something like, “Do you see yourself with your feet simultaneously on the gas and the brake? Take me through how you make sense of that.”

All of this said, we are not aiming to convince anyone to think or feel anything. Be ready to help your client identify new Big Assumptions. Use your knowledge of how to move from Column 3 to Column 4 here, and start with asking him to focus on his juiciest or most meaningful Column 3 commitments.

Big Assumptions Checkpoint 2: Having a Testable Big Assumption

A map is a strong foundation for overcoming an immunity to change when the entry or entries in the fourth column represent *testable* Big Assumptions. Our Big Assumptions can feel spot on, even hit us in the stomach and feel “Big Time Bad,” but that does not always make them testable. There is no way to safely test, for example, the assumption that “If I were to fail, I would lose all my self-respect.” We are not going to suggest someone go out and fail, and then see if she loses all self-respect. There is no way to logically test, “If I have to conclude I am not smart enough for this job, I will just die.” (What should the client do? Conclude the worst, and then see if he dies?)

In order to know whether your client has a testable assumption, it will help to know that the “tests” she will run—whether now or later—will be careful, open-minded and safe inquiries into whether the “if-then” sequence of his Big Assumption is really warranted. A good test inquires into whether the “if” condition we are working so hard at avoiding (“if no one accepts my suggestion...”) really results in the unbearably awful “then” consequence for ourselves that we imagine (“... then I will feel humiliated and lose face on the team.”).

Testing Now or Later?

We say “tests he will run—whether **now or later**” because in some cases, you will want to move directly from honing a map to testing a Big Assumption. As is the case throughout immunity-to-change coaching, you have choices as to which exercises you offer your client. Because data from years of coaching points to the impossibility of knowing in advance which exercise will generate the most powerful learning or become a turning point for someone, we tend to take the default position of offering all exercises, time permitting. Still, there will be times when our read of the circumstances or client preferences leads us to decide to skip to a particular exercise.

When might you move directly to testing the Big Assumption?

Three of the more common reasons we have done so are:

- There are time constraints in the coaching contract, e.g., for whatever reason, the coaching contract is for only a couple of months;
- The person has an immediate event that is driving his need to be coached, e.g., he is scheduled to give a keynote to a large audience in a month; and
- The person has both a strong preference for learning through immediate action and a low tolerance for reflection or thinking exercises.

If you decide that your client will be best served by moving to testing, you should know that there's a higher threshold you'll want to reach for having a testable assumption (which we take up in chapter six, "Testing the Big Assumption"). There are also more formal criteria (S-M-A-R-T criteria, which we discuss in that same chapter). If you are wondering why there should be a higher standard, the answer is that your client won't have the benefits of learning about his Big Assumption from the prior exercises in "Setting the Stage" and "Digging In." These earlier exercises are designed to help your client to better know her Big Assumption, which often becomes more differentiated. Occasionally, a person realizes that the initial Big Assumption isn't really the **Big** one. While there are trade-offs in moving from honing a map directly to testing, that decision can pay off. We have seen many people overcome their immunity through just testing Big Assumptions.

Whether now or later, is the Assumption Testable?

Let's return to the more likely scenario, that your client will continue to "set the stage" for testing his Big Assumption. In this case, the standard for what you need to accomplish is simply that you have confidence that his Big Assumption could be tested. You don't need to have the exact assumption yet, because that is likely to get sharpened through his engaging it in any or all of the exercises between this point and actual testing. (We will discuss this in later exercises.)

So how do we know if an assumption is going to be testable at this point? Here's a little quiz for you: which of the following do you think are testable-ish in their current form, and which are not testable yet? Circle the ones that don't appear testable.

1. I don't believe I can ever be skillful at managing my anger or frustration.
2. My self-worth is based on how others view me.
3. If I'm not skeptical, there's no clear way for me to add value as a leader.
4. If I'm not perfect and strong... I will not be respected in my role.
5. If I don't do it myself, it will be done badly and I'll have more work to do to clean things up.

6. I don't deserve to feel happy.
7. If I were to fail, I would lose all my self-respect.
8. I don't deserve the recognition because everything is easier for me.
9. I need to feel overfull in order to feel full enough.
10. If I made my boss angry, then I would get fired.
11. If I don't drink or eat, I won't be as fun, I won't fit in.
12. If I have to engage in all the tedious details, I will go out of my mind with boredom and hate my work.

If you found this hard, that's ok! There is not necessarily a bright line between what is testable and what is not. And the more experience you have working with tests, the easier it will be for you to generate possible testing ideas. Our answer to the quiz: items 6, 7 and 10 are not yet testable. Why not? (Before reading our answer you might want to look at the list in Appendix D of potential tests for all the other assumptions. See what you think.).

Need for quality data: One quick way to assess potential testability is to ask yourself what data, if they existed, could call the assumption into doubt. If you can't think of any, then it will be impossible to test it. A good test is one that sets up the conditions for the tester to learn that his Big Assumption is not 100% accurate. Data that confirm the Big Assumption, given that best case scenario, begin to suggest that the assumption may well be accurate. (Of course, we'd want the person to do another high quality test, again, by creating the conditions to disprove the certainty). What data could disconfirm the assumption, "I don't deserve to be happy?" We can't think of any, and if you can, do tell us!

Need to create safe "if": Another quick way to assess potential testability comes after you have identified what data would discredit a Big Assumption: is there a safe way to create the conditions that would generate those data? If you can't think of a safe way to test it, it's not testable. Lack of safety can come from either setting up the "if" or the "then" part of the assumption. An untestable assumption has problems with either portion of the Big Assumption or both. With that in mind, take a look at the example above to see what makes it untestable: "If I were to fail, I would lose all my self-respect." What's your diagnosis?

If you said it's the "if" condition, we agree with you. "Failing" has no shades of gray to it, it either happens or it doesn't. A person doesn't "kind of" fail. It is impossible to safely test this assumption as is (and the likelihood that the "then" consequence will occur is actually quite high!). If you thought the "then" statement was problematic, that's understandable because losing all one's self-respect, after all, would be catastrophic. But this Big Assumption is already not testable given the "if" clause.

What makes the Big Assumption “*If I were to fail, I would lose all my self-respect*” untestable?

Need to create safe “then” too: Our basic rule of thumb is this: a testable assumption is one where the “if” condition has degrees or shades to it so we can enact it safely and the “then” consequence is not so terrible that we couldn’t live with it if it was to happen. What happens if it isn’t testable in its current form? No worries, this is often the case. Whenever we can, we want to explore a powerful Big Assumption, even ones that are untestable in their draft form, since these typically capture a person’s most self-limiting worldview. We are going to show you how to convert these into perfectly useful testable assumptions, but you might want to take a first crack at doing that:

Any ideas how you might help a person with the Big Assumption “*If I were to fail, I would lose all my self-respect*” to make it more testable?

Big Assumptions Checkpoint 3: Helping to Help Make an Assumption Testable

When the “if” part of a Big Assumption makes it untestable:

Option 1: Consider whether there are assumptions embedded within your client’s current “if” statement (imagine you are “double-clicking” on the “if” statement). It’s not uncommon for a client to hold a series of assumptions, of “if, then” beliefs within that original “if” statement. In other words, a lot would have to occur for this “if” statement to happen! These additional assumptions are likely to be more testable. One way to ask your client about this is something along the lines of, “Let’s focus on the ‘if’ part of this assumption; what would you need to do to get to this point? It seems that the ‘if’ may be a consequence of other things – what precedes it?” Take a moment to try this out, as you imagine what a person with the Big Assumption “If I was to fail, I would lose all my self-respect” might say in response to this question:

Imagine what might be at least one “if, then” embedded in the “if” part of this assumption, “*If I were to fail, I would lose all my self-respect*”?

Whatever the person’s response is, it will expose a set of beliefs about what in/actions she believes would lead her to fail. She might say, for example, “If I didn’t get everyone on board with the initiative” or, “If I didn’t accomplish everything I expect” or, “If I got really angry.” There are endless possible answers to the question, and your client’s answer will depend on her own belief system. Still, the point is that these responses provide material that takes us closer to testable material. We may still need to ask another round of questions. If someone said that failure would result “if I didn’t accomplish everything I expect,” we might follow this with a first question that focused on the “standards” bar, i.e., “you would fail if you didn’t accomplish *all* of your expectations?” or on the “expectations” bar, i.e., “are you saying that all of your expectations are equally important?”

Option 2: Consider that there may be embedded concerns around generic issues that surround the assumption your client has named – self-esteem, learning, and tolerance of feelings are three such rich areas. Very often there is a set of assumptions that go hand-in-hand with an assumption, and these connect to the person’s beliefs about her capacity to learn to do something different, or the feelings she will have as she tries to learn, or how much she believes she will be able to bear the feared outcome. (For more on self-esteem and learning, please see the Ning site for Lisa Lahey’s review of Carol Dweck’s book, *Mindsets*.)

Note that your client may not say any of this as directly as in example #1 in the quiz above (“I don’t believe I can ever be skillful at managing my anger or frustration”) but these beliefs may be lurking behind her assumption, or along it, and she needs a little nudge to see it. For example, let’s say her assumption is that, “I assume every writing exercise is an existential blue book exam about whether I’m a good writer or not.” Another way she may well mean this assumption is “I assume that if my writing is not perfect the first time, I’m not a good writer.” This points to the possibility that she believes a person is either a good/ talented writer or she isn’t, that she is, to use Carol Dweck’s language, operating out of an entity mindset rather than a learning one. If this is accurate, it’s also likely that her sense of self-esteem will be at stake (some version of “If I fail the blue book exam I might as well give up any hope that I am a writer”).

Option 3: Hold off with questions and allow your client to discover what she means by her assumption in future exercises. (Just to give you a feel for how this works here, let’s say that your client opts to do a Continuum of Progress around his goal to be more collaborative. His first draft of what success looks like should include something about a new relationship to his assumption about “all” and “expectations” and his standards for his work. When reviewing that exercise, your job will be to help him specify these kinds of pictures.)

Why is the assumption “*If I made my boss angry, then I would get fired*” untestable?

It is untestable for two reasons. Perhaps the more obvious problem is that getting “fired” is too high a risk. But before that, we should see that the “if” portion is also problematic. What does the person believe he would do that would make his boss unhappy? This needs to get unpacked. So we can ask “What do you assume you do that would lead your boss to be angry?” to elicit those assumptions and then see which of those might be tested safely.

When the “then” part of a Big Assumption makes it untestable:

We suggest similar strategies for how to make a dire “then” portion of a Big Assumption more testable. First, see if your client can “unpack” or “double-click” on how his Big Time Bad, catastrophic experience would occur. (Hopefully, this option sounds familiar from our earlier discussion of working to make the “if” testable.) Here’s an example: “If I listen to people’s criticisms of me, I will decide that I am worthless.” The “if” portion of this assumption is relatively fine (of course, we can always ask for more information, such as what makes a person’s statement a criticism). The “then” consequence is unacceptable: discovering “I am worthless” is definitely too Big Time Bad to test, do you agree? But let’s stay with that for a moment and see whether we can together imagine the chain of internal events that could lead the person to feel worthless. One way to ask this is saying something like, “I am with you on the ‘if’ part of the assumption, but the jump to the ‘then’ part seems big; what happens in between? What else did you assume to make that second part true?” Another way to ask is, “Can you explain how listening to criticisms could lead to such feelings of worthlessness?” There is no correct answer here; the exercise is to practice imagining nested assumptions.

What might be at least one “if, then” embedded in the “then” part of this assumption. *“If I listen to people’s criticisms of me, I will decide that I am worthless”?*

When we asked this person the same question (yes, this is a real person's Big Assumption), here's what he said: "If I listen to criticisms of my work, then I'll end up trashing that project. I'll feel like I don't know what I'm doing, and that I don't have what it takes to create a project that has any merit. So I won't want to go back to the drawing board, since that will be criticized too, which means I won't have a way to connect to others or contribute to society. That's how I'll be worthless." As you can see, this person has a whole rich narrative behind his original Big Assumption. Most of us do too. So he could take any part of what he has unpacked there and test that out if he is criticized: Must he *trash* the project? Does he in fact feel that he knows *nothing*? Will he feel that a criticized project has *no merit*? Should he test any or all of these (in a manner we will get to soon), and discover disconfirming data (which, in fact, he did) that could lead to big alterations of his immune system (which, in fact, it did).

If your client's "then" statement needs to be less dire, ask (as we did above) what would happen between the time your "if" condition occurred and when you e.g., "died" "got fired," or "had a nervous breakdown"? His response may generate testable assumptions.

Tips and Pitfalls

Coach's Tips for Honing a Map

- Overall Tips*
1. Honing a map is not always necessary, and when it is, try to accomplish it in one session.
 2. The goal of honing is make sure your client has a powerful map, including a compelling picture of the immune system and a testable Big Assumption.
 3. Ask your client directly how powerful his map is to him and why.
 4. Use all the 4-Column criteria as your reference points.
 5. If you plan to move directly to testing Big Assumptions with your client, read Chapter 6 "Testing Big Assumptions" where you will find the S-M-A-R-T criteria and examples of tests.

6. If you plan to explore the Big Assumption through various exercises before testing, the threshold to cross now is having a “good enough” Big Assumption. That assumption will get honed naturally as your client engages in upcoming exercises.

1. *Column 1:* To get a more meaningful goal, try re-wording it (make it more or less specific, or state it in the positive or in the negative).
2. *Column 2:* Should include the most important in/actions. If there are a lot of entries, look to cluster these.
3. *Column 3:* To get a more essential form of self-protection, make sure: a) the “fear box” includes the worry re: doing the opposite of the most counter-productive Column.2 behavior; and b) the wording of the commitment keeps the “yuk” in it from the fear box.

*Specific Tips for
Strengthening a Map*

Try re-wording the commitment (make it more extreme, or state it in a different way).

See if there is a commitment to be loyal to someone or some group, or avoid being/looking like someone.

4. *Column 4:* Big Assumptions with awful consequences (whether in the “if” or “then” clauses) are not yet testable.

A necessary but insufficient criterion to assess if a Big Assumption is testable is whether you/your client can imagine data that would cast doubt on it. If so, a good test creates the conditions to generate that data.

Often, there are embedded “if, then” assumptions within a given assumption. Look to the “if” portion of an assumption first to unpack “loaded” words.

Self-esteem, learning, and tolerance of feelings are three rich areas for exploring additional assumptions.

Potential Pitfalls

Coach	Client
Loses sight of the purpose of developing a map (identifying an immune system and the assumptions that anchor it). Gets pulled into client's enthusiastic responses to her insights.	Experiences her map as powerful, but not because of seeing her immune system. Is excited by discovery.
Uses his personal standards to assess depth and power of map rather than relying on the combination of the Immunity-to-Change criteria and the client's experience.	Experiences map as "correct" according to coach's standards, but not powerful to himself.
Values quantity of entries over coherence within a column or across the columns.	Is not clear about the focus of the work, what she will be working on, or how.
Tries too hard to push the client to a "deeper" level or bigger insight.	Feels overwhelmed, scared, judged, and/or resistant.
Gets overly focused on meeting the criteria, not carefully listening to (and so getting disconnected from) client's own meaning, understanding, and/or experience.	Feels dread or worry about what the overturning process will entail. Or is unable to envision what the overturning work will involve.
Doesn't work with client so that written map reflects accurately and clearly what client intends (e.g., entry in third column may look noble as written, but client makes sense of it in a way that is not noble).	The map and its meaning remain vague. Any coherence and power depends on client's memory of his intentions.
Doesn't help client arrive at a testable assumption(s).	

In-depth Examples: Jackson and Amanda

Jackson's Map

Jackson is a middle manager in a large financial organization. He felt that his career was getting a bit stalled, in part because he tended to fly under the radar. He decided he needed to get better at publicizing his accomplishments as a way to gain greater visibility among higher level leaders.

Version 1

1. Commitment/ Improvement Goal	2. Doing/NotDoing	3. Hidden Counter- Commitment	4. Big Assumptions
Having senior management see more clearly my contributions to this organization.	I don't offer status updates. I make self-deprecating comments which I think are funny and can put people at ease with me. When people praise me, I get embarrassed and try to change the subject. I don't like colleagues who look for any opportunity to publicize their accomplishments. I don't do what I plan or intend to.	Fears – being a jerk, selfish, opportunistic and blind. Losing touch. Convincing myself that I deserve more. I am committed to not being Kurt (or curt!). I am committed to not being an asshole. I am committed to not selling my soul for a little bit more power and \$.	I assume that if I am bragging, I am just like Kurt (also selfish, arrogant, etc.). I assume that if I publicize my successes, I'll believe that I am a hero.

Jackson's coach read this first version of the map and immediately noted that the first column goal seemed more focused on getting others to do something (see Jackson's contributions) than on something Jackson himself needed to get better at. Also, the Column 2 entries weren't all framed as behaviors. In particular, what does it mean that Jackson doesn't like colleagues who publicize their accomplishments? How does that attitude show up as particular behaviors? Jackson's coach also planned to ask specifically about the Column 3 entries in order to understand their meaning for Jackson. For example, who is Kurt? Why is he a powerful figure that Jackson wants to avoid becoming? Additionally, the third column commitments had a bit of a noble feel to them. Who wants to be an asshole? Who wants to sell his soul for power and money? What wasn't at all clear yet was how these commitments might be forms of self-protection for Jackson. Together, they would need to explore and explain the underbelly of these commitments, if there was one. Hopefully, once the third column was clarified, they would be able to see if these Big Assumptions also needed to be reworked or reworded.

Version 2, Honed (Note: entries in **red** capture honing)

1. Commitment/Improvement Goal	2. Doing/NotDoing	3. Hidden Counter-Commitment	4. Big Assumptions
To get better at publicizing my accomplishments with senior management.	I don't request time for or offer status updates. I make self-deprecating comments. When people praise me, I get embarrassed and try to change the subject. I criticize colleagues who can publicize their accomplishments – I label that type of behavior as bragging, being arrogant. I imagine ways I could publicize my successes better but I don't act on these plans.	Fears – being a jerk, selfish, opportunistic and blind to my own human foibles. Losing touch with reality. Convincing myself that I deserve more than I do. I am committed to not becoming my brother (Kurt). I am committed to not fitting the mold of the "asshole" executive. ...not finding out that I actually am an asshole executive.	I assume that saying anything about my accomplishments is bragging. I assume that if I am bragging, I am just like Kurt (also selfish, arrogant, etc.). I assume that if I publicize my successes, I'll believe what I say.

Amanda's Map

Amanda is a part-time accountant and mother of two young children. Since her twenties, she had steadily gained a few pounds each year, and her weight rose dramatically after having her children. There is a family history of high blood pressure and high cholesterol, and Amanda was already taking medication to try and control both. Her doctor strongly recommended that she lose weight, but to this point, Amanda has been unsuccessful.

As part of a weight-loss program she was enrolled in, Amanda attended a workshop called “Are You Immune to Your Diet?” during which she designed her own immunity map.

Version 1

1. Commitment/ Improvement Goal	2. Doing/NotDoing	3. Hidden Counter- Commitment	4. Big Assumptions
To get thin and healthy.	I don't follow diets carefully. I eat when I'm stressed or feeling down. I don't go to the gym (bad weather, too tired, too busy, etc.). I drink beer before, during, and after dinner. I eat for rewards. I think that I inherited these problems.	Fears: rules, trapped, inconvenienced, annoyed, bleak. I am committed to freedom. I am committed to rewarding myself.	I assume that if I don't have freedom, what's the point? I assume that if I don't reward myself, I'll be unhappy.

Amanda's first version of her map did not feel very powerful to her. She saw in it exactly what she had expected to see. But she could clearly see how others in her workshop had developed very powerful maps, and she was curious to see if she could go deeper with her own. She also felt like the ITC approach to looking at her diet and exercise issues seemed intriguingly different from any she had tried (and failed at) in the past. She decided to enroll in individualized coaching as part of her weight-loss program. After working with her coach in their first session together, she completed a honed version of her map.

Basically, her coach asked her to be more specific about each of her entries and to write down a clearer, more explicit version – to really spell out completely what she was thinking. Also, her coach reminded her of the criteria for each column, helping Amanda rework her entries to meet those criteria. Amanda found that as she was trying to explain her ideas, her coach asked for more detail, more clarity. And then they would try to capture those ideas as carefully as they could in writing. Getting more specific entries helped Amanda see more clearly what was at stake for her, and by the time she was revising her 3rd and 4th columns, she felt that the map was much more powerful and insightful.

Version 2, Honed (Note: entries in **red** capture honing)

1. Commitment/ Improvement Goal	2. Doing/NotDoing	3. Hidden Counter- Commitment	4. Big Assumptions
To develop healthier eating habits. To lose 25 pounds thereby lowering my blood pressure and improving my cholesterol.	I don't count calories. I don't stick to diets. I eat when I'm stressed or feeling down. I use any excuse not to go to the gym (bad weather, too tired, too busy, etc.). I drink beer before, during, and after dinner. I use food and drink as rewards. I tell myself that I can't change my habits or get thin, and probably can't improve my numbers (bp, cholesterol) much because I inherited these problems.	Fears – having to follow rules, feeling trapped, inconvenienced and annoyed by diet. Embarrassment that others will know I care about this stuff. That my life will be bleak. I am committed to always feeling the freedom of having lots of options, making my own decisions, not having to follow someone else's rules. I am committed to rewarding myself, getting what I deserve. Not admitting that the implications on my health are as bad as they might actually be.	I assume that if I don't have lots of options, I will feel resentful, angry, impotent, and stressed. Life will be bleak. I assume that if I don't reward myself with food or drink, then I will be less motivated at work and in my personal life. I assume that if I were to take seriously the fact that my health is not great, I'll become depressed and maybe act in ways that are even more unhealthy.

Now it's your turn to assess some maps. Remember to go through all of the columns to make sure they meet the criteria and then to take a more holistic view of the systems at work. There is a space after each map that should be used for recording your comments (including what you would do to improve any weaknesses). After doing each, you can read our comments on these maps. We strongly suggest that you do not look ahead to our commentary until after you have completed your own.

Practice Time: Over To You

Practice Map I

1. Commitment/ Improvement Goal	2. Doing/NotDoing	3. Hidden Counter- Commitment	4. Big Assumptions
Stop being a workaholic.	Keep an open door policy. Allow myself to get distracted or interrupted by every little thing that crosses my desk or comes in the door. Don't delegate enough. Don't do a good job figuring out who does what. Don't clarify responsibilities with CEO. Don't set boundaries on how many hours I'll work. Don't take time to do what I need to do to keep myself healthy – sleep, eat well, stay fit.	Fears: Work won't get done or won't get done well. Our reputation with clients will suffer. The CEO will be angry and/or disappointed. Commitments: Being the best at everything I do – or am supposed to do. Get everything done. Looking good in the eyes of others. Making sure people have what they need to do their jobs. Not having others mad at me. Putting others' needs before mine.	I am the only one who will make sure the work will be done and done well. In the end, the CEO wants it done well and doesn't care how that happens. It is more efficient for me to just do the work then to try to train others. The organization cannot risk the potential short-term losses for the long-term gain. The CEO will hold me accountable for any mistakes others make.

Your Comments

Column 1

Column 2

Column 3

Column 4

Overall

Our Comments

What the Client Said/Wrote	What the Coach Was Thinking
Column 1: Stop being a workaholic.	OK, looks good. It is a very clear goal, and it looks like it implicates him. I will also need to confirm that it meets the other criteria – that it's true for him, there's room for improvement, that it is very important for him (hopefully it's a 4 or 5.)
Column 2: 1. Keep an open door policy. 2. Allow myself to get distracted or interrupted by every little thing that crosses my desk or comes in the door. 3. Don't delegate enough. 4. Don't do a good job figuring out who does what. 5. Don't clarify responsibilities with CEO. 6. Don't set boundaries on how many hours I'll work. 7. Don't take time to do what I need to do to keep myself healthy – sleep, eat well, stay fit.	A nice list – they are specific behaviors that undermine the Column 1 goal in that they keep him working longer hours than he'd like. Does #7 undermine Column 1? It could if it means that renewal would allow him to be more efficient or productive... something like that. But it could be that he really sees it as a consequence of not meeting his Column 1 goal. I should check in with him on that. I also want to confirm that I know what he means by #4 and #5. I can guess, but I want to make sure I'm not reading too much of my own interpretation into what he wrote. Maybe he'll want to reword those to represent exactly what he means.
Column 3: Fears: 1. Work won't get done or won't get done well. Our reputation with clients will suffer. 2. The CEO will be angry and/or disappointed.	I think I see how these make sense. Like, if he were to take the time for some of the behaviors he listed in the previous column (e.g., #3, #4, #5) that would mean he'd be taking time away from other work he's doing (and then it wouldn't get done)? I wonder if he was targeting specific Column 2 behaviors when he identified these fears? If so, which ones? Do those feel like they are the most powerful? I think I'd like to see if we could generate other fears here that feel more self-protective (e.g., I'll be less important; I'll feel selfish or mean; others will think I'm selfish or mean; I'll be bored...).

Our Comments continued

What the Client Said/Wrote	What the Coach Was Thinking
Commitments: 1. Being the best at everything I do – or am supposed to do. 2. Get everything done. 3. Looking good in the eyes of others. 4. Making sure people have what they need to do their jobs. 5. Not having others mad at me. 6. Putting others' needs before mine.	I do see how these commitments counteract Column 1 and create an immune system. The thing that feels like it could get more powerful though is that on the face of it, these fears don't seem that self-protective and so they end up generating counter commitments that feel a bit noble. I think #3, #5, and #6 are a little less noble and more self-protective. How powerful to do these feel to him? If he's game, I'd like to explore with him some ways to tweak these a bit or generate other possibilities. That could come from working on the fears. Here are some possibilities: • I'm committed to seeing others' needs as always more important than mine. • I'm committed to never giving anyone any grounds for suggesting I'm selfish. • I'm committed to feeling the adrenaline and excitement of saving the day again. • Etc.
Column 4: 1. I am the only one who will make sure the work will be done and done well. 2. In the end, the CEO wants it done well and doesn't care how that happens. 3. It is more efficient for me to just do the work then to try to train others. 4. The organization cannot risk the potential short-term losses for the long-term gain. 5. The CEO will hold me accountable for any mistakes others make.	Hm, interesting. I can imagine designing tests for these – to see, for example, what the CEO does expect, and what others actually do want. The survey might accomplish a good deal of this. Others, such as the third bullet point, would be a good thing to design tests around.

Our Comments continued

What the Client Said/Wrote	What the Coach Was Thinking
Column 4 continued:	I notice that not all of the third column commitments are addressed. Were those not so powerful to him, or he just didn't see assumptions there? What I think needs most work here is that the assumptions are mostly focused externally – on what others want or expect. I'd like him to also look within to see what he assumes will happen to him (how he will think, feel, etc). For example, “If I don't do everything the CEO wants me to do, as soon as she asks, I'll feel...” “If others do make mistakes, I'll feel...”
Overall:	I think the map could be more powerful and could more clearly show the immune system in action, but I need to make sure I see how my client feels about it. I don't want to push too hard or lose something in it that really speaks to him.

Practice Map 2

1. Commitment/ Improvement Goal	2. Doing/NotDoing	3. Hidden Counter- Commitment	4. Big Assumptions
Trust others (those who work for me) to create, be change agents, and be professional leaders in our field.	Perhaps too high expectations too soon. At times I'm not a good listener. I lead too strongly at times. I ignore, or disconnect, so as not to see any deficiencies. My attitude is, "If I want it done right, I need to do it myself." (Perhaps this would be an inner state). I'm impatient; I don't give people enough chance to grow and develop. Sometimes I don't communicate effectively enough.	I want to be viewed as the leader with all the answers. I feel safe when people look to me to lead the pack. It serves my Type-A personality well. I don't want to show any "kinks in my armor" (i.e. weakness). If I get too close, I might be taken advantage of.	If I "let go" of my leadership positioning, I will lose my stature in the hierarchy of the organization. "Stepping Back" is a weakness or negative.

Your Comments

Column 1
Column 2
Column 3
Column 4
Overall

Our Comments

What the Client Said/Wrote	What the Coach Was Thinking
Column 1: Trust others (those who work for me) to create, be change agents, and be professional leaders in our field.	OK, I think I get this, but I want to know more about what she means specifically – to create what? What does it mean for them to be change agents and leaders in the field? It looks like it implicates her. I will also need to confirm that it meets the other criteria – that it's true for her, there's room for improvement, that it is very important for her (hopefully it's a 4 or 5).
Column 2: - Perhaps too high expectations too soon. - At times I'm not a good listener. - I lead too strongly at times. - I ignore, or disconnect, so as not to see any deficiencies. - My attitude is, "If I want it done right, I need to do it myself." (Perhaps this would be an inner state.) - I'm impatient; I don't give people enough chance to grow and develop. - Sometimes I don't communicate effectively enough.	These look good but are a bit general or maybe just not worded as clearly as they could be. Again, I might try to pin them down a bit more – does she hold the expectations, communicate the expectations, or both (in #1)? How does she "lead too strongly" (#3) – what specifically is she doing (or not doing) that works against the Column 1 goal? In #5, I think she is right that she may have identified an inner state, but maybe there are behaviors that stem from that state that haven't already been named – e.g., "I tend to do things myself instead of asking someone else to do them." In #6 – how does that impatience show up in her behavior? She is short with people? She gives them unrealistic deadlines? She judges them? Something else? In #7, if she isn't communicating effectively, what is she doing? Being vague (as she is in this map)? Sending messages indirectly (through others or by hinting)? Speaking impulsively before she's had the chance to think through what she really wants to say? Something else?

Our Comments continued

What the Client Said/Wrote	What the Coach Was Thinking
Column 3 1. I want to be viewed as the leader with all the answers. 2. I feel safe when people look to me to lead the pack. 3. It serves my Type-A personality well. 4. I don't want to show any "kinks in my armor" (i.e., weakness). 5. If I get too close, I might be taken advantage of.	It looks to me like she actually did get to some powerful insights in Column 3 – I'll need to check and see if that is in fact what she thinks. And, I can see how they work against her Column 1 goal. Still, she may be willing to see if we can generate some other possibilities that are also (more?) powerful here. We might still generate the same counter commitments she has listed here, but maybe not, especially if we add to her Column 2 behaviors. I'd start with generating a fear box (to ensure that columns 2 and 3 are closely related and so that she can clearly see how her worries and hidden commitments explain her behaviors). Then I'd see if that list of fears showed her if there were additional/more powerful things that she was committed to... The second, third, and fifth bullets are not commitments. They seem more like explanations for why she holds the first commitment. The fifth bullet, for example, seems to be a Big Assumption. These could be stated as commitments (e.g. a commitment to feeling safe). And then we could also add the assumptions to her 4th column.
Column 4: 1. If I "let go" my leadership positioning, I lose my stature in the hierarchy of the organization. 2. "Stepping Back" is a weakness or negative.	These do seem like assumptions that underlie her immune system. Are they the biggest ones? That's not clear. The first bullet is testable but not very modest or safe. I'd want to "double click" on this assumption and unpack the assumptions embedded within it. For example, what would lead her to lose her stature?

Our Comments continued

What the Client Said/Wrote	What the Coach Was Thinking
Column 4 continued	The second bullet is not testable in its current form, but it could be tweaked a bit now (or later, as we get to the testing stage). Maybe something like, “if I step back from doing all the work I am doing now, I will see myself as a weak leader.” It seems to me we could add the assumptions she has listed in Column 3 here, and that there are other connected ones – like to take just one example, what does she consider to be a “kink in her armor?” (Some possibilities: “I assume that telling people I don’t have all the answers is showing a kink in my armor.” Or, “I assume that making my thinking transparent is a kink in my armor.”) I wouldn’t want to generate an endless list, but I would want to make sure we got to the biggest ones, as she sees them.
Overall:	I have a hunch that this might already feel quite powerful to my client and illustrate her immune system as she sees it. I think the map could be more powerful and could more clearly show the immune system in action, but I need to make sure she’s game for pushing on.

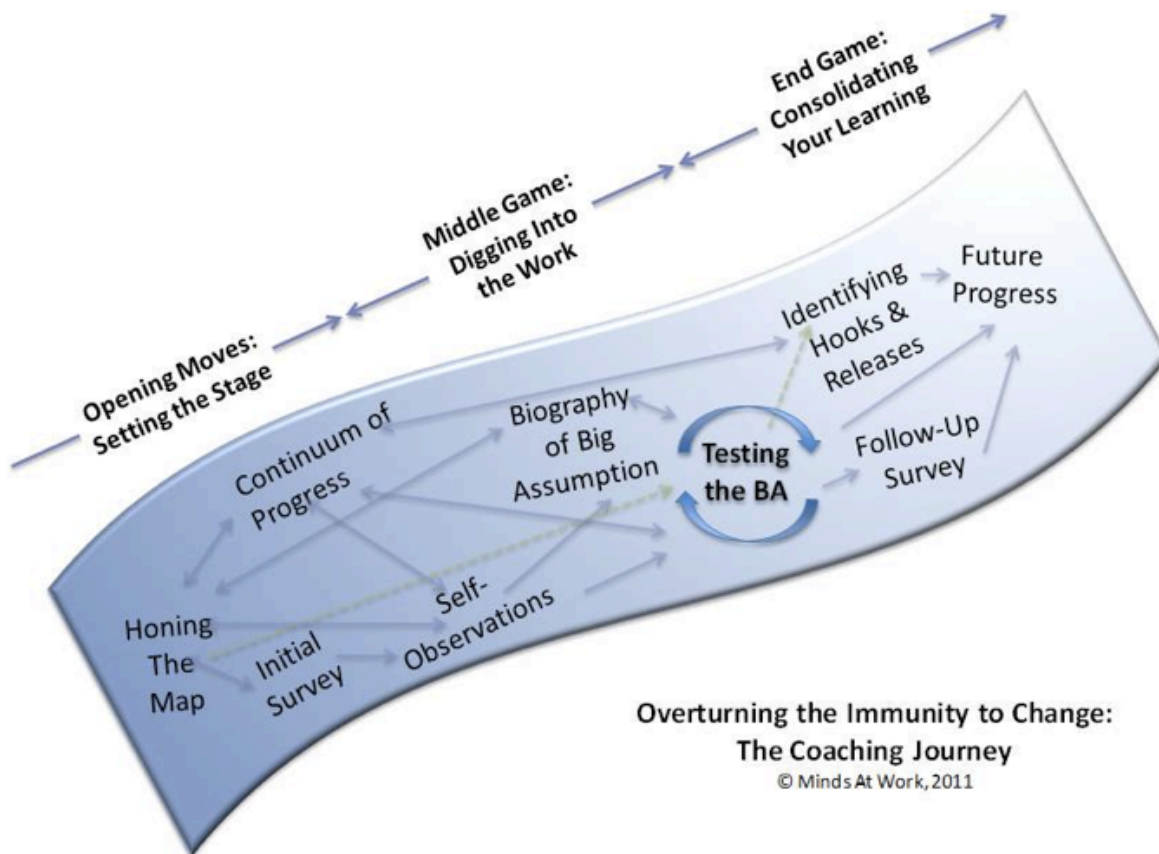
Appendix A

4-Column Criteria

1. Commitment/ Improvement Goal	2. Doing/NotDoing	3. Hidden Counter- Commitment	4. Big Assumptions
Column Criteria: ☐ It's true for you. ☐ It implicates you. ☐ There's room for improvement. ☐ It's <i>important</i> to you.	Column Criteria: ☐ Behaviors (not inner states). ☐ These behaviors get in the way of or work against Column 1 goal. ☐ Not "why" or what you should do about it.	Column Criteria: ☐ Follows from fear. ☐ Commitment to self-protection. ☐ Shows why Column 2 behaviors make good sense. ☐ Feels powerful, you can see the Immune System.	Column Criteria: ☐ Makes Column 3 commitment absolutely necessary. ☐ Has a Big Time Bad conclusion <i>for you</i>. ☐ Displays a contracted world. ☐ Feels real.

Appendix B

Immunity-to-Change Journey Chart



Appendix C

Subjectivity: Cartoon



It may take you a moment to “read” this cartoon. If you are having any difficulty: Check out the artist’s eye-glasses! Can we agree that before he can meet his change challenge, this artist would need to recognize that he is subject to the fly? Can we also agree, more seriously, that seeing our own Big Assumptions may be crucial if there is any distortion to our lens? Sometimes showing this to coachees can be a light-hearted way to show them that the assumptions that they may insist are “true” may still be subject to them.

Appendix D

Potential Tests

1. Big Assumption: *"I don't believe I can ever be skillful at managing my anger or frustration."*

Test #1

My Big Assumption Says:	So I Will (Change my Behavior This Way)...	And Collect the Following Data...	In Order to Find Out Whether...
I don't believe I can ever be skillful at managing my anger or frustration.	Take an anger management course.	Do I find the strategies compelling? Do they provide me with believable success stories or others who became skillful?	I can imagine the possibility of increasing my skills.

Test #2

My Big Assumption Says:	So I Will (Change my Behavior This Way)...	And Collect the Following Data...	In Order to Find Out Whether...
I don't believe I can ever be skillful at managing my anger or frustration.	Try out a new relaxation technique at work.	Did they lose respect How do I feel (physically, mentally, emotionally) before using the technique? After? How do I behave?	I can increase my skills.

2. Big Assumption: *“My self-worth is based on how others view me.”*

Test #1

My Big Assumption Says:	So I Will (Change my Behavior This Way)...	And Collect the Following Data...	In Order to Find Out Whether...
My self-worth is based on how others view me. (In other words, if others view me negatively, then I will have low self-worth.)	I will engage in some thought experiments – to imagine situations where others might possibly view me negatively, that would actually not lead me to have low self-worth. For example, I can imagine a situation like... I give kids daily chores to do and they are mad at me. But I know that over time, they are becoming more responsible people, and so I don't have low self-worth – I actually feel better.	Can I imagine several, plausible counters to my BA that are relevant to my own life?	There are any circumstances under which I wouldn't base my self-worth on others' opinions of me.

Test #2

My Big Assumption Says:	So I Will (Change my Behavior This Way)...	And Collect the Following Data...	In Order to Find Out Whether...
My self-worth is based on how others view me. (In other words, if others view me negatively, then I will have low self-worth.).	I tell my husband about my concerns about our kids' behavior.	Does he blame me for their problems? Does he feel I am a bad parent? If he does, must I share his assessment?	I can develop a sense of self-worth that is based on my own view of myself and how I'm doing as a parent.

3. Big Assumption: *“If I’m not skeptical, there’s no clear way for me to add value as a leader.”*

Test #1

My Big Assumption Says:	So I Will (Change my Behavior This Way)...	And Collect the Following Data...	In Order to Find Out Whether...
If I’m not skeptical, there’s no clear way for me to add value as a leader.	I will interview another leader (who is a very positive guy and as a fantastic reputation in our company) to ask him how he thinks about how he “adds value as a leader” (and also about the role of skepticism in that).	His definition of what it means to “add value,” which I can compare to my own idea.	He adds value without being skeptical.

Test #2

My Big Assumption Says:	So I Will (Change my Behavior This Way)...	And Collect the Following Data...	In Order to Find Out Whether...
If I’m not skeptical, there’s no clear way for me to add value as a leader.	At the departmental meeting on Friday, I will attempt to suspend judgment until Carl has presented his entire proposal. Then I will create two buckets of evaluations – potential strengths and potential weaknesses. Before the meeting, I’ll ask Amelia to see what she thinks of my contributions – do they add value? How do they compare to my usual contributions?	I will see if I feel that I still capture all the possible concerns I have, while also attending to the positives. Do I feel we have covered all our bases? I will get feedback after the meeting from Amelia.	I can add value without only expressing my skepticism.

4. Big Assumption: *“If I am not perfect and strong, I will not be respected in my role.”*

Test #1

My Big Assumption Says:	So I Will (Change my Behavior This Way)...	And Collect the Following Data...	In Order to Find Out Whether...
If I am not perfect and strong... I will not be respected in my role.	I will read biographies and memoirs of great leaders who changed history but were also able to show a softer, more vulnerable side – maybe even make mistakes.	Did they lose respect from others? Did they lose ground?	It is possible to show a weaker, softer side and still be respected as a leader.

Test #2

My Big Assumption Says:	So I Will (Change my Behavior This Way)...	And Collect the Following Data...	In Order to Find Out Whether...
If I am not perfect and strong... I will not be respected in my role.	I will ask for more input on the upcoming presentation from the 3 other presenters (even though they are subordinates).	Does the team become chaotic, feel like a free-for-all, or can I still step in and make an executive decision when I need to?	I have to hold the reins so tightly or if I can allow others to help me without being seen as weak.

5. Big Assumption: *“If I don’t do it myself, it will be done badly and I’ll have more work to do to clean things up.”*

Test #1

My Big Assumption Says:	So I Will (Change my Behavior This Way)...	And Collect the Following Data...	In Order to Find Out Whether...
If I don’t do it myself, it will be done badly, and I’ll have more work to do to clean things up.	I’ll read the book my coach recommended on how to delegate effectively.	Practical materials, tips, and strategies I can use to help others take more responsibility (and produce quality products).	I think I can learn to use these material, tips, and strategies.

Test #2

My Big Assumption Says:	So I Will (Change my Behavior This Way)...	And Collect the Following Data...	In Order to Find Out Whether...
If I don't do it myself, it will be done badly, and I'll have more work to do to clean things up.	Meet with Joyce, Ramona, and Aayush to go over the standards for a successful fundraiser.	What they say they understand is the standard we'll need to achieve for this fundraiser.	Their understanding of the standard is high enough.

6. Big Assumption: *"I don't deserve the recognition because everything is easier for me."*

Test #1

My Big Assumption Says:	So I Will (Change my Behavior This Way)...	And Collect the Following Data...	In Order to Find Out Whether...
I don't deserve the recognition because everything is easier for me.	Make a list of all my accomplishments – large and small, those that came easy and those that came hardest. Put an asterisk next to the ones for which I received recognition from others.	How do I feel about the accomplishments for which I wasn't recognized? How many were recognized (vs. unrecognized)? How were they recognized?	I am uncomfortable with any recognition... I am comfortable only when I'm not recognized.

Test #2

My Big Assumption Says:	So I Will (Change my Behavior This Way)...	And Collect the Following Data...	In Order to Find Out Whether...
I don't deserve the recognition because everything is easier for me.	I will accept praise and compliments graciously, without offering apologies, self-criticism, or making a joke. I will listen carefully to their praise in order to learn what it is that they appreciate.	How do I feel? What do I learn from what they say?	I can feel comfortable with recognition – even enjoy it – without immediately thinking about whether or not it is deserved? Can I learn from others' praise about what is important to them?

7. Big Assumption: *“I need to feel overfull in order to feel full enough.”*

Test #1

My Big Assumption Says:	So I Will (Change my Behavior This Way)...	And Collect the Following Data...	In Order to Find Out Whether...
I need to feel overfull in order to feel full enough.	After I have eaten half of my meal, I will ask myself if I am full enough? As long as I feel I'm not, I'll keep eating (and keep asking the question). When I feel full enough I'll stop.	How aware am I of what it feels like to feel full?	I eat to the point of “full enough” or if I go past that because there is still food on my plate.

Test #2

My Big Assumption Says:	So I Will (Change my Behavior This Way)...	And Collect the Following Data...	In Order to Find Out Whether...
I need to feel overfull in order to feel full enough.	I will drink a 16 oz glass of water before each meal. I will serve myself an appropriate, healthy portion of food. If I am still hungry after finishing the food, I will wait 20 minutes. If I am still hungry, I will eat a piece of fruit or a fresh vegetable.	Do I feel full faster with the water? Do I feel fuller after 20 minutes? Do I feel like I am depriving myself?	I can feel full by eating less food (or with more, healthier food).

8. Big Assumption: *“If I don't drink or eat, I won't be as fun, I won't fit in.”*

Test #1

My Big Assumption Says:	So I Will (Change my Behavior This Way)...	And Collect the Following Data...	In Order to Find Out Whether...
If I don't drink or eat, I won't be as fun, I won't fit in.	Watch other people at the party who don't eat or drink much.	Do they seem to be having fun? What are they doing instead of eating and drinking?	Other people can have fun without eating or drinking so much.

Test #2

My Big Assumption Says:	So I Will (Change my Behavior This Way)...	And Collect the Following Data...	In Order to Find Out Whether...
If I don't drink or eat, I won't be as fun, I won't fit in.	I will have only one small plate of food and one glass of wine at the party. Then I'll take a glass of water or seltzer (as many as I want) and walk away from the food table and mingle with guests who are far away from it.	Does the glass of water/ seltzer allow me to feel I have enough to keep my hands occupied, or do I feel too awkward just sipping the same glass? Do I talk to different people than I usually do?	I feel comfortable...if I have fun... if I enjoy the conversations as much as when I'm buzzed.

9. Big Assumption: *"If I have to engage in all the tedious details, I will go out of my mind with boredom and will hate my work."*

Test #1

My Big Assumption Says:	So I Will (Change my Behavior This Way)...	And Collect the Following Data...	In Order to Find Out Whether...
If I have to engage in all the tedious details, I will go out of my mind with boredom and will hate my work.	Set aside 15 minutes before lunch and before going home just for tedious details. Don't think about them except during those times.	How much can I get done in that time? How do I feel about it?	Giving myself set times when I have to focus only on them (and other times when I am not allowed to) helps me feel less controlled by them.

Test #2

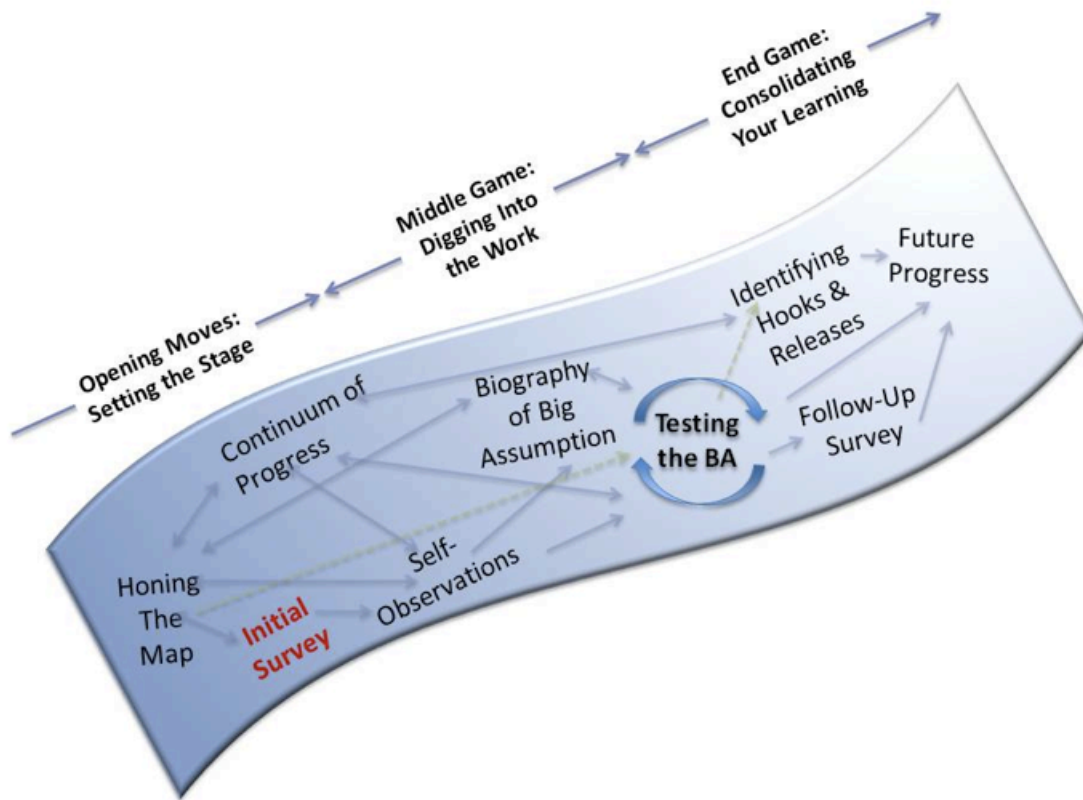
My Big Assumption Says:	So I Will (Change my Behavior This Way)...	And Collect the Following Data...	In Order to Find Out Whether...
If I have to engage in all the tedious details, I will go out of my mind with boredom and will hate my work.	Talk to my boss about giving some of those details to Mia's new assistant.	Does he say yes or no? Will he negotiate?	I actually have to engage in all the tedious details (or not).

Chapter 2

The Initial Survey

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Context for this Exercise

The survey can be conducted twice in the ITC coaching cycle: at the beginning, to get input on the person's goal and to establish a performance baseline, and again, at the end of the coaching, to learn whether others' perceptions of progress match one's own. It is not necessary that your client agree to both surveys from the start.

If you are already in a one-to-coaching relationship, you can choose to raise the idea of a survey prior to the 4-Column Map exercise, since the data from the survey can help your client clarify from the start the goal he wants to take to the map-making. (This is akin to a "virtual" form of 360 degree feedback we invite people to conduct in their minds when they do not have access to the real thing). Or you can wait to discuss the option of having a survey with your client after he has completed his 4-Column map.

When your coaching agreement follows the map-making exercise, then you can discuss the optional survey after he has completed his 4-Column map. You do not need to wait to hone the map as long as your client knows he wants to pursue his learning.

Overview

The overturning-immunities survey is a way for your client to get feedback from selected others about her current performance as it relates specifically to her Column 1 improvement goal. The survey asks questions only about a person's Column 1 goal; it does *not* disclose any of the more personal information of the 2nd, 3rd or 4th columns.

Not all clients have an ITC survey. This may be because there is insufficient time in the coaching cycle, the person's goal does not lend itself to input (either because the goal focus is just on one relationship or it is a personal, internal goal), or the person deems a survey to be too risky. The decision to do a survey rests with the client. The starting place for a survey, therefore, is to discuss with your client whether she wants to do one. Engaging her around her potential worries or fears about getting targeted feedback at this time will help lay a productive foundation for the entire survey process, should she choose to move forward with it.

The survey process has two basic phases: 1) collecting the results (including generating and sending out the survey) and 2) debriefing your client on the results (including preparing the results summary). Both phases require the coach to be attentive to details and logistics, as well as to the client's emotional responses. The whole process takes between 2-3 weeks to complete; while you are waiting for all survey responses to be submitted, you can begin to work with your client on another exercise (the Continuum of Progress or Self-Observations of the Big Assumption are natural next steps).

Purpose and Benefits

- ✓ To help your client determine if he has identified a sufficiently powerful 1st column goal or whether he needs to make revisions to his goal.
- ✓ To provide your client with baseline data on how selected others see his current performance on his 1st column goal. This gives data to compare/contrast with future changes. It also provides a picture beyond his personal perspective.
- ✓ To discover whether there are additional 2nd column behaviors.
- ✓ To communicate your client's intention to change to selected others.
- ✓ To maintain or increase your client's motivation to change by creating an 'audience' or set of 'witnesses'.

Three General Points about the ITC Survey

1. The ITC survey is highly focused. It is designed to generate data singularly relevant to the 1st column changes a person wants to make, consists of only a few questions (typically 6), to be completed by 6-8 respondents; and it takes them 15 minutes or less to complete. We point this out because we know the mere mention of the word “survey” can elicit all kinds

of less-than-enthusiastic associations, with images of a 360-item, 360-degree, hour-long epic to be completed by 360 of one’s closest friends, family members, associates, and clients.

2. A survey serves multiple purposes. At the simplest level, a survey generates “metrics” early in the process in order to collect baseline data on the participant’s current behaviors from other people’s perspectives. These data enable a client to learn about his impact on others (specifically the behaviors his Big Assumption generates) and their perception of him (which may be quite different from his). Specific examples provided by respondents may help to increase your client’s awareness of his actions. Also, people’s comments can reinforce, if not increase, the value your client already sees in pursuing his goal.

At a more complex level, sending a survey communicates a person’s intention to change. By deliberately letting a few people in on her 1st column goal early on—people who are in a position to notice differences in her behavior as they occur—a client can feel greater accountability and persistence (i.e., simply seeing people can remind her to stay focused on her goal). Additionally, it puts others in a position to provide her quality feedback at the end of the change program, as well as spontaneous observations and input along the way.

Because we will also measure those very same behaviors later, creating metrics at the very beginning of the coaching work also signals that: a) *we expect the participant will progress and make strides in meeting her Column 1 commitment*, and b) *progress is not an internal experience only, but manifests itself in actual behaviors and events that other people can see*.

3. Not all clients will have a survey and that is fine. The most common reasons why clients *don’t* do a survey are these:

Some 1st column goals don’t lend themselves to input. Here are a few examples: if the commitment is completely internally-focused (e.g., “I am committed to being kinder to myself when I screw up”), or is focused on a particular relationship (e.g., “I am committed to standing up to my boss”) or has specific personal standards (e.g., “I am committed to exercising five times a week for at least an hour each time”). It’s not impossible for a client to identify others who would be in a position to observe changes on these kinds of goals, but it could be much more difficult.

Your client does not want others to know what he is working on, perhaps because it is too personal, he feels too vulnerable, or it feels too risky.

There is not enough time in the coaching contract for the survey process (drafting it and waiting for people to respond).

To ground our discussion of the purposes of the survey and how to build one, let's take a look at a typical one:

Deconstructing the ITC Survey

1. *The area Al has chosen to work on is to deal more directly with situations and circumstances that may involve conflict, confrontation, and uncomfortable or “negative” feelings. To what extent do you experience Al dealing directly with these issues WITH YOU?*

1 = Not at all

10 = Very frequently

2. *To what extent do you experience Al dealing directly with these issues WITH OTHERS?*

1 = Not at all

10 = Very frequently

3. *COMMENTS: Please take a minute to expand on this quick take, e.g., any further thoughts, explaining what you mean, giving examples, will be helpful.*

4. *As you think about just this aspect of Al's functioning, **how important to the office would you consider his making significant improvement?***

1 = Not at all

10 = Very frequently

5. *Why do you say so? In what ways would it matter/not matter? (We know these take a moment, but they are extremely helpful to Al and his coach. The more particular you can be, the better).*

6. *If this is NOT an area you think Al should be working on, what alternative suggestions do you have?*

You'll notice that the first two questions are almost the same, and they both use the same scale; the only difference is that the first question asks about the respondent's personal, one-to-one experience with the person whose survey it is, whereas the second question asks about the respondent's view of how that person interacts with others. We ask both of these questions in order to elicit a fuller picture of the client's behaviors; it is not uncommon for a respondent's self-report to differ from how he sees the client behaving with other people. Asking both questions also reduces potential biases that might come from asking only “supporters” to participate in the survey.

All the remaining questions are standardized. We ask how important achieving the goal is (typically, question #4) because there is a significant difference between *identifying* an area for growth as opposed to seeing the *importance and value of achieving* that goal. Indeed, respondents' answers on Q1, Q2 and Q3 can indicate that there is room for improvement on this goal (one of the criteria for a quality Column 1 goal), but respondents do not believe that the goal is important to accomplish.

Ultimately, it is the client's assessment of how important that goal is that matters most; hearing other people's perspectives can deepen or reinforce his belief in its importance or it can lead him to question why he sees it as important while others don't. (Sometimes people do change their goal after receiving feedback. More typically, they make slight edits, if they change it at all). Of course, these decisions get more complicated when the client is participating in ITC coaching as part of an organizational change process. In such cases, the organizational context may circumscribe the type of Column 1 goal a client can select. For example, if the organization has been striving (and struggling) to decentralize decision making, they may want each person's Column 1 goal to focus on what she needs to get better at if decentralization is going to happen successfully. Or, a leadership team may decide that its members all need to do a better job of holding each other accountable for moving team projects forward. Each member of that team may select a Column 1 goal that represents what he needs to get better at to hold others on the team more accountable. In such cases, the opinions of survey respondents may carry more weight for the client if she is deliberating about her Column 1 goal.

Together, the results of these three questions (Q1, Q2, Q4) provide a quick picture of the respondents' assessments of the need for improvement and level of importance. The remaining three items (Q3, Q5, Q6) are all open-ended questions that invite the respondents to bring that picture to life by providing examples or explanations.

Brief Example of the Benefits of Doing an ITC Survey

Cathy opted to do a survey and asked all of her 7 team members to be respondents. Their input confirmed Cathy's assessment that her single most important improvement goal in relation to working better with her team was around her emotions and how she expressed them. Their input, especially the examples, helped Cathy see that the issue was broader than she saw it and she adjusted her goal accordingly. As is often the case, Cathy's improvement goal simultaneously spoke to her gifts or strengths, and her team's early input clearly celebrated this, leading Cathy to feel understood and appreciated. Team data from a survey 6-months later was also very helpful, confirming Cathy's assessment that she had made huge strides. People's specific examples of how they saw her better handling her emotions with them and others allowed Cathy to know that she wasn't fooling herself into believing she had changed. Their input provided a "reality check."

Help your client make an informed choice about whether to do the survey. Since the word “survey” can set off a set of immediate reactions (in either direction), it’s worth having an example of a survey handy (on paper or in your mind) so that you can ground your client’s understanding of this particular type of survey. In our experience, most people have not had such a focused survey, and when they see the type of specific questions, they quickly understand what it is and its intent.

Engaging your Client in this Exercise

The coach’s job, at this point, is to answer questions and listen for and respond to the client’s feelings about the survey and possible consequences. Then, the client can make the decision that is right for him. The coach’s job is not to persuade the client here. Here are a few examples of what your client may ask:

- Will people (i.e., my boss) other than you see the results?
- Will the respondents think I’m on probation?
- How will I know who to ask?
- What happens if people tell me they don’t think I need to improve on my goal?
- What do I say to people to let them know about this?
- What happens if I don’t agree with what people say?
- I’d like to know who says what. Is that okay?

It’s important that you feel confident that you can answer these questions. By the time you finish reading this chapter, we hope that you will be able to answer these questions confidently.

It’s also important that you hear what may be behind your client’s questions. It’s safe to bet that behind each of these questions is a feeling. Take a moment to think what you imagine someone might be feeling.

What might someone be feeling when they ask a lot of questions about including a survey in her coaching journey?

Expect a range of responses from clients when you ask whether they want to include a survey, from people who want to do one before you even explain what it is, to others who outright reject the idea. While people's reactions may be attributed to their personal preferences, we've also come to see that the organization's culture can make a very big difference (again, in either direction).

You may want to have a more general discussion about the valuable **role of feedback** throughout the coaching work. Here are some points to consider for your discussion:

Feedback provides information about what other people are seeing/experiencing and not. We often have a different picture of ourselves than others have of us. Others often see our developmental challenges more clearly than we can see ourselves (just as we can see their challenges more clearly than they can!). This is not a bad thing; this is the nature of being human.

Hearing from others about the impact your behavior is having on them can help motivate you to change. Sometimes we just don't know or see our impact and so are comfortable with things as they are.

On-going feedback provides information that can help point to areas of growth; the participant can use such feedback as information that his new attempts to act differently are getting the results he intended. It also points to areas for continued growth.

Feedback provides information for the coaching process; it helps both the coach and participant to learn what's working (and draw on successes) and to focus and target their work.

Different rationales will have differing appeal to people.

Here are a few points should you want to have a general discussion about the **value of survey results**. Different rationales will have differing appeal to people, and depending on who you are working with, some of the following explanations may not apply as well. In any case, the goal is not to try to talk a client into anything but to have a discussion about what is in her learning interests:

- The organization the participant works for values results. Surveys are a reliable means to gather data about results.
- Measurement can help keep people stay focused on the developmental work over time; mostly "you get what you measure."
- You, the coach, are confident the participant will make progress and you need a way to measure such progress. Survey results make the progress more visible, and also help to keep both the coach and participant honest about progress.
- This baseline survey will provide both coach and participant information about where to begin to focus their work.

- Because the survey targets specific respondents, the participant can get feedback from those people she most wants to hear from.
- Surveys generate a bigger and clearer picture of one's progress than when the person relies on spontaneous feedback, which tends to focus on one area by one person.
- Surveys can generate higher quality information than face-to-face feedback since the respondent feels freer to be honest, given the confidentiality of the survey. Also, the respondent is not required to be a skillful feedback giver, as the interviewer's questions and understanding of what she means will lead to better quality information (and information that is more likely to be "hearable" by the recipient).
- When on their own, the natural tendency of almost all people is to selectively attend to data. This selectivity ranges from attending only to the "good news" to attending only to the "bad news." Surveys increase the quality of all news, whether favorable or not.

Let your client know that he would have a hand in many aspects of the survey, including the wording of questions, the timing of the survey, and who he asks to respond. Depending on your client's decision, this may be the time to go over the material in Appendix E (Logistics of the Survey-Interview).

Let's say your client decides he wants to include a survey. Now what?

More than any other immunity-to-change exercise, including a survey in the coaching journey involves many details. We don't say this to discourage you! Instead, once you know these and can follow their flow, we expect you'll find it relatively straightforward to do one. For ease, we have identified two phases in doing a survey: one is collecting the data, and the second is debriefing your clients on the results.

Conducting the ITC Survey, from Soup to Nuts (& Bolts)

Phase I: Collecting the Data

There are two basic steps involved in collecting your client's data. These include:

1. Drafting the survey questions, getting your client's input and finalizing the questions; and

2. Getting the selected respondents' agreement to participate, getting accurate email contact information for all agreeing respondents and sending them (including your client) the survey, along with information about when and to whom to return the survey.

If you are using the *Immunity-to-Change Workbook* with your client, you can send her the survey description after you have first discussed whether this will be a useful exercise for her (See Appendix A).

As you can see from the *Immunity-to-Change Workbook* description, there are many sub-steps, some of which are for you, the coach, and others are for your client to execute. The following chart briefly summarizes each of your responsibilities.

	Coach	Client
Develop the survey	a. Drafts a survey for client input (or do this together during a coaching session) c. If needed, initiates discussion with client to finalize survey	b. Responds to draft, may make edits (or does this with coach during a coaching session) d. Gives the go-ahead for wording
Getting the survey out and returned	e. Initiates discussion with client re: criteria for selecting respondents h. Sends survey, with info re: when and to whom to return it i. Sends email reminder, if necessary to non-responders close to return date	f. Identifies all respondents and contacts them for inclusion g. Sends coach names and current email info for all agreeing respondents

Drafting the Survey. The most challenging of all these steps is likely to be drafting the survey itself. So let's focus now on the specifics of how to design quality questions. We've included the ITC Survey Template below in the simplest form to remind you of the basic questions we ask. Note: You have the option of preparing a personalized draft survey for your client's input (and sending it in advance of your conversation), or bringing the generic template into your coaching session and working up the question text together. If you opt to bring in a personalized draft of the questions, make sure you emphasize that what you have is a *draft*.

The typical ITC survey has six questions. (If your client's goal has multiple parts, there will be eight questions.) Here are a few examples of a multi-faceted goal:

"To become better organized and be a better delegator."

"To communicate more clearly in my written work and my stated expectations."

"To give feedback more directly and in a more timely way."

If the goal contains the word "and," chances are pretty good that you have a compound goal.

ITC Survey Template

The area <name here> is working to get better at is _____.

1. *Some form of:* How often does <name here> do this *WITH YOU*?
Scale here: 1 – 10
Note: If you have a compound goal, you will have one more "WITH YOU" question here.
2. *Some form of:* How often do you see <name here> do this *WITH OTHERS*?
Scale here: 1 - 10
Note: If you have a compound goal, you will have one more "WITH OTHERS" question here.
3. **COMMENTS:** Please take a minute to expand on this quick take, e.g., any further thoughts, explaining what you mean, giving examples, will be helpful.
4. As you think about <name here> goal, how important would it be <to the team/the organization/his life> if <name here> made significant strides?
Scale here: 1 – 10
5. Why do you say so? In what ways would it matter/not matter? (The more particular you can be, the better).
6. If you *don't* think this is a high-value improvement goal for <name here>, what alternative might you suggest?

Crafting Question #1. A good question should a) be clearly phrased so that the reader knows the goal your client is working on, b) include an implied scale (vs. require a simple “yes” or “no” response) and c) be something another person *can* know about your client. You are asking about behaviors (or attitudes expressed via behaviors) *that others can observe*. To be clear, you are not asking for advice or for the person to make any inferences about your client.

As an example, let’s say your client’s goal is to be better organized. You could turn this into a quality survey question by asking, “***To what extent*** do you experience <name here> as being organized when she works with you?” Or you might ask, “***How frequently*** do you experience <name here> as being organized when she works with you?” By contrast, you would not want to ask something like, “How organized a person do you think <name here> is?” since this is asking for about the respondents’ attributions about your client. We want to ask, instead, about the respondents own experience of your client, since this is all they really know.

Often, basic survey questions can be developed directly and easily from the 1st Column Commitment. Ralph’s Column 1 goal, “To be a better listener” is straightforward to put into a survey question: “How often do you experience that Ralph listens to you?” Embedded in the question is a continuum, “How often,” so that the respondents can assess the frequency (vs. absence or presence) of their experience of the targeted behavior.

Keeping in mind that there is no one way to phrase the question, here’s one for you to try:

Sally’s goal is “to be a better delegator.” What is a quality survey question?

Don't peek if you haven't tried answering this first! How about this: "How frequently does Sally delegate tasks to you?" That's a fine way to ask Q1. Let's compare that with an example of what we would not want to ask so you know what an off-track version looks like: "How frequently does Sally take on tasks that she ought to delegate to others?" How would you characterize the problem with this question? What do you think? The problem we see is that the respondent can't know what Sally "ought" to delegate.

If you want to get fancy, you could ask about the quality of your client's delegation, in which case you could add a next question: "When Sally delegates work to you, to what extent are her expectations clear?" or whatever your client wants to know about the quality of her delegating (e.g., whether the respondent feels she is respectful of his time or gives him enough time to complete the work). You may find that your client's Column 2 entries are helpful in pointing to what specific feedback she wants from respondents. That said, it's fine to stay with the simplest version of the question, assuming that people will comment in item #3 if they want to highlight something.

Beyond Question #1. Once you have crafted the first question, the rest is rather straightforward (unless you have a compound goal, in which case you will be creating an additional question). The Likert scale for the question is based on however you chose to word the question itself, and Q2 simply restates that question and asks "WITH OTHERS." The remaining open-ended questions are standardized. Our one caution is to make sure you have labeled the Likert scale clearly and in a way that matches the question. Most people will automatically interpret a 1 as "low" and a 10 as "high." Use that information to help your respondents to provide the answer they really mean.

Examples of standard ways of framing a question include:

"How consistent....?"

"How frequently/ how often ...?"

"How much....?"

"To what extent...?"

"How effective...?"

Following are a few examples of questions with their accompanying scales:

How effective a listener do you currently experience Allison to be WITH YOU?	
1 = Ineffective	10 = Extremely Effective
How frequently do you experience Carlos as being creative and intellectually risk-taking WITH YOU?	
1 = Not at all	10 = All the time
To what extent do you experience Darlene as having a generous attitude when she gives feedback TO OTHERS?	
1 = Not at all	10 = Very much so
To what extent do you experience Vijay as curbing a tendency toward over-working in his involvements WITH OTHERS?	
1 = Not at all	10 = To a very great extent

Get Input From Your Client. Remember that this is a draft you are creating, and you need to get your client's input. Now that he sees the survey, is he still game to do one? (Sometimes people get cold feet once there is something concrete). Does the survey capture what he wants to learn from others? Is there different wording he would prefer? Sometimes clients want to ask questions that are not part of the ITC template. Whether you include them or not is up to you. Our main recommendation is that you keep the survey short, since it makes it more likely that respondents will respond.

Selecting Respondents. Of all the sub-steps in the first phase of survey, developing the survey questions deserves the most attention. (If you'd like more practice, we've included a few draft surveys at the end of this chapter to analyze.) Once the survey questions are set, ask your client to think about who his optimal respondents are in light of these criteria: 1) they are people who see him in action and know him well enough so that they can answer the questions and provide examples from their experience with him, 2) they are in the best position to also notice changes were he to make them, and 3) they are a mix of

people, including those who he thinks are his toughest critics or from whom he thinks he has something to learn. In some cases, friends and family might be perfectly appropriate, but in others, they might be less likely to be candid and honest. Or it may be too difficult to preserve respondent confidentiality after you compile all the respondent comments. Attempt to get “objective” respondents as well. You may choose to emphasize that your client not “stack the deck” by asking only those people who he thinks regard his performance highly. Remind him that the point of the survey is to get targeted input on his goal so that he can have a realistic picture of himself. You can also remind that that he will find out whether the goal he identified is one that others also think would be a valuable goal for him to work towards. The optimal number of respondents is between 6 – 8, including himself (too many people, and there may be too much data, and too few people makes it tricky to maintain confidentiality).

We suggest that the client should respond to her own survey for a couple of reasons. First, her responses can then be directly compared with others’. Does she think her improvement goal is much more important than others do? Is she tougher on herself than others are? Second, since clients usually rate themselves pretty low in terms of their current practices related to their goals, completing their own surveys can help them to feel more psychologically prepared to receive low rankings from others.

Let’s assume that you have sent the survey out and everyone, including your client, has responded. Now what?

Phase 2: Debriefing your Client on the Survey Results

The three basic steps involved in survey debriefing are:

1. Preparing the data to share with your client;
2. Preparing yourself for the discussion by making sense of the data; and
3. Having the debrief session.

You may opt to send the data in advance of your meeting so that your client has the opportunity to digest the material before your discussion. All of these points are elaborated in the chart below, along with accompanying text.

	Coach	Client
Prepare data for sharing with client	Aggregate the data; remove any identifying comments or words; include client's own responses for comparison.	
Prepare for debrief	Agree upon date for debrief. Review data: What are key learning points? How does your client's self-assessment compare to other people's views? How might your client respond to the data? Which comments or ideas might be the hardest for your client to hear? How likely is it that your discussion may activate your client's immune system? If viable, decide whether to communicate the results via phone call or in person. Decide whether to send data in advance of debrief session. If yes, send cover message along with data, along perhaps with a few prompts (see Appendix D for an example). Further planning for debrief: Consider what you can say/ do to increase the chances that your client will get the most use from the survey responses. Of the number of points or insights from the data, what are the most significant ones?	Agrees upon date for debrief. Reads the data. Perhaps makes note in response to coach's reflection questions.
Have the debrief session	Understand how your client makes sense of the data. Use both listening hats. Determine whether there are any changes to your client's map (his goal, and 2nd column).	

Preparing the data to share with your client. A starting place is to simply aggregate the data so that everyone's responses are organized by question. Choose a way to separate your client's responses (e.g., put his words in italics or in a different color). So that respondents' confidentiality can be maintained, *remove any identifying comments or words.*

Preparing yourself for the discussion by making sense of the data. Review the data wearing your ITC coach's hat:

What does it suggest about your client's 1st column goal? Do respondents, overall, see that there is room for improvement? Do they believe that the goal is important for your client to achieve? Are respondents' scores similar (or clustered) or are they all over the Likert scale? If the latter, how do you make sense of that? Something worth keeping in mind here, as with any survey when you are asking for people's input: their feedback is as much a reflection of them as it is about your client. Another consideration is the respondent pool, i.e., people's role or in/formal relationship might contribute to disparate scores.

How do your client's responses to the survey compare with the respondents' assessments of her? If there is a wide range here, one thing to consider is whether your client's immunity might be at work. Someone, for example, can score himself quite low in keeping with a Big Assumption about his worth. Another person's self-score might be higher than others' and this might reflect her commitment to e.g., being superior. A different scenario is if respondents collectively don't agree that your client needs to improve, or that the goal is important. In the end, the goal your client chooses to pursue ought to be his own choosing whenever possible. We say this (even if the person paying for the immunity coaching is the coachee's boss) because we believe that the person's development will be better served if he can follow his own choices. In addition, a client's motivation to work on overcoming an immunity is typically greater when she "owns" the goal herself.

Are there any new behaviors that should be in the client's 2nd column?

Are there any general patterns or themes?

Now take a look at your analysis in light of what you know about your client:

How might she respond to the data? Which comments or ideas might be the hardest for her to hear? How likely is it that your discussion may activate your client's immune system?

In addition to helping you to prepare for debriefing your client, your answer to these types of questions will help you to decide how you want to ask your client to prepare. Do you want to send her the results in advance of your meeting?

A final preparation decision is around the actual data you will share with your client and how you want to present it.

Are there pieces of data that you think should not be shared with your client? Comments that are highly critical may be hard for your client to hear verbatim. There may also be comments that are inappropriate or off-the-mark in another way and should be discarded (e.g., “I’m glad that Cliff is working on preserving a better work/life balance. I guess what I am really hoping is that he’ll get a divorce and get on some Prozac.”).

How much of the actual comments do you think should be shared? Comments are valuable, and yet too many of them may obscure the main point.

Do you want to organize the data by theme? Or more simply, by question?

Are there other steps you need to take to preserve the confidentiality of the survey respondents (e.g., scramble the order in which you list the comments, take out identifying details, paraphrase or summarize, etc.)?

These decisions will be made on a case-by-case basis depending on the nature of the feedback.

Whether you choose to send your client the data in advance of your debriefing session, or present the data to him for the first time when you together review it, it’s good to remind him of the purpose of the survey and that it is a unique way of requesting feedback, i.e., that the survey specifically asked people *to rate him on an area he identified as one of his weaknesses*. This is the kind of thing we sometimes say to set the stage for the debrief: “You bravely asked people to reflect on the one big thing you most wanted to improve or would benefit from developing. So hopefully, they have shared their candid responses! Let’s see what there is to learn from them as well as your own responses in relation to their input.”

If you send your client data before you meet, it’s also good to send a few questions for him to take to his reading of the survey. (See the *Immunity-to-Change Workbook* for a set of reflection questions. You can send that specific page along with the data, or you can choose just a few of them.)

Having the Debrief Session. If you have done all your preparation, perhaps the most important thing to keep in mind during the debrief conversation is the need for you to wear both listening hats: one, the empathic listener, the other, listening for ITC material. The survey reflection questions will focus what you will be listening for with your Immunity-to-Change-listening hat, so let’s touch on the need to listen for your client’s feelings.

For some people, this feedback is the first time they have received any written input. For almost all clients, it is the first time they are getting input from other people about their selected goal. While it’s logical to think that every client should know that other people may score them as low as they score themselves on their current performance specific to the goal, people can still have a lot of feelings should the scores turn out that way. Some people feel bad about having their growing edge be seen and acknowledged by others. Feelings of shame or defensiveness may emerge. Sometimes people have a part of them that is hoping that they are being too hard on themselves and that others will see their performance more favorably. They may feel disappointed learning that other people see them similarly.

It is not uncommon for coachees to be curious about who said what in the surveys. This is especially the case if there was a highly negative score(s) or comment(s). Again, both listening hats are important here. It will be helpful for you to provide space for her to reflect on her feelings; this may or may not address her need to know. On the Immunity-to-Change front, be prepared to remind your client that respondents were promised confidentiality.

Resources for this exercise: See Appendices A-E.

Tips and Pitfalls

Coach's Tips for ITC Survey

1. Remember to use both listening hats throughout the survey process. *Overall Tips*
2. Introduce a next ITC exercise to keep the momentum going with your client while her survey data is coming in.
3. The *Immunity-to-Change Workbook* contains a lot of written material to help your client understand and participate in the survey process.
4. Don't assume that a survey is necessary. An internal goal typically is not a goal on which others can provide feedback. *Deciding on the survey*
5. Give your client the information necessary for her to make an informed decision about whether she wants a survey.
6. If your client decides to do a survey, she needs to weigh in on the questions and choose the right group of people as respondents. Help her to do this by sharing the relevant criteria. *Gathering data phase*
7. Create a timeline for the survey with your client. If possible, work towards a 2-week completion date in an effort to maximize getting baseline data.
8. Consider using a customizable on-line survey program, such as Boomerang, to make administering the survey easier for you.
9. Anticipate your client's reactions to the data and present the data accordingly. *Debriefing phase*
10. Use the reflection questions to guide your preparation for the debrief and your conversation with your client.



Potential Pitfalls. Challenges for the coach fall into one of two buckets: the technical aspects of the survey, and/or the interpersonal dimension.

Coach	Client
<i>Deciding on the survey:</i> The coach focuses on the purpose and/or logistics of the survey and not sufficiently on the client's emotional responses (e.g., coach interprets a "yes" or "ok" as genuine agreement from the client). In the most extreme, the coach unduly influences the client (and may be unaware of this) while the client is not actually committed to doing the survey.	Is worried about having the survey yet does not tell the coach. Sees the coach as in charge of and responsible for the learning process.
<i>Gathering data phase:</i> The survey is not worded well: the questions are vague or do not ask about the client's goal, and/or the Likert scale wording is confusing.	Sees the coach as the expert on surveys and does not partner with him. Doesn't "own" the process.
The coach uncritically accepts the client's revisions to the survey and loses track of the importance of how the questions and the response options are worded.	Feels and remains defensive.
<i>Debriefing phase:</i> Coach has a vested interest in her interpretation of the data. Does not listen well to client's feelings and/or interpretation of the data.	Sees the coach as the expert interpreter. Does not necessarily understand. Doesn't "own" the interpretation.
Does not tune into client's feelings	Feels and remains defensive.
Coach's own immune system gets activated around giving people critical feedback.	May miss important learning that could result from survey, were feedback given more effectively.
Misses the ways that client's immune system is activated by survey.	Triggers BA(s). Cannot benefit much from survey feedback without further work on overturning her immune system; may have compromised momentum, motivation, trust, etc.

In-depth Examples: Jackson & Amanda

Both Jackson and Amanda felt they learned a great deal from their surveys, and we include them here to illustrate, in part, how the process can be adapted to fit particular circumstances.

Jackson's Survey

Jackson has chosen to work on “*getting better at publicizing my accomplishments with senior management.*”

1. How well does Jackson take opportunities to let senior management know of his accomplishments without sounding like he is bragging or being arrogant?
1 = Not very well 10 = Very well
2. Could Jackson self-publicize more often without sounding like he is bragging or being arrogant?
1 = Not at all 10 = To a great extent
3. Comments:

- 1 = Not at all 10 = Yes

Version 2

1. When you observe Jackson interacting with senior management, how often does Jackson take opportunities to publicize his accomplishments?

1 = Not at all 10 = All the time

- 1 = Not at all 10 = To a great extent

4. Do you think this is the right area for Jackson to be working on?

1 = Not at all 10 = Yes

- ould you suggest?

Summary of Jackson's Survey Results

1. When you observe Jackson interacting with senior management, how often does Jackson take opportunities to publicize his accomplishments?

1 = Not at all

10 = All the time

Respondent Scores: 3, 3, 4, 5, 5, 5

Average (Mean) Score: 4.2

Self Score: 4

2. When you observe Jackson interacting with senior management about his accomplishments, to what extent does he communicate what he has accomplished effectively?

1 = Not at all

10 = To a great extent

Respondent Scores: 1, 2, 2, 3, 3, 4

Average (Mean) Score: 2.5

Self Score: 3

3. Comments:

- *He admits his accomplishments only when he is directly asked to report, and then he is pretty short, direct, too modest and humorous. He'll never get noticed this way.*
- *Jackson never lets them know the full extent of his talents and achievements. This contrasts sharply with others who tend to exaggerate. It also means that he gets overlooked when he shouldn't be.*
- *I have been telling him to do this for YEARS. I'm glad he is finally listening to me.*
- *Senior management knows that he has a great reputation with colleagues and those who work for him. But they don't really know why everyone likes him so much. Jackson needs to let them know!*
- *Jackson always makes decisions with XXX (the company's) interest in mind – but it's a well-kept secret.*
- *He's too much a team player. I watch Jackson allow others to take center stage, while he acts like they should be receiving praise and accolades. It makes me angry because then the ones who don't deserve this recognition continue to get it. Jackson, make them get out of your way! And not just by telling a joke!*
- *I understand this kind of thing (praise) makes him uncomfortable, and I worry that he is getting passed by.*
- *Jackson has a great sense of humor, but he lets the jokes get in the way of his message.*

4. Do you think this is the right area for Jackson to be working on?

1 = Not at all

10 = Yes

Respondent Scores: 8, 8, 9, 9, 9, 10

Average (Mean) Score: 8.8

Self Score: 9

5. If this is not the area you think Jackson should be working on, what alternatives would you suggest?

Comments:

- *If Jackson gets better at this, he should be senior management in 2-3 years.*
- *This would complete the picture – he does everything else well.*
- *I hope he does work on this!*
- *I think he could also be gaining more international experience if he took a larger role in (names project).*

Reflection Question	Your Response
What, if anything, does the data suggest regarding your Column 1 Commitment? (i.e., do the results suggest that you have targeted a powerful Column 1 Commitment?)	Yes
What, if anything, does the data suggest regarding your Column 2 behaviors? (i.e., are there additional Column 2 behaviors to add to your map?)	Yes. Three respondents noted that I am too self-deprecating, which they seem to think is fine with anyone BUT senior management. One person noted that I am “too much a team player.” One person said that I appear “uncomfortable with praise.”
What, if anything, does the data suggest regarding your Big Assumption?	Well, nobody sent out warnings about me getting too arrogant or blind to my faults. That surprised me. I wonder if because they know me, they would be less likely to see me that way, even if my behavior changed. I was also kind of impressed that they seem pretty generous in their estimations of my work and how high they think I could go at XXX. Makes me realize that maybe I’ve been assuming that I’ve almost maxed out my potential.

Reflection Question	Your Response
Compare your responses with those of your respondents: • What's similar? • Where are the differences? • What's your take on those differences?	Similarities: Using humor as a defense, as easy-out. Differences: They like me more than I do? (ha ha.)
What are your "take-aways" from thinking about this data?	What should be the limits of my ambitions? Who do I want to be when I grow up?

Jackson's coach agreed with many of the insights Jackson had taken from the survey, and their conversation helped to explore some additional possibilities Jackson had not previously considered.

Reflection Question	Your Response
What, if anything, does the data suggest regarding your Column 1 Commitment? (i.e., do the results suggest that you have targeted a powerful Column 1 Commitment?)	Yes.
What, if anything, does the data suggest regarding your Column 2 behaviors? (i.e., are there additional Column 2 behaviors to add to your map?)	Yes. 3 respondents noted that I am too self-deprecating, which they seem to think is fine with anyone BUT senior management. One person noted that I am "too much a team player." One person said that I appear "uncomfortable with praise."
What, if anything, does the data suggest regarding your Big Assumption?	Well, nobody sent out warnings about me getting too arrogant or blind to my faults. That surprised me. I wonder if because they know me, they would be less likely to see me that way, even if my behavior changed. It could also be that I am particularly sensitive to seeing self-promotion as bragging, and others don't feel like that danger is always lurking nearby. Or they don't care – that bragging is sort of normal in modern American business life, perhaps. Makes me realize how my own train of thought may be very unique to me in a way I hadn't really considered before. Huh!

Reflection Question	Your Response
	I was also kind of impressed that they seem pretty generous in their estimations of my work and how high they think I could go at XXX. Makes me realize that maybe I've been assuming that I've almost maxed out my potential.
Compare your responses with those of your respondents. - What's similar? - Where are the differences? - What's your take on those differences?	Similarities: Using humor as a defense, as easy-out Differences: They like me more than I do? (ha ha.)
What are your "take-aways" from thinking about this data?	What should be the limits of my ambitions? Who do I want to be when I grow up? There may be a connection between my distaste for self-promotion and my hesitancy to be ambitious in thinking about my long-term career goals.

Amanda's Survey

Amanda was very interested in doing an ITC survey, primarily because she felt that it was a good way to let close friends, co-workers, and family know what she was working on, and to enlist them as aids and supporters of her efforts. However, she did not feel like she had any idea of how to construct a survey that could also potentially provide her with useful information. "I mean, what should I be asking them?" she wondered aloud to her coach, "something like how much weight do they think I need to lose?"

Amanda's coach suggested some possible types of information they might find valuable:

- To find out if there might be specific contexts in which Amanda eats better than others.
- To find out if there are specific unhealthy foods that Amanda is more likely to indulge in.
- To find out if the people in Amanda's immediate network have accurate ideas of what foods are healthy, and how much food is appropriate.
- To find out how closely Amanda's responses compare with those in her network.

Amanda agreed that those might all be issues worth exploring, although she didn't know how to draft survey questions to generate this type of data. Her coach then suggested that she would draft the survey herself and email it to Amanda for her to review. Here is the draft:

Amanda is committed to improving her health. She intends to do this by developing healthier eating habits.

1. To what extent do you observe Amanda eating in ways you would consider healthy?
1 = Rarely eating healthily 10 = Always eating healthily
2. When you observe Amanda eating, to what extent does she choose unhealthy foods to eat?
1 = Rarely eating healthy foods 10 = Always eating healthy foods
3. When you observe Amanda eating, to what extent does she eat too much food?
1 = Rarely eating too much food 10 = Always eating too much food
4. Please provide some specific examples of what Amanda typically eats and how much she typically eats:
5. If improving her eating habits is NOT the most important area you think Amanda should be working on to improve her health, **what alternative suggestions do you have?**

Amanda liked the survey draft and quickly made arrangements to arrange for her respondents to receive a copy to complete.

Amanda's Survey Results

1. To what extent do you observe Amanda eating in ways you would consider healthy?
1 = Rarely eating healthily 10 = Always eating healthily
Respondent Scores: 2, 4, 5, 5, 7, 7
Average (Mean) Score: 5
Self Score: 3
2. When you observe Amanda eating, to what extent does she choose unhealthy foods to eat?
1 = Rarely eating healthy foods 10 = Always eating healthy foods
Respondent Scores: 4, 4, 7, 7, 8, 9
Average (Mean) Score: 6.5
Self Score: 4
3. When you observe Amanda eating, to what extent does she eat too much food?
1 = Rarely eating too much food 10 = Always eating too much food
Respondent Scores: 3, 3, 3, 4, 7, 8
Average (Mean) Score: 4.7
Self Score: 8

4. Please provide some specific examples of what Amanda typically eats and how much she typically eats:
 - *Normal food – take-out from local restaurants. I guess she eats what they give her, one serving.*
 - *I don't see her every day. At family gatherings, she seems to eat a regular amount. Maybe snacks too much? Too many sweets?*
 - *She usually eats better than I do – eats more vegetables, salads, and fruits than I do. And she eats less. But because I am a man, I'm not sure how much women are supposed to eat.*
 - *I don't really notice (N=2).*
5. If improving her eating habits is NOT the most important area you think Amanda should be working on to improve her health, **what alternative suggestions do you have?**
 - *She's fine.*
 - *You can do it, Amanda!*
 - *Well, I guess more exercise would be the logical thing.*

Reflection Question	Your Response
What, if anything, does the data suggest regarding your Column 1 Commitment? (i.e., do the results suggest that you have targeted a powerful Column 1 Commitment?)	It is very powerful to me, but I can see that others don't really care about it.
What, if anything, does the data suggest regarding your Column 2 behaviors? (i.e., are there additional Column 2 behaviors to add to your map?)	I guess that they are normal things lots of people do.
What, if anything, does the data suggest regarding your Big Assumption?	??
Compare your responses with those of your respondents. • What's similar? • Where are the differences? • What's your take on those differences?	I think I'm harder on myself than they are.
What are your "take-aways" from thinking about this data?	??

After reading Amanda's survey results and her reflections, her coach took note of the patterns she recognized and decided to discuss them with Amanda in their next session. In particular, she noticed:

- Amanda's respondents seem unaware of how much and what Amanda eats. It seems likely that their own eating habits are similarly unhealthy. If they are to be supports to Amanda, they may need to be educated in how to do that.
- If Amanda gets her own understanding of what portion size and type of food is "normal" from those around her, her own standards will likely be poor.

When they next met to reflect further on the survey results, her coach raised these issues for discussion, and they talked further about what the survey results might tell them.

Version 2

Reflection Question	Your Response
What, if anything, does the data suggest regarding your Column 1 Commitment? (i.e., do the results suggest that you have targeted a powerful Column 1 Commitment?)	It is very powerful to me, but I can see that others don't really care about it. If I want them to support me in changing my habits, I'm going to need to be really clear with them about why this is important to me so that they can help.
What, if anything, does the data suggest regarding your Column 2 behaviors? (i.e., are there additional Column 2 behaviors to add to your map?)	I guess that they are normal things lots of people do. That tells me that maybe the people around me don't have healthy habits either, or else maybe they are not paying much attention to what I eat. Maybe I eat stuff sort of secretly, and so they don't know about it? Their answers make sense to me because I often feel like I eat the way others do, so why am I fat if they're not?
What, if anything, does the data suggest regarding your Big Assumption?	Maybe part of the reason I feel like I deserve food is because I see what others eat and feel like I should have that too. I'm as deserving as they are. (Add to map: I assume that I should be able to eat what others eat and look the way they do. I assume that they all don't have to think about what they eat at all and don't have any negative results from bad habits.)

Reflection Question	Your Response
Compare your responses with those of your respondents. • What's similar? • Where are the differences? • What's your take on those differences?	I think I'm harder on myself than they are.
What are your "take-aways" from thinking about this data?	If I want others to support me, I'm going to have to be really clear with them about how they can help. I also realize that I have been jumping to conclusions (assuming) that I know what (and how much) they eat, and whether they have health issues or not – even though I don't really know this.

Practice Time: Over to You

As a reminder, a good question should:

1. Be clearly phrased so that the reader knows the goal your client is working on;
2. Include an implied scale (vs. require a simple "Yes" or "No" response); and
3. Be something another person can know about your client. You are asking about behaviors (or attitudes expressed via behaviors) *that others can observe*. To be clear, you are not asking for advice or for the person to make any inferences about your client.

Exercise 1

Below is a draft survey. Read it through first, and then analyze the strengths and areas for improvement.

Callie has chosen to make her passions for art and helping people become more financially self-sustaining and personally fulfilling.

(Please put an "X" to the right of your number response. If you feel you don't have enough information to answer the question, please choose the "?" response.)

- Name at least three (3) strengths of this survey:

Goal	Question #1	Revised Question 1?
Joan is working on controlling her displays of anger.	How frequently does she control her anger?	How frequently does she direct her anger at you?
Bob is working on being less controlling.	How often do you experience him as controlling you?	OK
Jason is working on being more courageously assertive in situations and circumstances that may involve conflict, confrontation, and uncomfortable or “negative” feelings.	To what extent do you experience Bob being courageous with these issues WITH YOU?	To what extent do you experience Bob dealing assertively with these issues WITH YOU?
Alan is working on being more open and positive towards his team members’ requests of him.	As a team member, when you approach Alan with new projects how frequently does he appear open and positive towards your request? 1=Not at all.....10=All the time	As a team member, when <i>you</i> approach Alan with new projects, how frequently do you experience him as open and positive towards your request?
Paul is working on completing his work in a more timely way.	How often does Paul complete the work you’ve delegated to him? 1=Never.....10=All the time	OK

Appendix A

Excerpt from ITC Workbook: Survey

The intent of this customized baseline survey is to get other people's perspective on your change goal: do they also think it would be useful for you to work on your stated goal? What do they see as your current level of success in enacting your Column 1 goal? In this way, the data provides you a "reality check" (is what you see yourself doing what significant others also see?). I will send a second survey to the same respondents at the end of this process, if appropriate. The baseline data will thereby provide a means for you to track and measure your progress accurately.

Towards this end, I will be asking you to identify 6 – 8 respondents, including yourself. Please select those people who see and/or interact with you most frequently around your Column 1 improvement goal. Be vigilant to not "stack the deck" by asking only those people who you think regard your performance highly in this area! Assuming you want a realistic picture, include people who you think are your toughest critics or from whom you think you have something to learn.

Once your respondents send me their written thoughts, I will compile them to send them to you for future conversation. I will try my best to alter any identifying comments in such a way that their meaning is maintained, but the respondent's identity is masked. However, since you work closely with these respondents, *and* some of their responses will be specific to projects in which you engaged with them, please be aware that you may be able to identify them through their comments. No one but you and I will see the responses.

Because the survey questions are designed to generate data most relevant to the changes you are looking to bring about in our work together, people's feedback will be targeted. This survey ensures that people will provide more honest – and therefore more useful--feedback than they might otherwise do if *you* were to ask them for direct feedback (at least early on in this process). Feel free, however, to use additional means to gather information from your co-workers about your behaviors and the impact on them.

Preparing for the Survey Process

Please read the Sample Survey below so that you can see what a survey looks like.

Let me know your thoughts and questions about the survey and data gathering. Comment on any aspect, *especially if you have any concerns*. Before we move further, I want you to decide whether the survey would be valuable to you.

If you agree to the survey, I will ask you to respond to the following questions:

1. *How do you want to inform respondents of your request for their input?* You can: a) tell them in person or by phone, at which time you can answer any of their questions; b) send them an e-mail (if you want, I can send you a sample note you might want to send); or c) I can contact them (by e-mail or phone). If you choose to contact them yourself, please give them my name and tell them they can expect to hear from me shortly. Let me know by **date here** how you want to handle this. If you want me to take this step, then please send me people's contact information at this time too.
2. *Who do you want to get feedback from?* Remember to select people who see and/or interact with you most frequently around your Column 1 improvement goal. Include people who you think are your toughest critics or from whom you think you have something to learn.
3. *Send me the names and e-mail addresses of all of your respondents.* If you are contacting them, send me this information as soon as you have contacted everyone. Can we agree to you sending me that by **date here**?
4. *What specific wording would you like in your survey, especially in communicating the area you have chosen to work on?* I have attached a draft of what your survey might look based on your current immunity map. However, this specific wording might not be what you want to use, so think about how best to explain to your colleagues what it is that you want to work on.

Survey Process

1. You complete "Prep" steps as described above.
2. All respondents sent survey and directions.
3. You and I set a phone meeting time (45 minutes) for two weeks after the survey is sent out.
4. Respondents have one week to complete the survey. (I will have information re: who has and hasn't responded, and will send a reminder if needed to those who haven't returned their survey by mid-week).
5. Before our phone meeting, and within the week of my receiving all responses, I send you a summary of survey results.
6. Once you receive your results, you prepare for our phone meeting by answering the reflection questions below.

Sample Survey

The area Al has chosen to work on is to deal *more directly with situations and circumstances that may involve conflict, confrontation, and uncomfortable or “negative” feelings*. There are many ways that Al’s skill at keeping relationships smooth is a great strength, of course, but he wants to work at reducing unproductive sides of this tendency, particularly in areas where conflict may be necessary for pushing the business forward.

This is a confidential survey. You were chosen by Al to be one of his survey respondents. It is his hope you will answer as frankly as possible. *Obviously, Al’s own self-assessment on the following questions at the present time would be rather low.*

Responses will not be identified by respondents. Al will receive an anonymous profile of the results of 5 – 8 surveys like this one. On his behalf, I thank you for the benefit of your thinking and about 15 minutes of your time—now, and again in about four months.

1. *The area Al has chosen to work on is to deal more directly with situations and circumstances that may involve conflict, confrontation, and uncomfortable or “negative” feelings. To what extent do you experience Al dealing directly with these issues WITH YOU?*

1 = Not at all

10 = Very frequently

2. *To what extent do you experience Al dealing directly with these issues WITH OTHERS?*

1 = Not at all

10 = Very frequently

3. *COMMENTS: Please take a minute to expand on this quick take. E.g., any further thoughts, explaining what you mean, giving examples, will be helpful.*

4. *As you think about just this aspect of Al’s functioning, how important to the office would you consider his making significant improvement?*

1 = Not at all

10 = Very frequently

5. *Why do you say so? In what ways would it matter/not matter? (We know these take a moment, but they are extremely helpful to Al and his coach. The more particular you can be, the better).*

6. *If this is NOT an area you think Al should be working on, what alternative suggestions do you have?*

REFLECTING ON YOUR SURVEY DATA

Your Workspace:

Consider the data in the context of your most recently revised immunity map.

Reflection Question	Your Response
What, if anything, does the data suggest regarding your Column 1 Commitment (i.e., do the results suggest that you have targeted a powerful Column 1 Commitment)?	
What, if anything, does the data suggest regarding your Column 2 behaviors (i.e., are there additional Column 2 behaviors to add to your map)?	
What, if anything, does the data suggest regarding your Big Assumption?	
Compare your responses with those of your respondents. • What's similar? • Where are the differences? • What's your take on those differences?	
What are your "take-aways" from thinking about this data?	

Appendix B

Sample Letter from Coach to Client Explaining ITC Survey Process

Dear **Client Name**,

We hope this letter finds you well – and still feeling connected to the good work we began together at the **XXX** off-site. Over the years, we have learned a few things about how to help people stay with the work of overturning “immunities to change,” and modifying possibly constrictive “Big Assumptions.” As your work continues, I will be inviting you to try out a variety of exercises and activities. One of the things that can make a very positive difference is, early on, deliberately letting a few people in on your 1st column commitment – people who are in a position to notice differences in your behavior along exactly the lines of your 1st column commitment should they occur.

The simplest and most effective way to do this is through a very brief “mini-survey,” administered toward the beginning of your process to get a baseline of others’ perceptions, and again at the end (in about 6 months). Since we know the mere mention of the word “survey” in many organizations can elicit all kinds of less-than-enthusiastic associations, let me quickly explain the survey:

This is not a 360-item, 360-degree, hour-long epic to be completed by 360 of your closest friends, associates, and clients. Quite the contrary, it consists of only a few questions, tightly focused on your 1st column commitment; you will ask only 5-8 respondents to fill it out; and it will take them 15 minutes or less to do it [see a sample below].

You will choose your respondents (in consultation with me), and the material they generate will be anonymously aggregated by me and presented back to you for us to consider together.

By administering the survey twice, you will have a chance to see how your own sense of change, and the difference it makes, matches with the observations of others. (Knowing that these folks will be a part of your own learning process can help to “hold you” in the work.)

Specifically, how would this work?

1. In your next meeting, I will give you a draft of this mini-survey and we will finalize a copy together. I will also ask you to create an optimal list of the 5-8 people you'd like to ask to be respondents.
2. You will be in touch with these folks within the next few days to let them know you are participating in a personal learning project and that you would like their help. You will let them know they will soon receive an e-mail version of the mini-survey.
3. Once you have contacted everyone, let me know and I will e-mail those who have agreed to participate. People will be asked to return their surveys within two weeks.
4. I will anonymously aggregate their responses, break out the relationship between your responses and theirs, and share these results with you at our next coaching session.

What does a sample survey look like?

(Please note: the surveys are not a sharing of the highly personal, full 4-Column map. They only make reference to the learning goal that appears in your 1st Column Commitment.) Here is an example that is drawn from a CFO's personal learning project.

Al's Baseline Survey

The area Al has chosen to work on is to deal **more directly (and in a more timely way) with situations and circumstances that may involve conflict, confrontation, and uncomfortable or "negative" feelings**. There are many ways that Al's skill at keeping relationships smooth is a great strength, of course, but he wants to work at reducing unproductive sides of this tendency, particularly in areas where conflict may be necessary for pushing the business forward.

This is a confidential survey. You were chosen by Al and his coach to be one of his survey respondents. It is his hope you will answer as frankly as possible. **Obviously, Al's own self-assessment on the following questions at the present time would be rather low.**

Responses will not be identified by respondents. Al and his coach will receive an anonymous profile of the results of 5 – 8 surveys like this one. On his behalf, we thank you for the benefit of your thinking and about 15 minutes of your time—now, and again in about six months.

1. *The area Al has chosen to work on is to deal more directly (and in a more timely way) with situations and circumstances that may involve conflict, confrontation, uncomfortable or “negative” feelings. To what extent do you experience Al dealing directly with these issues WITH YOU?*

1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 9 10

1 = NOT AT ALL

10 = VERY FREQUENTLY

2. *To what extent do you experience Al dealing directly with these issues WITH OTHERS?*

1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 9 10

1 = NOT AT ALL

10 = VERY FREQUENTLY

3. *COMMENTS: Please take a minute to expand on this quick take, e.g., any further thoughts, explaining what you mean, giving examples, will be helpful.*

4. *As you think about just this aspect of Al’s functioning, how important to the office would you consider his making significant improvement?*

1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 9 10

1 = NOT AT ALL

10 = VERY IMPORTANT/VALUABLE

5. *Why do you say so? In what ways would it matter/not matter? (We know these take a moment, but they are extremely helpful to Al and his coach. The more particular you can be, the better.*

THANK YOU for your time and your thoughts!

Appendix C

Sample Letter from Client to Survey Respondents

To: [name of prospective respondent here]

From: [your name here]

Subject: Requesting your input

I am participating in a professional development exercise along with several other **name of organization** partners (**name of project** sponsored by **name of sponsor**, and co-designed with **coach's name**). One step in the process is to gather feedback from colleagues through the use of a customized mini-survey. The form is very brief (should take about 15 minutes to complete) and I am asking you to complete it to support my on-going professional development.

You will receive an email with my survey in the next day or so from **me/coach** (**your** e-mail here), asking you to return to **him/her** your completed version within the next two weeks. I helped develop the survey and the selected areas of improvement. I chose you for input because you know me and have had many occasions to observe how I think and act, which I expect, will be quite helpful for me to hear. Please be candid and honest in providing your view. (Responses will be reported to me as an anonymous profile of the aggregate of respondents).

If you have questions or prefer not to participate please let me know. Thanks so much for your input and support in my efforts.

Appendix D

Sample Email from Coach to Client re: Preparing for Survey Debrief

To: [name of client here]
From: [your name here]
Subject: Your survey responses

Hi ____,

I'm attaching your survey response data! As you know, I'd like you to take a moment to prepare yourself for this feedback before you read it. There are few things I hope you'll keep in mind:

1. This survey is a unique way of requesting feedback. That is, unlike many other surveys that request feedback on all aspects of your performance, you are specifically asking people **to rate you on an area you have identified as one of your weaknesses**. First, remind yourself of your own responses to the questions – what numbers did you circle? Now, consider how you anticipate you'll react to others' responses. How do you think you'll react if they rate you higher or lower than you did?
2. We had some specific purposes for conducting the survey. So, you might want to read through the data with these questions in mind:
 - Is there basic agreement that you have chosen a 1st column commitment that others also think is important for you to improve on?
 - Is your own assessment of your current performance aligned with others? (Did others rank you much higher or lower than you did?) What do you make of that?
 - Did others identify any additional behaviors (potential Column 2 entries) that go against your Column 1 Commitment?
 - How are you feeling generally about your survey data? What are you think about having read through the data? What key things did you learn?

We can discuss these issues in our next phone call. But feel free to email with questions, comments, initial reactions, etc.

Appendix E

Logistics of a Survey Debrief by Phone

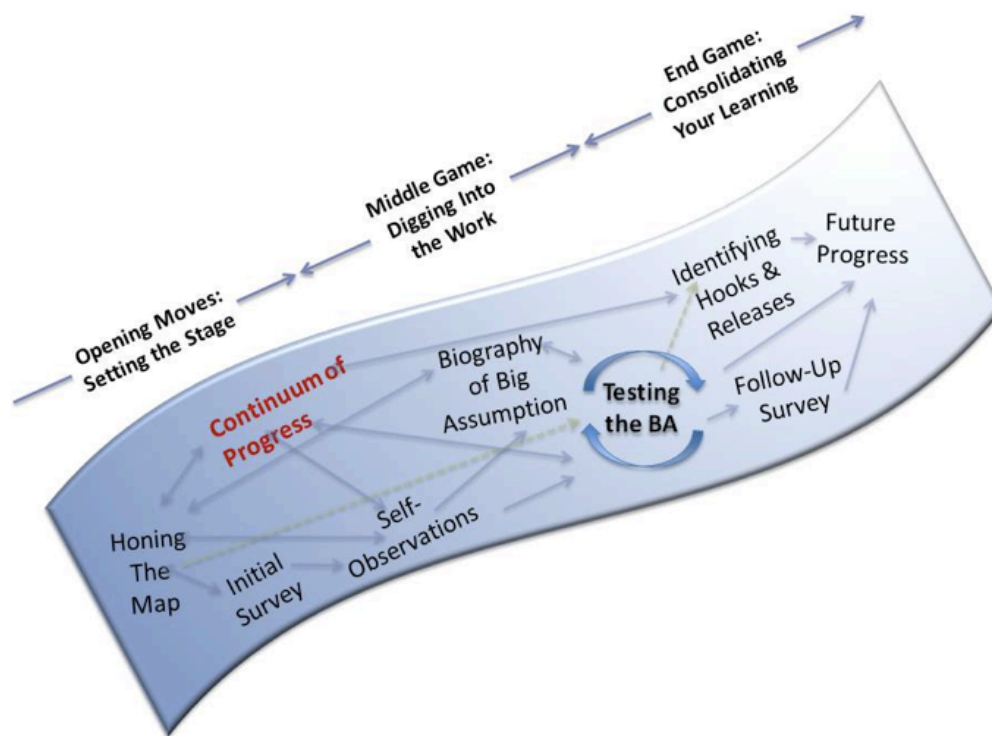
1. Coachee completes “Prep” steps.
2. All respondents sent survey and directions.
3. You and client set a phone meeting time (45 minutes) for two weeks after the survey is sent out.
4. Respondents have 1 week to complete the survey. (You will have information re: who has and hasn’t responded, and will send a reminder if needed to those who haven’t returned their survey by mid-week.)
5. Before your phone meeting with your coachee, and within the week of your receiving all responses, you will send coachee a summary of survey results.
6. Once coachee receives the results, he/she prepares for the phone meeting by answering reflection questions. (See page titled, “Reflection Questions”.)

Chapter 3

The Continuum of Progress

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Context for this Exercise

The Continuum of Progress is part of “Middle Game” and is best introduced early in the coaching journey because it helps clients to begin imagining how to be free of their Big Assumption. It is not a means to overturning an immunity, but rather a way of building the necessary muscles of attending to feelings and

thoughts, and seeing the connection between behaviors, thoughts and feelings. When done well, it sets the stage for digging into the work because it increases motivation for and clarity about the digging, and it provides rich material for potential tests of Big Assumptions.

If your client has opted to do a survey as part of his process, you can introduce him to the Continuum of Progress (CoP) while you are waiting to collect his survey results. This may seem counter-intuitive, given one of the purposes of the survey is to get input from others that your client is working on a goal they also see as important. However, there are very few occasions when someone completely revises his goal, and modest goal revisions can easily be worked into a Continuum of Progress. Maintaining momentum and motivation are key factors to use when deciding whether and when to do this exercise.

As with other ITC exercises designed to help prepare a client, it is perfectly fine to skip this one. If you do choose to include it, it is good practice to return to it periodically, and use it at the end to gauge success, so that it does not become an isolated exercise. Client reflections from self-observations and tests often generate valuable reality-based thoughts and feelings, especially positive ones, previously unimaginable, and ideally, these should be added to the Continuum of Progress.

Overview

The Continuum of Progress (CoP) exercise is designed to help us anticipate the short-term and long-term mindset (thoughts and feelings) and behavior changes we need to make in order to reach our goals. In the best cases, we are able to envision an exciting, personalized picture of what success looks like in terms of how we think, feel and act differently (the dimensions which, when combined, create lasting change). This can be motivating. In the best cases, we also have begun to describe an internal landscape, and accompanying, new behaviors, that are no longer captive of our Big Assumptions. In doing so, we continue to set the stage for having a proactive relationship to our Big Assumptions.

Purpose and Benefits

- ✓ Your client prepares for success by visualizing a picture of an imagined future self unburdened by her current Big Assumptions. This picture includes the affective, cognitive and behavioral landscape she desires, including what she would like to reduce, eliminate and/or add.
- ✓ Your client builds her capacity to interact with a Big Assumption more objectively, more productively.
- ✓ Your client develops potential tests of her Big Assumption.
- ✓ Your client sees the value of change as developmental, occurring over time.
- ✓ Your client's motivation to overturn her immune system continues or increases, as she understands how the Continuum of Progress connects to accomplishing her change goal.
- ✓ You and your client become aware of additional learning needs that she may have (e.g., a book or chapter on how to delegate; a writing coach; someone to help him organize his office) and you begin to consider how to direct her in this more “technical” (versus “adaptive”) regard.

Five General Points about the Continuum of Progress

1. The Continuum of Progress (CoP) is based on the core immunity concept that sustained behavior change occurs only when a person alters the actual *sources* of the behaviors. The sources of a client's behavior are his meanings (and, as you know, can be found in his Column 3 Commitments and Column 4 Big Assumptions). This is why the exercise directs a client to include thoughts and feelings as he envisions success. These are not just any thoughts and feelings, but the ones that follow from imagining being unencumbered by Big Assumptions.

2. The Continuum of Progress exercise is a thought experiment for a client to imagine how she could meet her goal by no longer being captive of her Big Assumption. A high quality CoP generates for an ITC coachee the same advantages athletes derive in their preparations from visualizing success – a focused, purposeful, directed mental images of herself successfully meeting her goal. A high quality CoP does even more though: as an integral part of her success, the coachee has a picture of a future self freed of her Big Assumptions. When she imagines the possibility that her assumptions are not so true, she can also imagine new thoughts, feelings and actions that she can make that will allow her to accomplish her Column 1 goal. A Continuum of Progress is neither a plan of action nor a means to overturn our immune systems. It is only a preparation for that overturning (albeit a very useful one).

3. A client may need to learn new content knowledge or skills in order to eventually test her Big Assumptions, and the Continuum of Progress includes these. Change challenges often have a mixture of adaptive and technical features. One practical implication of an immune system and Big Assumptions about why we must protect ourselves is that we have not developed particular competencies relevant to our goal. For example, a client has a goal to “distribute leadership.” If she assumes she needs to be in control of everything in order to have quality results (col. 4), then she doesn't delegate to other people (col. 2). So she has a lot of experience *not* delegating, and little, if any, experience of delegating. It's likely that she never tried to learn best practices of how to delegate given her Big Assumption that delegating will lead to poor quality results. In this way, she will benefit from developing a success picture to identify what she may need to learn and be able to do to be successful (e.g., learning how to communicate her expectations clearly, or how to give timely, productive feedback or how to break down a large project into manageable pieces). She can practice those skills before enacting a test of her assumption about being in control of everything.

4. The real purpose of the Continuum of Progress is often misunderstood by clients (more so than for any of the other ITC exercises). Some people

are over-enthusiastic, others are understandably averse.

- The over-enthusiasts mistakenly see the exercise as an invitation to create a paved road and a plan of action. They jump in to define their milestones, want to attach “by when’s” to each, and feel, “Okay, I get what is going to happen – I’ll just do these things in turn, and before long, I will have reached my goal.”
- The averse make the same mistake of seeing the exercise as a plan of action, but because they have been intrigued with the prospect of meeting their adaptive challenge via an *adaptive* means, they wonder “What happened to the diagnosis of my immune system?” “The window into my mindset seems to have closed! Why did I need to develop my 4-Column map if it is all going to this? I don’t need my map to create my Continuum of Progress!”

Whether they understand the purpose of the exercise or not, there are some who will feel confused and clueless about how to do the exercise. They are wondering: how can you create a picture of success when you don’t know what you don’t know? They say things like, “I wish I knew how I would be different but I don’t.”

(See Tips section for ideas on how to respond to a client’s misunderstanding or struggle with the exercise).

5. Done well, a Continuum of Progress can lead to significant increases in a client’s motivation to work on overturning her immune system. This is mainly a consequence of two factors. For one, the person feels more optimistic about her ability to change because she has unpacked the adaptive, and when relevant, the technical features of what she will need to change. She has accounted for new thinking, feeling and behaving. Secondly, her plan doesn’t create unrealistic hopes that success is going to happen all at once or right away. She has identified do-able first steps and so she knows where to start.

The Continuum of Progress can be a turning point for some clients. Sue, a real person, is an example of such a client. For her, the exercise opened up a new vista for how she could make progress on her 1st column goal, to be more effective with conflict, by altering her Big Assumption. Let’s first take a look at her 4-Column map so that you can get a sense of what mindset and behavior shifts she may need to make in order to accomplish her goal. Then we’ll turn to her completed Continuum of Progress.

Brief Example of a Continuum of Progress

1. Commitment/ Improvement Goal	2. Doing/NotDoing	3. Hidden Counter- Commitment	4. Big Assumptions
Be more effective with conflict. Being more direct speaking in times of conflict. Taking the risk of saying I disagree with what the person is saying. Taking the risk of telling the person I'm not going to "go there"— and telling them to take it to the person directly.	I allow people to vent without limits. I don't always direct them to the other. I sometimes join emotionally into the conflict. I minimize the conflict/ actions to calm them down. Sometimes I agree when I don't mean it. I don't always express my disagreement.	To be accepted thru having a supportive stance. To not being seen as cold or uncaring.	If I was not accepted, then people wouldn't like me and I wouldn't have value. I assume I couldn't feel secure in my relationship during conflict. I assume that to disagree is to be cold and uncaring (or seen that way). I assume that the relationship will not remain if I disagree.

Before we turn to Sue's Continuum of Progress, what shifts in mindset and behavior do you suppose could lead her to be more effective with conflict? Use this space below to jot down your ideas.

Possible mindset and behavior shifts for Sue's Continuum of Progress:

Here's Sue's Continuum of Progress:

Column 1 Goal & Big Assumption(s)	1st Steps Forward	Significant Progress	Success
Be more effective with conflict: Being more direct in my speaking in times of conflict, including saying when I disagree and setting limits. Most relevant Big Assumption(s): I assume I couldn't feel secure in my relationship during conflict. I assume that the relationship will not remain if I disagree.	I notice when I let myself get pulled into trying to solve the other person's problem—especially when I agree to take action. I tell my team I am working on not getting pulled into conflicts. I actively look to frame my helping the other person in terms of my being a good listener. I pay attention to how much value I can add by being a listener. I notice how I feel when others are “not playing nice.” I ask what my role is in that (what comes up for me and why?). I pay attention to what I'm feeling, and what's pushing my buttons. I look for patterns. I catch myself when I am being self-critical and do these other things.	I notice my urge to take action to solve the person's problem and I am able to stop myself from getting pulled in. With people I feel less risk, I tell them that I'm not the right person to solve their problem. I explain why I think they are in a better position to solve it. When the problem involves a third person, I encourage them to talk with that person directly. And I offer to help them to be more effectively themselves. I can listen without feeling the need to fix. I actively experience my value in being a good listener in these situations. I pay attention to the relief I feel in not shouldering the problem. I pay attention to the benefits others feel when they effectively take the problem on themselves. I pay attention to how I can help other help themselves. Help them to “play nice” with each other.	→ No matter who, I tell the person that I'm not the right person to solve their problem. I explain why I think they are in a better position to solve it. When the problem involves a third person, I encourage them to talk with that person directly. And I offer to help them to be more effectively themselves. I feel good about doing this. I have a full repertoire of ways to internalize the good feelings from work I do. While I appreciate accolades and positive feedback from others, I get more nourishment from my own feelings of value.

What made this such a valuable exercise for Sue? While trying to work on her Continuum of Progress, Sue realized she was having a familiar experience: feeling like she couldn't do a good job. In that moment, she put her finger on a critical missing behavior in Column 2 of her map, which was her negative self-talk, all of which took some form of, "you are no good at this!" (which she then added to her map). She could see how that self-talk would need to change if she was even going to try to get better with conflict. Sue had another "ah ha" when she spontaneously envisioned a potential way she could still stay connected to people *without* having to shoulder or fix the conflict or convey false agreement: she could be a good listener. This became a critical testing ground for Sue's Big Assumption that her value depended on people liking and accepting her for being supportive in ways that exhausted and depleted her.

Engaging your Client in this Exercise

Help your client understand the context for the assignment. Your job is to reconnect your client to the core ideas of the Immunity-to-Change concept, especially the connection between a Column 1 improvement goal and the Big Assumption. At this point in the process, it wouldn't be a surprise if he doesn't remember or hasn't yet internalized the key idea that

sustained change can't happen unless he can overturn the mindset which right now needs to produce the very behaviors that undermine his goal.

If you have done a survey, you can also say something about the connection between this exercise and the survey. Check point for you: what would you say the connection is? Take a moment to answer that and then read on.

Connection between Continuum of Progress and ITC Survey:

You might say something like this: “The survey helped you to clarify your improvement goal. You have a goal that you now know other people see as important for you to succeed on. The Continuum of Progress exercise starts with that goal and asks you to envision what personal success looks like, short-term and long-term, in terms of how you would think, feel and act differently were your Big Assumption inaccurate.”

If your client became aware, through his survey, of additional Column 2 items (things he is doing/not doing that work against his Column 1 goal), encourage him to review the survey comments to see if there is anything he wants to add to his Continuum of Progress.

Give your coachee a copy of “Continuum of Progress.” (See Appendix A.)

Explain the purpose of the assignment, including an explanation of what the assignment is not. The purpose of identifying these signs of progress is *not* to treat them like steps you should begin immediately trying to accomplish. The whole point of the immune system concept is that this is not a straight-forward matter as people often think. The core immunity concept is that sustained behavior change occurs only when a person alters the actual *sources* of the behaviors, e.g., the hidden, counter-commitments in Column 3, and the Big Assumptions in Column 4. The main purpose is to create a picture of what success, gradually achieved, will look like when you imagine not being constrained by your Big Assumption. It is not a “How to” for accomplishing that success. It hopefully helps to remind us that lasting change doesn’t happen in just a couple of days, or in one fell swoop. Also, answering these questions should begin to enable you to create a Continuum of Progress that can eventually be fleshed out further as a metric of Column 1 progress, and also a potential ground for testing your Big Assumption (which we will get to later). It’s the idea that if you start with the end in mind, you’re much more likely to get there.

If you are asking your client to do this as “homework” for your next session, let him know that it takes most people between 30 – 45 minutes to complete this exercise.

When your client struggles with the exercise. While your client listens to you explain the Continuum of Progress, he may say things that reveal his confusion about the purpose of the exercise. As we said earlier, this exercise can be misunderstood. (And you might not know how your client interprets the exercise until he shows you his work).

- If your client views the CoP as an action plan, it could be useful to discuss the idea that none of us can meet adaptive challenges by “dieting.” You might also consider letting him proceed as is, especially if he is someone who favors action, if it helps him to get started. Soon enough he will see the difference between a technical and an adaptive journey—as long as you keep that distinction alive in your conversations with him (especially when designing and debriefing tests of the Big Assumption).

- If your client doesn't see the CoP as a way to address the adaptive nature of his change challenge, you might want to show him an example of how the most powerful CoPs *do* take the person's ITC map, especially their Big Assumptions, into account. These CoPs are rich in descriptions of an internal landscape (ways the person would think and feel differently) and accompanying behaviors that run counter to their Big Assumptions, and are simultaneously clear progress on 1st column goals.

When a client feels stumped by imagining what success looks like, you might want to respond with an empathic reflection. Creating a picture of success is not necessarily easy! Because your client has been captive of her Big Assumptions, she may have little, if any, positive experience to draw on. This might be an occasion when you decide to drop the exercise. Other worthwhile options to consider include: a) suggesting that as a first step your client identify someone else whom she sees as an exemplar of her 1st column goal, and that she observe or even talk with this person about how he does what he does; b) suggesting a relevant reading that might help your client to see that, or how, other people embody her 1st column goal; c) seeing whether your client can generate examples of what thoughts, feelings and/or behaviors of hers would cast doubt on the certainty of her Big Assumption; d) you can let go of the exercise at this point and come back to it once the person has done a few observations that counter her Big Assumption, or after there are new data points from running actual tests.

Additional Resources for this exercise. Examples of completed Continuum of Progress can be useful (see Appendix B). You may also want to give your client a copy of the self-review guidelines (see Appendix C), as well as the CoP Tips sheet (see Appendix D). (Note: these are all on separate pages so you can pick and choose which, if any, you want to use.)

Let's assume that you explained the Continuum of Progress to your client and he completed it on his own. He sends you a copy of his work prior to your session. Our tips in this section are options of what you can listen for as you read a Continuum of Progress and consider how you could help your client make it more meaningful for him if needed.

Tips for improving a Continuum of Progress

The 4-Column Map Shows up in the CoP

A high quality Continuum of Progress can't be written without a 4-Column map. Do you hear Columns 2, 3 and 4 of his immunity map being addressed somehow? What is your client's level of understanding regarding what he needs to change in order to better realize his Column 1 commitment?

Considerations regarding Column 2, Doing/Not Doing. If your client wants to *stop doing* certain behaviors, listen to the Continuum of Progress for whether he includes thoughts and feelings that go along with reducing those. Many people don't consider how to develop the capacity to reduce unwanted behaviors (e.g., learning which cues produce the behaviors; increasing my awareness of when I'm about to engage in the unwanted behavior or when I do engage it; learning how to turn self-sabotaging messages into productive ones, etc.).

In addition to reducing behaviors, are *new* behaviors needed in order to be successful in reaching his Column 1 goal? What thoughts and feelings might accompany that new behavior (e.g., someone wanting to be less conflict averse is very likely to see "stating my opinion" as success, but may not consider that *how* he expresses his opinion, and the emotional message that conveys, matters a lot)?

Considerations regarding Columns 3 & 4. Listen for whether your client's CoP includes ways that his behaviors are tied up with his feelings connected to his hidden commitment or Big Assumption. For example, if the person who wants to be less conflict averse has a commitment to avoiding being in touch with or expressing anger, a high quality CoP for him would include being aware of, and doing something with, his anger before speaking.

What's the person's assumption(s) he plans to test? A Continuum of Progress success picture can help a client see that success may depend on factors he hadn't considered before and to plan accordingly. An example of this happened for a person whose Column 1 goal was to be a better delegator: when he completed his Continuum of Progress, he realized that his success depended on the quality and number of people to whom he would delegate. He knew that kind of bench strength wasn't available and so he added steps to his CoP picture that named what he would start doing, thinking and feeling that would increase his

people's capacity to take the ball and run. If he had not thought this through before testing his Big Assumption that he had to be in control of everything for things to run properly, he may well have collected data that his assumption was correct.

Beliefs about Change Show up in the CoP

A client's CoP can reveal her beliefs about change, its depth, pace and how it happens.

What is your client's mental model regarding change? Your client's frame of change is important to understand because it informs her expectations, including her disappointments, of the scope and pace of the work. You may discover that helping her to re-frame how she conceptualizes change is an essential part of your work with her.

How does your client think change occurs? Does she see change as an unfolding process or more of a checklist? Has she created a thread from 1st Steps, to Significant Progress to Success? What is her thinking about how the earlier steps lead to "Significant Progress" and to "Success"?

Participants' entries also have the potential to reveal their "theory-of-action"; that is, their personal (and often tacit) understanding of how change will actually occur. Theories-of-action are a series of "if, then" statements that lay out the logic (head and heart) of what the person believes or assumes would need to happen in order for the change to happen.

Change research (see Elmore) suggests that a theory-of-action leads to a greater likelihood of successful change, even when the theory itself is flawed. This is because the person has raised to an explicit level something which can be tested and revised accordingly. (Testing and revising one's theory-of-action is basically at the heart of testing and reformulating one's Big Assumption, i.e., the whole process of making what one is "subject to" into "object" so that it can be looked at, acted upon and re-made.) A person's "theory-of-action" can be brought forward by questions that invite the person to explain how she sees the various "dots" in her picture as connected. What you hear may be another source of material to draw on when giving your client feedback.

Examples of questions to elicit theory-of-action: "So that I can better get with you, could you explain how you see this step as moving you closer to your success picture?" or "People work on this particular behavior you've named for different reasons. What's your thinking about how this behavior will help you to be more successful?"

Additional Big Assumptions Can Show up in the Continuum of Progress

Sometimes, a client's Big Assumptions get activated as they do this exercise. Some of these people believe that they cannot change; the exercise asks them to suppose they can change,

but their current captivity to their Big Assumption doesn't allow them to suspend that belief. For example, Cary's Big Assumption was basically that she was not going to change at her age, "If I have been unable to change my flaws and weaknesses already, that means they are incredibly hard to change going forward as they are an integral part of who I am."

Other people find it almost impossible to let themselves imagine success, let alone write it out for someone else to see, since that violates their assumption that they should never talk about their successes. To do so is to be boastful, "tooting my own horn," or self-promoting. We suggest you eliminate the exercise or let go of it at this point and come back to it later. As soon as your client begins to acknowledge data that casts a doubt on his Big Assumption, you start having good material for a Continuum of Progress.

Other Considerations

Because none of us knows what we don't know, getting input on a CoP can be very useful. A coach can be a useful resource for making suggestions for possible new frames or skills, as well as offering recommended resources such as readings and relevant organizations. You might also have additional recommendations based on your hunches about where your clients is from a constructive-developmental perspective? What do you see as the developmental demands inherent in your client's CoP?

Your role is to understand your client's entries, offer feedback questions and/or suggestions you may have, keeping in mind the purposes of the CoP. The point is not to create a finished product, since his success picture and interim steps may change the more he understands through your work together.

Tips and Pitfalls

Coach's Tips for Continuum of Progress Exercise

1. The overall goal is to get an incremental picture of success for the 1st column Improvement Goal, leading to a visualization (like athletes do) of Success. *Overall Tips*
2. This picture should capture the person's imagination re how she might think, feel and act differently (in relation to her 1st column) if not under the control of her current Big Assumption.
3. Don't worry about your client naming everything required for success. She can revise the continuum over time.
4. Debrief in the same order as your Coachee filled out the chart, i.e., first take a look at the **Success** column; then go to **Significant Progress**; then **1st Steps Forward**.

5. Remember the Coach's "Two Hats": an "Appreciative Receiver" (letting your Coachee know you get what she is saying before you start pressing: be sure to empathize first) and a "Probing Inquirer" (making sure the criteria below are met). Too much of the first without the second makes for a pleasant conversation which is not forwarding the work, but too much of the second without the first makes a person feel they are being grilled.

Tips Regarding "Success"

1. Make sure **your Coachee is at the center of his picture** of ultimate progress (how he or she is doing and feeling differently, rather than how others are, or how the world looks different).
2. What is she **thinking feeling, and doing**? Try to get at changed behavior internally (psychologically) and externally (action and non-verbal behaviors).
3. Has he addressed **Columns 2, 3 and 4 of his immunity map** somehow (especially whichever Big Assumption is most getting in the way)? It can be helpful to take out the 4-Column map and cross-reference against the CoP together with the Coachee to make sure all relevant pieces are covered.
4. Does the change amount to realizing **big progress** on the 1st column goal? Is there depth to the entries? Are they reasonable changes the person has control over? Or do they seem to depend on extraordinary circumstances and luck?

Tips Regarding "1st Steps Forward"

1. Again, make sure your **Coachee is at the center** of her picture of first steps (how she is doing and feeling differently, rather than how others are, or how the world looks different).
2. Thoughts, feelings and actions: Do they connect? Do you see how it is a start on the 1st column Commitment? Is it compelling to your Coachee?
3. Skill and Will: Is this something the person *can* now do (or does he need to acquire some additional skill(s) before undertaking it)? Is this something your Coachee *really wants* to do now?

Potential Pitfalls

Coach	Client
Loses sight of the immunity-to-change dimension of the exercise (connection between mindset and behavior change).	CoP doesn't address her Big Assumption in any way.
Orients only to the adaptive requirements for the client's improvement.	Orients to the CoP as a "to do" list.
Loses sight that the CoP belongs to the client (e.g., inserts own agenda for the client; advocates ideas and language).	CoP is not about herself as much as it is about how other people will respond to her.
Loses focus on client's agency.	CoP is not reality-based (i.e., the imagined changes aren't ones the person has control over, but depend on extraordinary circumstances or luck).
Over-empathizes and under-probes or over-probes and under-empathizes.	CoP is weak and does little to motivate client; or, CoP entries meet criteria but client feels grilled in process.
Loses sight that the CoP is part of the whole process. Doesn't return to the CoP to have client integrate learnings from observations and tests.	There are big gaps in the person's logic or beliefs about the relationship between thoughts, feelings and behaviors, and intended outcomes.

In-depth Examples: Jackson and Amanda

Jackson's Continuum of Progress

While they were waiting for the responses to Jackson's survey, Jackson and his coach began work on the Continuum of Progress. Jackson sent his completed Continuum of Progress to his coach before his coaching session and included a message that he had a hard time with the exercise. He added, "I don't know what to imagine – how things could be different if I didn't have my Big Assumptions."

Version 1

Column 1 Goal & Big Assumption(s)	1st Steps Forward	Significant Progress	Success
To get better at publicizing my accomplishments with senior management.	In my annual performance review conversations, I can talk confidently and assertively about my skills and accomplishments.	I keep senior management updated on my skills and accomplishments. I get a raise and a promotion.	→ I am senior management and no longer need to publicize my accomplishments.

When Jackson's coach read his Continuum of Progress, he could see that Jackson had misunderstood the assignment. Not only had he focused on behaviors and results (excluding changes in his thinking and feeling if he was less captive of his Big Assumption), he had named things that were largely out of his control (e.g., getting a raise and a promotion).

In their next meeting, Jackson's coach reminded Jackson of his Big Assumptions:

- I assume that saying anything about my accomplishments is bragging. I assume that if I am bragging, I am just like Kurt (also selfish, arrogant, etc.).
- I assume that if I publicize my successes, I'll believe what I say.

He then asked Jackson to try and imagine in greater detail what it could look like to overturn his Big Assumptions. To help Jackson focus on those, he asks him to record each one in Column 1 beneath his entering commitment. As Jackson begins to describe what success would entail, his coach continues to prompt him for more depth and detail, asking ques-

tions like, “What would you be doing?”; “What would that feel like?”; “What would you be thinking about?” When Jackson gets stuck, his coach throws out a handful of possibilities, which provide Jackson with some ideas to respond to.

He also wanted to ask Jackson to consider the idea that there might be a skill component to self-promotion – that a person who was quite good at framing and wording his message could effectively communicate his intentions (to honestly let others know what he had done without bragging or being arrogant). If Jackson was interested in exploring that idea, it could form the basis for a revised Continuum of Progress.

Together, they worked on a new version. By the end of the session, Jackson had revised his Continuum of Progress so that it felt much richer, more powerful, and quite motivating to him.

Version 2

Column 1 Goal & Big Assumption(s)	1st Steps Forward	Significant Progress	Success
To get better at publicizing my accomplishments with senior management. I assume that saying anything about my accomplishments is bragging. I assume that if I am bragging, I am just like Kurt (also selfish, arrogant, etc.). I assume that if I publicize my successes, I'll believe what I say.	I request that my annual performance review be rescheduled. In the review conversation, I can talk confidently and assertively about my skills and accomplishments. I will strike the right tone so that I am not bragging or being arrogant. I am nervous about doing more self-publicity, but I don't let that feeling prevent me from doing it. I watch for occasions when I could do more self-publicizing than I do now. I look for examples of other people here who can self-publicize (in ways that don't strike me as bragging or arrogant).	I keep senior management updated on my skills and accomplishments — especially when I think I have done something (or can do something) that would be worthy of a raise or promotion. I know how to prepare myself (and manage my feelings) so that I can self-publicize when opportunities present themselves. I have a repertoire of ways to word things so I can accurately describe my skills and accomplishments in ways that strike the tone that I am after.	→ I don't have to work so hard to identify opportunities to self-publicize. I can self-publicize without having to prepare or manage my feelings. I don't mind self-publicizing. I can actually enjoy communicating to others what I can do and have done.

Amanda's Continuum of Progress

Amanda brought her Continuum of Progress to her coaching session and told her coach how excited she to have a clear plan for herself.

Version 1

Column 1 Goal & Big Assumption(s)	1st Steps Forward	Significant Progress	Success
To develop healthier eating habits. To lose 25 pounds thereby lowering my blood pressure and improving my cholesterol.	Count calories. Stick to my diet. Stop eating when I'm stressed or feeling down. Go to the gym. Stop drinking beer.	Lose 15 pounds. Run 5 miles. Cook more. Wear a new dress to my cousin's wedding.	→ Lose 25 pounds and have lower blood pressure and better cholesterol. Buy myself some new clothes.

Her coach could see that Amanda had not quite understood the purpose and goals of this exercise. She had thought about progress in terms of measurable results, rather than seeing progress as what it would look like to be **overturning her assumptions** in the change process. Her coach asked Amanda to enter her Big Assumptions in the first column as a way to help her focus on imagining the process of overturning them. Amanda continued to struggle to imagine what this process might be like, and in her conversation with her coach wanted also to focus on some of the tips and new behaviors she was learning about in her weight loss program. They agreed to incorporate some of these new behaviors, as well as to focus on internal changes Amanda was hoping to make (to her thoughts and feelings).

Version 2

Column 1 Goal & Big Assumption(s)	1st Steps Forward	Significant Progress	Success
To develop healthier eating habits. To lose 25 pounds thereby lowering my blood pressure and improving my cholesterol. BAAs: I assume that if I don't have lots of options, I will feel resentful, angry, impotent, and stressed. Life will be bleak. I assume that if I don't reward myself with food or drink, then I will be less motivated at work and in my personal life. I assume that if I were to take seriously the fact that my health is not great, I'll become depressed and maybe act in ways that are even more unhealthy. I assume that I should be able to eat what others eat and look the way they do. I assume that they all don't have to think about what they eat at all and don't have any negative results from bad habits. I assume that I know what (and how much) they eat, and whether they have health issues or not – even though I don't really know this.	Keep a record of everything I eat and drink. Switch to lite beer. Keep a record about when I want to eat stuff I shouldn't, when it feels good to eat right. Read about the WW diet – note where I have choices. Go to the gym twice per week. Let others (esp. Josslyn) know what I'm working on and how they can help. Remind myself that I don't know what others eat when I'm not with them. I don't know what other health issues they may have. Remember my doctor's warnings and my mental image of what I will look and feel like if I lose weight. Forgive myself if I fall off the wagon but then get right back on it.	Follow WW plan as closely as I can, making choices within their guidelines. Keep lots of healthy foods on-hand to choose from at home. Have lots of ideas for healthy "to go" meals for work days. Or bring healthy meal from home. Develop and start to use strategies for keeping me on track and helping me get back on track if I screw up. Go to the gym four times per week. Feel good about how my body is getting stronger and healthier. Enjoy seeing changes when I look in the mirror or try on clothes. Stop comparing myself to other people. Track weight and cholesterol regularly. Develop and start to use other types of rewards that are healthier (e.g., massages, movie tickets, going dancing). Drink more of other types of drinks (like green tea or seltzer) instead of beer that will help me relax.	→ Think of myself and feel like I am a healthy person. Think of my new eating habits as a way of life to be maintained. Am easily able to get myself on track when/if I don't maintain healthy habits. Go to the gym at least 4 times per week. This is built into my routine – I don't think about whether to go or not. I just go. I look forward to exercise and healthy eating because they make me feel good. I feel proud of how I look and feel. I regularly reward myself in healthy ways. I track my weight and cholesterol less frequently because numbers remain stable and low. I become a role model for others, showing them how to eat healthier.

Practice Time: Over to You

Practice Example #1:

Below is a Continuum of Progress, written by a client whose goal was to pursue her passions in a way that would also generate money. For the purposes of applying your understanding of the Continuum of Progress, and for practicing how you might interact with a client, let's assume that this person is your

client. You know that one of her Big Assumptions is "If I cannot meet my commitments to myself and my family, then I will be a total failure." In your last session, you gave her the Continuum of Progress to do as "homework" and she has emailed you a copy of her Continuum of Progress prior to your upcoming session. Read this, keeping in mind the purposes and criteria for a quality Continuum of Progress. Make notes on another page of where you see her entries as "on track" and "off track" (there's a space for this purpose following the Continuum below).

Column 1 Goal & Big Assumption(s)	1st Steps Forward	Significant Progress	Success
To pursue my passion for both art and helping people in a direction that would better utilize my artistic abilities, and make sense and purpose of my life's path and bring in enough money to meet our family's financial obligations.	I will have completed the final psychology credit to attain my Bachelor of Science in Art Therapy. I have created a resume and cover letter to begin applying for better paying jobs. I have applied for the Maternity counselor position, interviewed and explored what that role might entail, and shared my ideas for utilizing art expression in adoption counseling. I am sending out resumes and cover letters to the list of all California adoption agencies I received. I am bringing four guests to the Saturday Business development Seminar. I am bringing four clients to the Image 101 class.	I am focused, and use my time to the most productive ends. I have a position doing adoption counseling which meets all our family's financial needs and obligations. I am able to utilize art expression as a helpful tool for people wrestling with the issues surrounding an unplanned pregnancy. We have been able to afford home repairs bringing our house up to respectable living standards. We can afford some luxuries like a family vacation. I have residual money coming in from my e-commerce business.	I would be watching the opening night performance of my play <u>Grace Street Serenade</u> on a major New York Stage where it was brought from having a successful run in Boston, and was heralded as a timely and thought-provoking "must see". The ideas in the play have helped many wrestle with the issues surrounding unplanned pregnancy. I feel fulfilled utilizing art therapy in helping couples wrestle with unplanned pregnancies. I feel confident that I have the necessary wisdom and expertise to guide them through this important decision making process. Many children find themselves in homes where they are loved and valued, and cared for capably because of my efforts.

Chart continued

Column 1 Goal & Big Assumption(s)	1st Steps Forward	Significant Progress	Success
.	I am spending an hour per night working on my play.	I have time to produce a staged reading of my play.	My e-commerce business is successful in helping many others actualize their dreams. I feel proud that I have provided adequately for the needs of my own family and have set a responsible example for my sons. I feel exuberantly joyful as I create relevant and uplifting artwork of my own that will leave the world a better place, and which God will use in expanding His kingdom.

Make notes here of where you see her entries as “on track” and “off track.”

Where I see this client as “on track” and “off track”:

Our Comments

Here's how we answered that same question (we encourage you to answer this first for yourself!):

What the Client Wrote	What the Coach Was Thinking
Success: I would be watching the opening night's performance of my play <u>Grace Street Serenade</u> on a major New York Stage where it was brought from having a successful run in Boston, and was heralded as a timely and thought-provoking "must see." The ideas in the play have helped many wrestle with the issues surrounding unplanned pregnancy. I feel fulfilled utilizing art therapy in helping couples wrestle with unplanned pregnancies. I feel confident that I have the necessary wisdom and expertise to guide them through this important decision making process. Many children find themselves in homes where they are loved and valued, and cared for capably because of my efforts. My e-commerce business is successful in helping many others actualize their dreams. I feel proud that I have provided adequately for the needs of my own family and have set a responsible example for my sons.	OK, so this client's 1st Column Commitment is "To pursue my passion for both art and helping people in a direction that would better utilize my artistic abilities, and make sense and purpose of my life's path and bring in enough money to meet our family's financial obligations." And I know her Big Assumption is "If I cannot meet my commitments to myself and my family, then I will be a total failure." That's important for her to keep in view, so I'll remind her to add it to her Continuum of Progress. Let's see how she imagines being fully released from that Big Assumption... Uh oh! What she is imagining here is less about what she is like and more focused on an event. And, she's imagining things that aren't really in her control (what happens to the play, how others respond to it). OK, this is better –focuses on how she feels, regards herself, her skills, etc. Hm, again, more about what might happen as a result of her (and so not fully in her control) than on how she is different. Gets better here. Able to set a measurable, controllable goal. But what does that mean to "provide adequately" and "set a responsible example?" I want to make sure she has a realistic and tangible idea of what she wants to provide. I also want to make sure that setting an example is about her (not necessarily about how they'll feel about her or regard her).

Our Comments continued

What the Client Wrote	What the Coach Was Thinking
I feel exuberantly joyful as I create relevant and uplifting artwork of my own that will leave the world a better place, and which God will use in expanding His kingdom.	Starts out better here, but again she starts to focus outward – on what will happen to the world and how God will use it. Takes the focus off of how she will behave differently, think differently, feel differently in specific ways.
1st Steps Forward:	
I will have completed the final psychology credit to attain my Bachelor of Science in Art Therapy.	Good, specific behaviors. These seem do-able (she is already enrolled in the course and successfully completing assignments).
I have created a resume and cover letter to begin applying for better paying jobs.	
I have applied for the Maternity counselor position, interviewed and explored what that role might entail, and shared my ideas for utilizing art expression in adoption counseling.	This one starts to get a little more ambitious. How fully developed are her ideas for utilizing art expression in adoption counseling? Her survey feedback tells us that she needs to get better at how she expresses herself to others in a way that presents her as knowledgeable, reliable, organized, etc. Maybe we need to do some skill development here.
I am sending out resumes and cover letters to the list of all California adoption agencies I received.	Not sure what she is thinking about with these two. She hasn't mentioned these projects to me. Is she going in too many different directions? We should discuss them further.
I am bringing four guests to the Saturday Business development Seminar.	Good.
I am bringing four clients to the Image 101 class.	But, overall how is she feeling? How is she thinking differently? We haven't touched on that here. She has more references to those things in her "Success" column (with less specific behavioral change).
I am spending an hour per night working on my play.	
Significant Progress:	
I am focused, and use my time to the most productive ends.	OK – let's unpack that more. What does that mean, exactly?
I have a position doing adoption counseling which meets all our family's financial needs and obligations.	Again, what are her family's financial needs and obligations? Does she know?

What the Client Wrote	What the Coach Was Thinking
I am able to utilize art expression as a helpful tool for people wrestling with the issues surrounding an unplanned pregnancy. We have been able to afford home repairs bringing our house up to respectable living standards. We can afford some luxuries like a family vacation. I have residual money coming in from my e-commerce business. I have time to produce a staged reading of my play.	And, she has focused more on outcomes here – what are the behavioral changes she is making? How is she thinking differently? How is she feeling? I feel like we need to get very clear about what it means to meet her commitments to herself and her family – not just in terms of outcomes but in terms of what she will be doing, thinking, feeling differently. And what that will take to accomplish.

Summary of Potential Pitfalls

- ✓ This client has not attended in all columns to how she will behave, think, and feel differently.
- ✓ In important places, especially in the “Success” column, her entries are not about herself but are instead about how other people will respond to her.
- ✓ She also has a tendency to get away from what is realistic – to imagine things that depend on extraordinary circumstances and/or luck.

Here is space for you to make notes of what you would think to say to this person:

What might I say to this client:

Below are various questions and comments we might make. As you read them, keep in mind that we might or might not make all of them, since it would depend on what emerged in the course of conversation. We need to keep our good listening hat on, and also probe into immunity-to-change territory. This will inevitably unfold in a back-and-forth way.

- What was the experience of creating a Continuum of Progress like for you? (And then depending on how they answer: Was it powerful? If so, how? If not, why not? Was it hard? What was hard? etc.).
- Remind the client of the purposes/potential outcomes of a Continuum of Progress and see if one or more resonate with his experience.
- Point out ways that the Continuum of Progress already does achieve these purposes, and where it could more powerfully achieve them, **addressing each of the pitfalls you identified**, e.g., to be able to visualize success, to find areas where additional skills/information are needed, to help identify specific aspects of the experience that might be different – things he will be doing differently, ways he will be thinking and feeling differently. See if you and your coachee can pinpoint these kinds of things for each column to make the image of success as powerful as possible.
- Check back in with the client throughout the conversation to make sure that the Continuum of Progress resonates for him, is growing more powerful, and is fulfilling its purposes.

Practice Example #2:

Amelia's first column commitment is to being a better listener. She has identified three Big Assumptions:

- *I assume that if I do listen to information I don't find valuable, I would fail in controlling my world.*
- *I assume that if I do listen to information I don't find valuable, I would be overwhelmed.*
- *I assume that if I were dispassionate, or take in information I don't find important, I'd be disappointed in myself – perhaps lose myself.*

Her Continuum of Progress follows:

Column 1 Goal & Big Assumption(s)	1st Step Forwards	Significant Progress	Success
I am committed to being an active listener. Assumptions: if I listen to information I don't find valuable, I would fail in controlling my world; if I listen to information I don't find valuable, I'll be overwhelmed; if I were dispassionate, or take in information I don't find important, I'll be disappointed in myself – perhaps lose myself.	I begin to make observations and to run experiments to tell me about what I need to do differently and how to do that.	My listening skills become “second nature.” I no longer “drift off” thinking about all the other issues and tasks I have at hand. “Mindfulness” becomes second nature.	I consistently put others' concerns and issues first. I would know I am being a good friend and/or colleague. My friends, colleagues and family would recognize I am focused on their issues and concerns.

Make notes here of where you see her entries as “on track” and “off track.”

Where I see this client as “on track” and “off track”:

Here's how we answered that same question (we encourage you to answer this first for yourself!):

What the Client Wrote	What the Coach Was Thinking
Success: I consistently put other's concerns and issues first. I would know I am being a good friend and/or colleague. My friends, colleagues and family would recognize I am focused on their issues and concerns.	OK, so let me review her 1st Column Commitment and Big Assumptions. And then, let's see how she imagines being fully released from that Big Assumption... Hm, I see these as connected to her Column 1 goal but not so connected to the Big Assumptions she identified. She says nothing here about how she would regard information that she finds not valuable or important. Is she suggesting that if she's fully successful, she wouldn't find anything to be not valuable or important? I can see that maybe she also has another Big Assumption – that she must put her own needs/interests second to others.
1st Steps Forward: I begin to make observations and to run experiments to tell me about what I need to do differently and how to do that.	OK – yes, that is what everyone does as part of this process. So, what exactly would these experiments entail? In what ways can she imagine she might be changing – not just what she does but also how she thinks and feels?
Significant Progress: My listening skills become “second nature.” I no longer “drift off” thinking about all the other issues and tasks I have at hand. “Mindfulness” becomes second nature.	Good – she is at least thinking about one part of what might change by identifying one thing she will be doing differently. I need to get her to start generating other possibilities. This is the first time she has mentioned mindfulness. Sounds like a potentially powerful concept for her that we need to unpack to see what it means to her, how she would be acting/thinking/feeling differently if she were more mindful.

Summary of Potential Pitfalls

- ✓ Amelia's Continuum of Progress does not focus on how things will be different if she is not captive of her Big Assumptions – there needs to be a stronger connection there.
- ✓ Her Continuum is too general. She needs help to imagine specific changes that could happen.
- ✓ This client has not attended in all columns to how she will behave, think, and feel differently.
- ✓ The Continuum of Progress introduces new material (new concepts, assumptions) that uncover a larger picture of her Column 1 goals and immunities than was captured in the map. This new material should be explored, and her map needs to be updated accordingly.

Here is space for you to make notes of what you would think to say to this person:

What I might say to this client:

Here is what we might say:

- What was the experience of creating a Continuum of Progress like for you? (Was it powerful? If so, how? If not, why not? Was it hard? What was hard? etc.)
- Remind the client of the purposes/potential outcomes of a Continuum of Progress and see if one or more resonate with his experience.
- Point out ways that the Continuum already does achieve these purposes, and where it could more powerfully achieve them, **addressing each of the pitfalls you identified**, (e.g., to be able to visualize success, to find areas where additional skills/information are needed, to help identify specific aspects of the experience that might be different – things he will be doing differently, ways he will be thinking and feeling differently if freed up from his Big Assumption). See if you and your coachee can pinpoint these kinds of things for each column to make the image of success as powerful as possible.
- Check back in with the client throughout the conversation to make sure that the Continuum of Progress resonates for him, is growing more powerful, and is fulfilling its purposes.

Appendix A

Continuum of Progress Exercise

This exercise is designed to help you to plan for your success in meeting your Column 1 Improvement Goal. Its purpose is to have you envision what success looks like, both short-term and long-term, in terms of how you act, feel and think, *while drawing on your insights into your immune system*. The main focus here is on *you*.

Why we invite you to create this personalized picture of emerging success:

- ✓ A clear picture of success **provides direction**. You are more likely to get where you want to go the more you know where you want to go.
- ✓ Being able to visualize what full success looks like – like athletes do – also **increases the likelihood of being successful** as you imagine effectively engaging in targeted new mindsets and behaviors. This often **releases energy and optimism for improvement**, important allies for personal change.
- ✓ You can safely **explore how revising your Big Assumption can lead to new mindset and behavior options**. In doing so, you may develop potential ways you want to test your Big Assumption.
- ✓ You can use your success picture to **identify what you may need to learn** to be successful. In this way, you plan for success.
- ✓ A completed Continuum of Progress **provides a realistic image of the pace of improvement**. Lasting change depends on small, incremental steps, taken over time, with success building upon success.

Directions: *Review your 4-Column map before you start this exercise to remind yourself of your immune system and Big Assumption(s).* Feel free to also look at the example provided below and Tips if you want more information.

1. In far left column, enter your Column 1 Improvement Goal and the Big Assumption(s) that most get in your way.

2. Focus on the last column, envisioning “Success”: What would it look like if you were to be fully successful in realizing your Column 1 Improvement Goal? **Allow yourself to imagine you are freer of your Big Assumption as you do this.** *Be as specific as you can* along three dimensions: what would you be thinking? Feeling? Doing? Write your answer in the “Success” column.
3. (Work backwards from there). What would constitute “significant progress” in moving towards that success? What would enable you to realize more of your Column 1 goal? Again, imagine you are freer of your Big Assumption as you develop this picture of your new thoughts, feelings and actions. Consider incorporating behaviors (cognitive, social, or emotional) that will help you catch yourself when you are falling into your default mode and get you back on track. Enter your answer in the column entitled, “Significant Progress.”
4. Then answer the question, “What first steps will move you forward towards your picture of success?” It is often helpful early in a change process to tell at least one person about your intentions. Consider whether there is someone you want to talk with and even ask for his or her support. Enter your answer in the column entitled, “1st Steps Forward.”

Continuum of Progress: Envisioning your Success

Column 1 Goal & Big Assumption(s)	1st Steps Forward	Significant Progress	Success

Appendix B

Continuum of Progress Examples

Example #1

Column 1 Goal & Big Assumption(s)	1st Steps Forward	Significant Progress	Success
			→
To deal directly and effectively with conflict and difficult conversations. BA: If I tell someone what I really think, they will react negatively to me, I will get overwhelmed by feelings of self-doubt and worry that I'm offending him or her.	I become more aware of times I'm avoiding conflict. Are there any patterns – what pushes my buttons? I sit down and think about what I would say if I was to deal with any of those situations directly and effectively. I get feedback on my imagined comments from someone who wasn't a part of the situation. Also, I ask that person what she or he might have said. I pay attention to times when I overhear others dealing directly & effectively with conflict to figure out what they are doing that works. Maybe I talk to one of them afterwards about whether they doubt themselves when disagreeing. I read a few highly recommended readings on how to deal with conflict and practice the advice in my mind.	I know what some of the topics are that lead me to avoid conflict. I have thought through, as much as I can, what I really think about the topic. When the topic next comes up with someone, I don't mince words or sugarcoat my position. I say what I think. Even if I feel nervous saying it, I feel good for having said it. I am open to what the other person says in response. I don't react; I listen and take it slow. I figure out how to not let my feelings take me over both before and during my comments. I don't start doubting myself. I feel okay about the person disagreeing with me.	I'm aware right in the moment that I disagree, or I know I need to say something that might lead to a difficult conversation. I say what I'm really thinking, but without getting all caught up in nervous & anxious feelings I may have. I catch myself when I'm reacting too quickly to the other person. I catch myself when I feel like they are dismissing my idea and know how to stay in the conversation productively.

Example #2

Column 1 Goal & Big Assumption(s)	1st Steps Forward	Significant Progress	Success
			→
To opening up my own “space” to others, bring others (my colleagues, friends and wife) more behind my wall. BA: The rewards of opening myself up to others will be overwhelmed by the burdens I will feel from sharing & listening to people.	I don’t let my calendar get so filled with work commitments that there is no room to take the time to connect more with people. I do not “hide away” when in meetings with my colleagues, or in social situations. I let a few people, including my wife, know what I am trying to do and ask them for feedback. I begin to be more attentive to my own feelings. I begin to imagine what might be in this for me. I read a few highly recommended readings on how to deal with conflict and practice the advice in my mind.	I talk more about myself and my feelings with others. And I feel comfortable doing so. I ask for help, receive help, give people the opportunity to help me. I feel good about that. I am learning more what is in this for me (not just making others feel better on this front). I let myself feel vulnerable and open to feeling pleasure of connecting to others.	I continue to share myself, now more deeply, with others. I continue to ask for and receive people’s help and feel good about that. I develop a new metric (not a zero-sum game re trade-offs of independence and dependence), so that I am opening up more, telling more what I think and feel, not cutting off prematurely – not only so that others will feel more embraced by me and less troubled, but because I myself genuinely value and pursue more this way of being. I come to experience the ‘benefits of dependency’ (without giving up the benefits of independence).

Example #3: Big Assumptions

Column 1 Goal & Big Assumption(s)	1st Steps Forward	Significant Progress	Success
			→
To be much more effective at “deep listening” with my clients; be able to really “sit beside them” and “stay with them” even when they are expressing hard feelings (rather than quickly flee to “action mode” or the “solution space”). BA: If I genuinely listen to people, they will start saying things that I won’t know how to respond to. I won’t be able to respond effectively in the moment.	Pay attention when I’m doing what’s in my Column 2 (with whom, what topics/issues etc). Who is it with? What’s it about? Any patterns? Tell my colleague, Mark, about this goal. Ask him in advance to give me feedback along the way. Talk to someone I admire as good at this kind of listening. What do they do? What’s their advice to me?	When these situations come up I can often stay present for them; I can catch myself when I slip into not listening, and much of the time get back on track. I am much more aware of the situations that are likely to be most difficult for me when it comes to “deep listening”, and I can bear these discomforts. I feel fine with being uncertain about what to say. I let myself feel what I’m feeling.	I actively create conditions in which my clients want to speak to me in these ways and I’m able to be present. I can catch myself before I slip into not listening and most of the time refocus my attention. I have a host of ways to keep me listening deeply. I no longer feel afraid of being unable to handle what is said to me, and instead feel welcoming of the opportunity to be with my client when they want to share personally difficult feelings.

Appendix C

Self-Review Guidelines

Self-Review:

If you've completed the exercise, here are a few specific questions which can help you to know whether you are on track:

- Look at your “Success” column. Does what you've written there amount to extraordinary progress on your 1st Column Improvement Goal? Have you focused on yourself, your new thoughts, feeling and behaviors? Have you allowed yourself to imagine being freer of your Big Assumption as you developed this picture?
- Start with “1st Steps Forward” and move through the columns: can you “connect the dots” of how your entries in each column build on the prior column and ultimately depict full, spectacular success?
- Do you find your Continuum *compelling*? Set aside whether you think you can make these changes; are these changes you *really want* to make?

You'll know you have successfully completed this step when you have a clear direction that includes you being less captive of your Big Assumption(s), an imagined pathway to get there, a compelling “pull,” and a rough set of “metrics” to help you see your change when it occurs.

If you conclude that your Continuum hasn't quite crossed these thresholds, you may want to look below to the chart entitled “Strengthening your Continuum of Progress” for further tips. In any case, there's no need for perfect execution in completing this exercise. You can revisit and revise your entries over time, **as you learn more about what you want for yourself.**

Appendix D

Strengthening Your Continuum of Progress

Column 1 Goal & Big Assumption(s)	1st Steps Forward	Significant Progress	Success
Enter here your “Column 1 Commitment.” Enter here the Big Assumption(s) that most get in your way (from your Immunity Map).	<i>New Interpersonal Behavior</i> (a) Move your project out of your own head: tell someone who you know and trust about it. (b) Observe selected Col. 2 behaviors, esp. ones that significantly work against your col. 1 goal. (c) If you are ready, alter a Col. 2 behavior. See what happens: how do others respond? How do you feel? (d) Pay attention to your body language and notice if/when it works against your Col. 1 goal (e) If you don’t know what progress on your goal looks and feels like, find someone (in person or through a book or movie) who embodies your goal and/or successfully defies your Big Assumptions. Talk to them, or watch them: what do they do and say? How might they be feeling as they engage in those productive behaviors?	<i>New Interpersonal Behavior</i> (a) Intentionally alter Col. 2 behavior(s), and notice what happens externally and internally. (b) Ask for feedback on your new behaviors from people you know and trust. (c) Notice when your Big Assumption takes you over and actively experiment to recover your balance. Act in new ways with more people, across more situations. What would that look like? <i>New Cognitive Behavior</i> – Learn more about: (a) How you benefit from acting in new ways; (b) What throws you back in your default mode; (c) What helps you prevent default mode or helps you recover your balance; and (d) Actively plan how to use your emerging stance in new situations.	<i>New Interpersonal Behavior</i> (a) Actively seek out situations that you normally avoid. (b) You’ve developed a rich repertoire of ways to stay in this “sweet spot,” or get back on track when you fall off. What would that look like in your case? <i>New Cognitive Behavior</i> (a) You know what triggers your Big Assumptions and how to avoid getting triggered. (b) You have new assessments as to the value or risks in your Col. 1 goal (i.e., there’s a new “metric” at work). What might these new metrics be for you? (c) You know you can use your new stance in new situations.

Strengthening Your Continuum of Progress continued

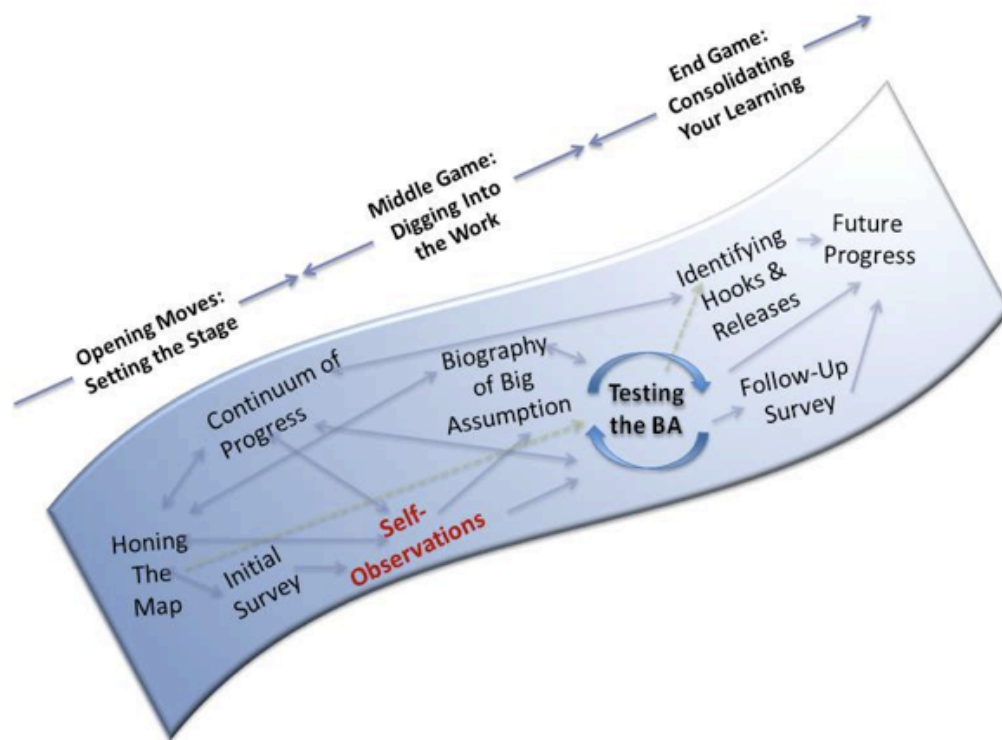
Column 1 Goal & Big Assumption(s)	1st Steps Forward	Significant Progress	Success
			→
	<i>New Cognitive Behavior</i> (a) Notice when you are engaged in col. 2 behaviors, (including your non-verbals) and notice what you are telling yourself in those situations. (b) If you are altering your behavior, what are you telling yourself? <i>New Emotional Behavior</i> (a) Notice how you are feeling as you engage in your Col. 2 behaviors. (b) If you are altering your behavior, how are you feeling in the moment? After?	<i>New Emotional Behavior</i> – You are able to: (a) Bear the discomfort of trying new behaviors that run “across your grain” (i.e., contrary to your mindset); (b) Notice new, positive feelings you may experience; (c) Allow yourself to fail from time to time, and feel okay about that. When you fail, you have ways of being kind to yourself, and have a learning stance towards your “failure;” and (d) Bear the discomfort of “neither here, nor there,” (i.e., not acting as you have in the past, but not yet acting as you would like to).	<i>New Emotional Behavior</i> – You are no longer “protecting” yourself from the new behaviors; it no longer feels like you need to. What does this look like in your case?

Chapter 4

Self-Observations

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Context for this Exercise

By now, your client should have “set the stage” for overcoming his immunity to change. He should have a map that feels compelling to him, as well as a picture of future success in realizing his self-improvement goal. He may have received input from people on the importance and value of his goal, and if so, he has a baseline of his current performance relative to this goal (or he has a new goal). Self-observations are one of several exercises that invite your client to “dig into the work.” Collectively, these exercises are designed so that your client can take a proactive stance towards his Big Assumption in order to learn about its reality.

There are two self-observation exercises: 1) Observing the Big Assumption in Action, and 2) Staying Alert to Counter-Examples of the Big Assumption. Each is described separately in this section. Both exercises strengthen our observation skills (we learn what to pay attention to in order to overcome our immunity to change, including our thoughts and feelings), and both help us to learn about the validity of our Big Assumption. An important difference between the two observation exercises is that the first leads us to see what happens when we operate out of our Big Assumption, whereas the latter tracks what happens when we are not captive of it. Looking for counter-examples of the Big Assumption assumes our Big Assumption is not 100% accurate. In both, clients are asked to take up the position of observers, of descriptive self-researchers, of ethnographers of the self; they are explicitly asked not to take up the position of change-agents or experimenters (yet). The purpose of these observations exercises is increased self-understanding; not increased self-improvement.

Part One:

OBSERVING THE BIG ASSUMPTION IN ACTION

At a Glance

Overview

The context of this first self-observation assignment is your client acting and thinking in his usual ways (in other words, allowing himself to be captive by his Big Assumptions). By not trying to change any of his behavior or thinking yet – despite his potential strong temptation to do either or both, your client can get to know his Big Assumption, how it influences how he looks at things, feels about things, takes action (or, often more importantly, chooses not to take action), makes choices, and spends his energies. In the process, your client better learns about his Big Assumptions and his accompanying experience of being captive by them, including the costs.

And in the process of learning about his Big Assumption(s), your client begins to alter his relationship to them. He is no longer simply captive of his Big Assumption; he is looking at it, rather than through it. In subject-object language, he is relating to his assumption as an object of his attention. By definition, a Big Assumption “has” us, we are “subject” to it: it leads us to see ourselves and the world in a predetermined way, and we automatically take what we see to be “the truth.” When your client takes a self-detective stance and observes his Big Assumption in action, he disrupts that automaticity. He becomes aware of it (especially when he is using it), his thoughts and feelings at the time, and the potential price he is paying for doing so.

The more your client can catch himself operating out of his Big Assumption, and the more detail he observes in those situations, the more material he has to discern a pattern of what activates his Big Assumption. When he sees a pattern, he may begin to circumscribe the power his Big Assumption has over him (i.e., he may see that it isn’t relevant 100% of the time). Noticing costs is another way he can alter his relationship to his Big Assumption: is the way he is protecting himself worth those costs?

Purpose and Benefits

- ✓ Your client better knows his Big Assumption(s), including the costs of it.
- ✓ Your client begins to develop hypotheses of what triggers his Big Assumption(s).
- ✓ Your client strengthens his observation muscles, especially of his thoughts and feelings.
- ✓ Your client's motivation continues or increases as he sees himself operating out of his Big Assumption(s) and feels the accompanying costs.
- ✓ Your client becomes more objective about his Big Assumption(s).
- ✓ You and your client gather potential material for testing his Big Assumption(s).

Five General Points about Observing the Big Assumption in Action

1. Observing the Big Assumption helps change our relationship to it. Despite its simplicity, this exercise begins the heart of the work of overcoming our immunities—building up the necessary muscles to preserve our distinction from our Big Assumption so that we can eventually mindfully test it. Careful observations begin to change our relationship to our Big Assumption, the mindset that keeps our immune system intact. What changes is that we are looking at our Big Assumption, rather than through it. If we can watch it “do its thing” in real-time, we are

no longer being so completely and unmindfully run by it. In technical terms, this amounts to learning to hold our Big Assumption as “object” rather than being reabsorbed in (once again, “subject” to) it. When we can hold something as “object,” we have the option to make choices. In the best of times, such observation can actually lead us to re-consider our Big Assumption; it loses its power over us because we are available to see more, and in seeing more, we become aware that we don't have to have our usual reactions.

2. Observing the Big Assumption helps us know it better. Because we take a self-detective stance when noticing our Big Assumption asserting itself, we have all kinds of data about our Big Assumption: When does it take over? Who were we with? What

topic was in the air? What does it look like from the outside? What's going on inside us? What were we thinking? What were we feeling? What unintended consequences or costs did we incur? Occasionally, we can learn more about our Big Assumption by discovering additional assumptions that are connected to it.

3. Collecting enough observational data allows us to identify patterns. The more we catch our Big Assumption in action, the more data we have to identify when and where it hooks us. For this reason, it is worth staying with this exercise until we have at least three observations. A common outcome at this point is for us to see that our Big Assumption is not applicable all of the time: we begin to see that there are particular circumstances that hook us. That sharper understanding allows us to be more focused and precise about what mindset we are exploring and testing in the subsequent exercises.

4. Observing the Big Assumption increases motivation to pursue the hard and often uncomfortable work of overcoming our immunity to change. Increased motivation can follow from seeing and feeling the costs of operating out of our Big Assumption. Similarly, seeing ourselves at the mercy of our Big Assumption in other arenas in our lives, or in more situations than we initially realized, can be a motivational catalyst. We see that our Big Assumption is more influential than we knew. Taking up the observer's role almost inevitably leads to a head and heart experience that we have hold of what physicists refer to as "a non-trivial phenomenon," or in more everyday language, what we might call "a big deal."

5. Observing the Big Assumption helps focus our awareness on current costs and new possibilities. When we observe ourselves being captive of our Big Assumption, we see two realities at once—the benefits of the way we take care of ourselves, and the costs we are paying for doing so. As long as we maintain that cost-benefit ratio, we maintain our immunity to change. Exploring whether it is possible to think and feel that we can still be safe while pursuing our desired change goal creates the possibility that we discover an alternative cost-benefit equation. Tackling this key change challenge requires that we first know what we think and feel. We can then "think about our feelings" and "feel our way into new ways of thinking."

It's impossible to know what else will turn up when we do self-observations. We may discover another Big Assumption connected to the original one(s) or see something new in the Big Assumption itself. Many people experience value in simply paying attention to themselves in this focused way, aware that they are already doing something different than before.

Brief Examples of Observing the Big Assumption in Action

Identifying New Dimensions of a Big Assumption

David's Big Assumption was "If I don't find a way to get things done, I'll stop being valuable." When he observed times he said "yes" to a person's request and when he didn't ask for help, he noticed what was going on inside of him and discovered that he was equating doing individual tasks himself with being important and valuable. In seeing this, he realized that his definition of how to get things done (i.e., he needed to do it himself) and his meaning of "important and valuable" were quite narrow. He hadn't known this dimension of his Big Assumption before, and it turned out to be a key feature of his mindset that he needed to alter.

Cathy's Big Assumption was that she needed to give 110% of herself at work all of the time in order to be a good team member. Her observation example is a dramatic one, but real: She watched her Big Assumption take over while she was being hospitalized for exhaustion after two days of non-stop preparation for a major client meeting! She was able to pay attention to her self-talk and what she discovered was a consuming fear that she could lose something precious at any moment and an assumption that this would happen if she did not relentlessly prove her value. Her self-observation revealed this crucial dimension of her Big Assumption.

Increasing Motivation

Claus' goal was to better prioritize. One of his 2nd column behaviors was compulsively reacting to what was in front of him. He noticed himself trying to take care of everything in every bucket on his desk one day, and also noticed himself feeling highly anxious while doing this. This one self-observation confirmed his resolve to continue the ITC work, as he felt certain that he could not go on feeling such a high level of anxiety and burden.

Increasing Sense of New Possibilities

When Ben watched himself avoid reaching out or asking for help (behaviors reflective of his Big Assumption), he also noticed that he was emotionally primed to feel rejected by people. Whether they said “no” (an outright rejection) or “yes” to him, in both cases, they might look down on him for being needy. Seeing how quickly and frequently he protected himself like this was an eye-opener for him. Having this informed insight, he felt optimistic about the prospects of feeling differently about people he might ask to help him.

Help your client understand the context for the assignment. Like all exercises, your job is to help your client to understand how the exercises connect to each other, and to the core ideas of the immunity-to-change concept (especially the connection between a column 1 improvement goal and the Big Assumption).

Engaging your Client in this Exercise

So, it would be good to take a moment to make those connections for yourself.

Which prior exercises do you see self-observations most connected to and how so?

We see this exercise as directly related to the Honing the Map exercise. In that exercise, your client uncovered the Big Assumptions that underly the hidden commitments that explain the column 2 behaviors that undermine the column 1 goal. By taking the time to observe these Big Assumptions in life, as it is now, the client will have the first opportunity to take an objective look at these assumptions to get to understand them better (after all, she has probably had years of experience looking through them; now we want to give her a chance to look at them before she can overturn them).

You may not want to say all of this, or all at the beginning of your session. It can be useful to also end your session with some of these points.

Give your client the exercise, “Self-Observing the Big Assumption in Action.”

Explain the purpose of the exercise, including an explanation of what the exercise is not. Explain the purpose, walk her through the directions, and offer an example. Take a moment now to prepare yourself for doing this. What will you say?

What are the key points to convey to your client?

Here is how we answer the question about key points:

- Resist changing your behavior.
- The purpose is to better understand your Big Assumption.
- You accomplish this by observing and taking notes about what you notice.
- What to notice: When is your Big Assumption operating? Then: Who were you with? What was the topic? Where were you? What were you thinking and feeling prior to this happening? And while it was happening?
- Write what you notice in your workbook.
- The purpose is not to immediately get better.

Doing/debriefing the work. To accomplish the goals of this exercise, you need to wear the “two hats”— that of an effective active listener and another that of an effective immunity-to-change coach. As a reminder, when you wear that first hat, you will be listening, including responding, with 3s, 4s, & 5s statements and questions at Levels 3, 4, and 5 (using our “5-point Listening Spectrum”) as your client describes his observations.

Do you understand how your client’s example makes sense as an instance of his Big Assumption in action? It isn’t unusual for a client to be vague about how a given example illustrates his Big Assumption. Alternatively, he may be clear but his explanation isn’t clear to you. Ask questions like, “Can you help me to see how your Big Assumption gets in your way in that example?” Your listening and inquiry responses provide both a mirror and a workspace for your client to see more clearly and deeply how his examples are (or aren’t) illustrations of his Big Assumption in action. Also, because of the client’s immune system, the way he makes sense of or interprets what happens may be informed by his Big Assumption. In other words, he will have an interpretation of “what happened” that is skewed by his Big Assumption and may be unable to see other ways of interpreting the situation (interpretations that would be possible if he weren’t holding his BA as true).

Tips on What to Listen for in Your Client’s Observations

Occasionally, self-observations may lead a client to an insight that what he thought was his BA isn't really at the heart of the matter. This can happen when the person catches his BA in action and he then notices his mind chatter reveals a different (sometimes related) assumption that is especially self-limiting. For example, someone observing the BA. "Authorities need me to be smaller than I am" catches himself feeling belittled when his boss says something to him. In that moment, he becomes aware that his more basic assumption is "I should know everything, all the time, or I am not good enough." He sees that he, alone, is making himself feel small by applying an unrealistic standard and that the authority's comment is what activates his self-criticism.

Do you understand your client's experiences—including his thoughts, feelings, and costs—in his examples? Learning to pay attention to our thoughts and feeling in the moment is an essential immunity-to-change skill, as is being aware of the costs we incur for being captive of our Big Assumptions. Overcoming an immunity to change is, essentially, a head-and-heart consideration of an alternative cost-benefit equation. A guiding question is whether it is possible to think and feel that we can still be safe while pursuing our desired change. Being alert to our thoughts and feelings in real time enables us to answer that question.

If your client has not named how he thought and felt at the time his Big Assumption was activated, ask him to try recreating the situation in his mind and see whether he can reconstruct his thoughts and feelings.

If you can't see how, and in what ways, it is a problem for your client when he operates out of his Big Assumption, consider explicitly asking about this. By asking about costs, the client directly faces the trade-off he is making in protecting himself as he does. You could say something like, "As you think about all these examples, how much of a problem would you say your Big Assumption is for you? Let's use a scale of 1 – 5, where '1' means 'Not at All' and '5' means 'Very Considerably/A Whole Lot.' Are there some situations where you feel the costs are higher? If so, in what ways?" (Asking about the number of situations may help increase motivation, as the person sees the extent to which his Big Assumption causes problems that go beyond simply working against his column 1 goal).

We hope that your client will find that the current price he is paying is high! This may sound perverse, but it comes from our observations over time that the wish to reduce pain or hurt often fuels people to change. (For some clients, the longing to reduce pain may also show up in the very column 1 goal they name).

Let's say you ask your client about how problematic the unintended outcomes of the situations are for him and he rates it a 3 or less. How might you respond if this happens? We encourage you to take time now to really write down what you might say!

How might you respond if your client doesn't experience the situations as problematic?

We hope that your response captured your intention to listen with both “hats,” the empathic, active listener, and the immunity-to-change coach who has a particular intention for the client, i.e., that he be in touch with a reality he may be unaware of because of his subjectivity to his Big Assumption. The idea is this: to keep in mind that the Big Assumption is getting in the way of the client making progress on his column 1 goal, which presumably is important, if not very important to him to accomplish. Help remind your client of the connection between his Big Assumption and progress on that goal, as well as other goals he may have.

What might you say to your client if you wanted to take this route to explore whether there were more problematic outcomes than he realizes?

Again, keeping in mind that there's no one right way to do this, you could say something like, "Let's go back to your column 1 goal. When we talked about this earlier, you indicated that (col. 1 goal here) was (important/very important) to you, and through the mapping process, we came to see that your Big Assumption was getting in the way of your being able to succeed at the level you want to with that commitment. Is that right? (Hear and affirm response). If so, it seems like at least in that situation, your Big Assumption is a (considerable/very considerable) problem. If we applied that same idea to these other situations, I wonder whether what you're trying to accomplish in any of the examples you just told me about is that kind of important to you too. What do you think?" Keep in mind the possibility that in some situations, the costs are higher than in others.

Another route you could take is to draw on your own hunches – based on what he had shared with you — about how his Big Assumption may be keeping him from accomplishing something important in the example(s) or how it may generate negative consequences (unintended as they may be). There are risks to this approach, as is always the case when you introduce your own interpretations.

What are some of the risks of you drawing on your hunches about potential costs your client might be incurring? How might you reduce or manage these risks?

Do you follow the “who, what, where, when” your client describes in the observation examples? These data, the particulars of what happened, are often quite straightforward and most clients report them easily. Still, it is important to know that the purpose of asking a client to name these is so that she can begin to differentiate her Big Assumptions. The all-encompassing assumption becomes more specific. Also, paying attention to the particulars focuses the person's attention and keeps her watching. The more we can watch our Big Assumption “do its thing” in real-time, the less we are being unmindfully and completely run by it. Finally, the more we catch ourselves operating out of our Big Assumption, and the more detail we observe in those situations, the more material we have to discern a pattern of what activates our Big Assumption.

Can you identify patterns across the observations? It is quite possible (and sometimes preferable) that your client will not have thought about patterns, or he has nothing to say. In that case, your role is to help your client discern patterns or themes.

Occasionally, searching for patterns leads a client to become more precise about what his Big Assumption is. This is especially likely to happen when the client is observing a very general Big Assumption. For example, the person's assumption, "I assume that if I am not seen as a good girl/daughter, then I am not loveable" becomes "I assume that if I am seen as an independent woman with a mind of her own, then my family won't accept me and won't love me". Notice how the person got much clearer about her BA, especially the "if" clause. By attending to a time she felt not loveable, she noticed that they were all occasions when she was taking a stand on an issue or asking for something for herself. Differentiating a Big Assumption in this way can also lead to more powerful outcomes in the upcoming exercises, since the person is testing a more specific assumption.

Can you identify what triggers the Big Assumption? Given his prior unawareness of his Big Assumption, your client will not know that triggers exist or what the triggers are. Depending on the quality and quantity of his observations, he may discover what triggers his Big Assumption.

Why is discerning triggers important in this work?

One answer is that identifying triggers means we have circumscribed the power of our Big Assumption, i.e., we discovered that it isn't relevant 100% of the time. That's progress. And that progress can lead to greater focus and learning when observing ourselves. How so? We can then notice the trigger in real time when it happens again and test whether that activates our Big Assumption (to provide data on whether the hypothesized trigger is a trigger). If it is indeed a trigger, then in future observations we can look to further differentiate

between people, places and times when our Big Assumption is operating (e.g., I thought it was all authority figures, but now I can see that it's just same-gender authority figures). Triggers can also be a resource to uncovering the “inner talk” that occurs when our Big Assumption is activated (e.g., I become more aware of feelings my Big Assumption generates in me and of messages I give myself about the situation, the other person, and myself). Additionally, when we focus on patterns and triggers, it is common for us to see that our Big Assumption is apparent in more domains than we initially thought (e.g., “I thought this was a problem for me in my personal life, dieting, but now I see that it causes problems for me at work as well.”) These patterns and triggers can function as a spotlight for upcoming exercises, specifically testing the Big Assumption. Our trigger situations are the ripest grounds for testing our Big Assumptions.

(At the risk of overwhelming you, this is a relevant time to point out that the line between observing and testing can be blurry, and that's ok. In other words, sometimes observing can lead us to start changing our minds (our Big Assumption) because we start to see things for the first time that lead us to naturally question the accuracy of our assumption. For example: A person with a Big Assumption “I am only as good as my last contribution” observes that he beats himself up for not being prepared for a meeting. Observing his Big Assumption in action in that moment, he then notices that other team members are not prepared either. He notices that he does not think anything less about them as a consequence, nor does he downgrade their prior contributions. He immediately becomes mindful that he need not hold himself to a standard he doesn't hold others to.)

How to Coach your Client to Uncover Patterns and Triggers

Comparing and contrasting the various examples is the most straightforward way to uncover patterns. A mix of types of questions, from very general (e.g., “Do you see any similarities across these examples?”) to very specific (e.g., “What might the people in the various examples have in common?”) can work well. Examples of questions include:

- Are there themes to the situations?
- Are there similarities in what you feel/think these situations require of you?
- Are there similar risks for you in the situations?
- Do the examples all involve the same person?
- Think back to what you were feeling before each of these situations occurred — is there any similarity there (i.e., perhaps each of the occasions was preceded by your client having a fight with someone, with having a bout of lower self-esteem etc)? .

Invite your client to respond to patterns you notice (e.g., “It strikes me that in most of these situations—general statement with examples here—what do you think about

that?") If you do offer your hunches, remember that these are your ideas, not his, and that some clients want to please their coaches by agreeing with them (whether they do or not). Managing these risks starts with your own self-awareness regarding your purposes: if some part of you wants or needs your client to see what you see, that's likely to undermine you and your client. If your purpose, by contrast, is to help expand your client's sense of possibilities, then you can engage your client's reactions and invite him to put the idea into his own words.

Consider that relevant "Big Assumption" data may be happening in real-time in your relationship with your client. This channel is worth tuning into both to help you catch yourself should you be enacting your own Big Assumption, and to hold a mirror up for your client should you suspect she might be enacting her Big Assumption with you. Drawing on real-time data can be very powerful for your client, sometimes even overpowering. Take care when you offer your observations to name that they are observations, not conclusions.

Tips and Pitfalls

Coach's Tips for Observing the Big Assumption in Action

1. Keep the purpose and intended results in mind when introducing and de-briefing the exercise: the most important outcome is that your client better know his Big Assumption, the particulars of when it gets activated, and the costs of operating out of it. In the process, your client learns the core ITC skill of self-observation, especially regarding his thoughts and feelings.
2. Remember that the purpose is not to get better or make progress directly on a column 1 goal.
3. Remember the Coach's "Two Hats": an "Appreciative Receiver" (letting your Coachee know you get what she is saying before your start pressing; be sure to empathize first) and a "Probing Inquirer" (making sure the ITC criteria below are met).

Overall tips

4. The ITC thresholds for this exercise:
 - Your client’s examples are instances of her Big Assumption in action and you follow the logic.
 - You understand your client’s experiences—her thoughts, feelings and costs in these examples.
 - You understand the particulars within the examples, any patterns across them, and any potential triggers of the Big Assumption that emerge.
 - You notice whether anything informs your client’s Continuum of Progress.
5. Appropriately leverage your “real-time” relationship with the client.

Potential Pitfalls

Coach	Client
Loses sight of the immunity-to-change dimension of the exercise (connection between mindset and behavior change). Doesn’t ask client how the observation reflects her Big Assumption (BA) in action.	Observation isn’t about her Big Assumption (BA). Or client is very focused on behavior and col. 1 goal and loses sight of how it is connected to her BA.
Doesn’t recognize that client is moving into testing (vs. observing) his BA.	Intentionally does something different and reports on that.
Fails to inquire about the nature of client’s thoughts and feelings or doesn’t probe when client discusses them.	Has a hard time knowing what she thinks and feels.
Fails to inquire about the client’s experience of the costs or doesn’t probe when client discusses.	Doesn’t appear to experience many costs of her BA operating and/or becomes more aware of “goodies” that come from holding BA as true. Has a limited notion of costs as concrete, external consequences rather than internal states, or as limited to one domain (e.g., work) rather than impacting other domains (e.g., family, personal time).

Potential Pitfalls continued



Coach	Client
Fails to keep the focus on overturning BAs as a way to make progress on the client's own 1st column goals.	Has difficulty getting what she needs from the exercise: is highly self-critical about being subject to her BA, or rationalizes about why her BA is correct, or focuses on her intellectual understanding that the BA is not valid, or has no patience to reflect and insists on moving towards action and problem solving.
Fails to probe and show client the importance of providing particulars and linking these closely to interpretations.	Offers only headlines or generalities (doesn't describe particulars). Makes large inferential leaps from what happened to what that means.
Fails to ask client to look across examples for themes, similarities, and key contributors. Fails to suggest potential patterns to client.	Has difficulty identifying patterns across instances and so can't tell how generalized or differentiated the BA is.
Loses sight of the purposes of focusing on what is within one's own capacity to change – i.e., one's self.	Directs attention outward (focusing more on what others are doing and saying and their responsibilities than on own contributions).
Loses sight of "real-time" relationship with client. Occurs when coach loses sight of personal BAs that may be interfering with own effectiveness as coach, and/or doesn't notice the client's BA operating in their coaching relationship.	Becomes defensive when coach shares observations of real-time dynamics between them that may reflect the client's BA in action.

Part Two:

OBSERVING NATURALLY OCCURRING COUNTERS TO THE BIG ASSUMPTION

At a Glance

Overview

Whereas in the first self-observation exercise your client is asked to notice himself captive of his Big Assumption, in this exercise, he will observe what happens when he is not captive of his Big Assumption. He is looking for spontaneously occurring experiences that could lead him to question the truthfulness or widespread applicability of his Big Assumption. Big Assumptions maintain their power over us due to our certainty about their accuracy, a certainty which arises from their self-sealing operation: they direct our attention to what we see and ensure that we systematically avoid or ignore other data. In order for this to work, we must remain unaware of this happening. The intent of counter-observations is to turn off the automatic pilot, actively search out information our Big Assumption doesn't permit us to see, and notice what we see.

Like the prior observation exercise, you ask your client not to change any of his behavior or thinking. This will allow him to discover already existing, unexpected evidence that his Big Assumption is inaccurate, not always applicable, or wrong. In engaging in this exercise, as in the prior one, your client will also strengthen his observation skills (we learn what to pay attention to in order to overcome our immunity to change, including our thoughts and feelings), and learn about the validity of his Big Assumption.

Purpose and Benefits

- ✓ Your client better knows his Big Assumption(s).
- ✓ Your client hones hypotheses of what triggers his Big Assumption(s).
- ✓ Your client further strengthens his observation muscles, especially of his thoughts and feelings.
- ✓ Your client's motivation continues or increases as he sees that his Big Assumption(s) are not 100% accurate.
- ✓ Your client becomes more objective about his Big Assumption.
- ✓ You and your client gather potential material for testing his Big Assumption.

1. This assignment follows from the widely shared observation that people, as meaning-makers, are highly selective about what data they attend to (and consequently, to what data they are missing or blind to); furthermore, they are unaware that they are filtering information. This process leads to self-sealing meanings. In other words, because only the data which confirm one's meanings are brought into focus, and data which would challenge or even refute one's meanings are avoided or interpreted in a way that aligns with the person's need to see it in a certain light, the person's meanings remain intact. This is the essence of what happens with the Big Assumption—because we take our assumption as truth, it in turn leads us to see some things, yet not other things, with the result that our assumption continues to permeate our meanings. Mindful attention to situations that run counter to an assumption disrupts this self-sealing process when we actively seek data that our Big Assumption leads us to ignore. We become objective about the data we seek and the meaning we make of that.

Six General Points about Observing Naturally Occurring Counters to the Big Assumption in Action

2. Note that we are not intentionally altering our behavior but instead attending to naturally occurring instances of counters to our Big Assumption. There is a later exercise in which we are intentionally and mindfully changing our behavior to see its effects, but that is saved for a time when the coach has had an opportunity to help us plan for an experiment. A typical kind of counter-example occurs when we simply notice something happening that our Big Assumption would not predict. For example, a client with a Big Assumption “I assume that if I show signs of vulnerability at work, I will be unable to compartmentalize my feelings and will lose focus,” may notice that she feels quite comfortable with one of her work colleagues and can occasionally be more emotionally open with her when they have lunch together. After lunch, she can get back to work without feeling that her focus has been compromised. Or, she may notice that there are others she works with who can be quite vulnerable at times without losing their focus. Both observations lead her to question the rigidity of her own Big Assumption.

Another type of counter-example occurs when we have no choice but to do something different because of circumstances. In this case, the altered behavior is something we would have done independent of this assignment; the assignment simply directs our attention to the outcome of it. Here's an example: someone with a Big Assumption “I assume that if I am not directly involved in the work, the quality will suffer” ends up having no choice but to turn a piece of work over to someone while she is called out for a family emergency. Upon her return, she discovers that the person she left in charge of this work did an absolutely fine job.

3. Discovering even one counter-example (even though most people typically find more) can be valuable, since this alone can suggest that our Big Assumption may not be as uniformly true as we have always believed. This can begin to loosen the Big Assumption's grip on us. From even one instance, we can also begin to ask whether there are any predictable occasions in which it will again not be true. In reality, most of us discover several instances. In addition to the outcomes already named, in this case, we may have ample data to test our emerging hypotheses about what triggers our Big Assumption and to refine the Big Assumption if possible (e.g., we thought the trigger was authority figures, but a counter example occurred with a woman we view as an authority figure. We then see that our Big Assumption is relevant only with male authority figures). We can later draw on this refinement to help us craft highly focused intentional tests of our Big Assumption (the "Testing the Big Assumption" exercise follows the next one, "The Biography of the Big Assumption").

4. We also have access to different thoughts and feelings than we imagined were possible while we were only seeing through our Big Assumptions. Typically these thoughts and feelings are quite liberating and can even be positive (exactly the opposite of what we had been thinking and feeling would happen!).

5. Finding natural challenges can also inspire us to feel that it is possible to change. We now know that we can, in fact, do something we have assumed we couldn't do, even if it is a tiny instance. What at first seemed like a dry well, can begin to be a new source of energy.

6. Perhaps most important, this exercise (and the prior self-observation exercise) builds the necessarily muscles both to focus our awareness and to make connections between what we do and what's going on internally (what doing "X" tells us about our mindset). When we observe situations that run counter to our Big Assumption, and we tune into our thoughts and feeling in real-time, we discover that the worst case scenarios we assumed, are not only not true—at least in this situation—but that sometimes very positive outcomes occur. This opens the door to re-assessing and revising our long-held cost-benefit ratio of risk to reward.

Ben's Big Assumption was this: "If I'm truly open to people, I risk revealing my neediness/weaknesses/shortcomings and will likely be rejected, disappointed, ignored, or overlooked, and end up feeling an even greater sense of aloneness. Better to pretend to not need/want/be able to find a partner." While he had no plans to discuss this with his best friend, he found himself spontaneously sharing his "ah ha" over a drink. She was surprised to hear this, and reminded Ben of all the ways he acted just the opposite in their relationship: he reached out to her and actively pursued her friendship, even when he was seemingly rebuffed. Ben fondly remembered several occasions when this had happened. He used this counter-data to further focus his ITC work by actively exploring what allowed him to pursue that relationship so openly.

Brief Examples of Observing Naturally Occurring Counters of the Big Assumption

Anna's goal to get better at prioritizing her research and writing was very important to her. The theme across her column 2 entries was that she was saying "yes" to other people's requests for her time, but she was not following through consistently with her own work. Her Big Assumption? That she was not good enough, and her work would not be good enough to pass the high standards of her chosen field. After sharing this insight with her ITC mapping partner, her partner asked Anna to describe what she had been up to in her own work, and then asked Anna a few questions about specific pieces of it. Her self-assessment of this specific, recently completed work, surprisingly led Anna to conclude that it had more heft and quality than she gave herself credit for. She realized at that moment that in all her second guessing, she hadn't had the courage to look directly at what she was producing. A scientist by training, seeing this "counter-data" to her assumption that she was not-good-enough fueled her determination to overcome her self-doubt, and it provided a template for what she knew she needed to do to get unstuck: create more time and mechanisms to do her work, get it out there, and see what she thought of it.

Help your client understand the context for the assignment. Like all exercises, your job is to help your client to understand how the exercises connect to each other, and to the core ideas of the Immunity-to-Change concept, especially the connection between a column 1 improvement goal and the Big Assumption.

Engaging your Client in this Exercise

Which prior exercises do you see self-observations most connected to and how so?

Here are the connections we see: This exercise is directly related to the Honing the Map exercise. In that exercise, your client uncovered the Big Assumptions that underly the hidden commitments that explain the column 2 behaviors that undermine the column 1 goal. By taking the time to observe these Big Assumptions in life, as it is now, the client will have the first opportunity to take an objective look at these assumptions to get to understand them better (after all, she has probably had years of experience looking through them; now we want to give her a chance to look at them before she can overturn them).

Your client's counter observations and reflections may also connect to his Continuum of Progress.

You may not want to say all of this, or all at the beginning of your session. It can be useful to also end your session with some of these points, including asking your client whether he wants to update his Continuum of Progress based on any take-aways from debriefing his counter observations.

Give your client the exercise, "Observing Naturally Occurring Counters to the Big Assumption."

Explain the purpose of the exercise, including an explanation of what the exercise is not. Explain the purpose, walk your client through the directions, and offer an example. You may want to be explicit about the rationale for this assignment and convey the same message to your client as we have to you (i.e., research on people's meaning-making, predictable biases in data selection and interpretation, self-sealing meanings, a tendency to be unaware of this, and how all of this connects to the Big Assumption). We

suggest you be explicit at this time so you can begin introducing the idea of meanings filtering data, a concept that actively runs through the rest of the sessions. Consider giving your client a reading on this topic, as it can help him to better understand the idea and not take it personally (see Personal Mastery in Senge's *The Fifth Discipline*, as well as Chris Argyris' *Ladder of Inference*).

Take a moment now to prepare yourself for doing this. What will you say?

What are the key points to convey when explaining the purpose of and ideas behind this exercise?

Here is how we answer the question about key points:

- Don't try to do anything different than usual, other than paying attention.
- Purpose is to learn more about your Big Assumption, specifically when it is not accurate.
- You accomplish this by observing and taking notes about what you notice.
- What to notice: when your Big Assumption should be operating but isn't. Then: who were you with? What topic? Where were you? What were you thinking and feeling prior to this happening? And while it was happening?
- Write what you notice in your workbook.
- The purpose is not to immediately get better.

It's worth mentioning that when some clients hear the directions to this exercise, their first reaction is one of doubt. That's understandable: by looking out at the world through Big Assumptions (being subject to them), a person who imagines looking for counter-instances will predict that nothing will turn up, that the exercise is going to be a waste of time, or like looking for a needle in a haystack. Respond with your "two hats" here, including encouragement that searching for, or even staying open to, counter-instances usually leads to

their appearance, the way you can shift your vision from looking through a windshield to looking at it. It is there, all the time, but we just don't see it until we see it.

Doing/debriefing the work. To accomplish the goals of this exercise, you need to wear the same “two hats” we’ve discussed — that of an effective active listener and that of an effective immunity-to-change coach. As a reminder, when you wear that first hat, you will be listening, including responding, with statements and questions at Levels 3, 4, and 5 (using our “5-point Listening Spectrum”) as your client describes his observations.

Being an effective immunity-to-change coach for this exercise requires that you listen for and respond to four dimensions:

1. How your client's examples illuminate how his Big Assumption may be somehow incorrect or incomplete;
2. Your client experiences (thoughts, feelings and costs) in these examples;
3. The particulars within the examples, as well as any patterns across them; and
4. Whether anything informs your client's Continuum of Progress.

If you cross these various thresholds, you will be helping your client to get the most out of this exercise (see next section for more about each of these, including why they are important and what you can do).

Do you understand how your client's example illuminates how his Big Assumption may be somehow incorrect or incomplete? The client may be vague about how a given example counters or challenges his Big Assumption (i.e., he knows in his gut that this is a counter example but he doesn't know how it is, or he can't explain it), or he may be clear but his explanation isn't clear to you. It can be useful to ask a general question (e.g., "Can you help me to see how this example suggests your Big Assumption may not be totally accurate?"). Eventually, you will want to get to the specifics of the actual outcome in the situation and your client's interpretation of that. This can be rich territory as it takes you, once again, into the person's meaning making. Your listening and inquiry responses to what you hear will provide him both a mirror and a work space to see more clearly and deeply how his examples are counter--observations of his Big Assumption in action.

Tips on What to Listen for in your Client's Naturally Occurring Counter-Observations

What if your client brings in an example of data based on someone else doing what his Big Assumption wouldn't allow? (e.g., your client's Big Assumption is that giving immediate feedback to people on the team will lead to being punished. He brings in an example of someone in his team who commented on the leader's shift of topic, and how the result was unexpected: the recipient said "you're absolutely right" and the meeting resumed with more coherence.)

Your client shares observations that challenge his Big Assumption, but the data is based on someone else's actions. How would you respond? Explain why.

What matters most at this point is that the counter example illuminates how your client's Big Assumption may be less than absolutely true, and your client can explain how. So it's fine if the example is about another person or about himself.

What if your client brings in a counter-example that resulted from him altering his behavior? This is not uncommon! Many people are action-centric and are chomping at the bit to "get going already." Let's hope that the test was a relatively safe one, mostly importantly. In people's enthusiasm for action and progress, they can sometimes do too much and with exactly the people they ought not try to do things differently before they have prepared differently for how to act.

Assuming your client didn't get himself into hot waters by changing his behavior, does his example qualify for a counter-example? What do you think? How would you handle this situation?

Hopefully, your response included at least the following:

1. You asked him to unpack the situation so you both see how what happened counters his Big Assumption (i.e., the behavior was one his Big Assumption typically would lead him to avoid and how the consequences of acting that way were inconsistent with what his Big Assumption predicts); and
2. You helped him to see his hand in creating this different reality (i.e., he enacted a new behavior and was open to seeing an unexpected outcome).

Do you follow the “who, what, where, when” your client sees in the examples?

Identifying the particulars in a counter-situation is important for the same reasons as when your client was observing his Big Assumption in action: he begins to differentiate the Big Assumption, and gets an increasingly clear and specific picture of what the “if” and “then” portions of his assumption entail.

Do you understand your client’s experiences — his thoughts, feelings, and costs — in these examples?

Has your client named these thoughts and feelings? If not, ask him to try recreating the situation in his mind and see whether he can reconstruct his thoughts and feelings. Again, learning to pay attention to what we are thinking and feeling is an essential immunity-to-change skill, as is being aware of the sometimes surprising benefits or positive outcomes when we are not captive of our Big Assumptions. Overcoming our immunity to change is, essentially, a head-and-heart consideration of an alternative cost-benefit equation. Learning whether it is possible to think and feel that we can still be safe while pursuing a change is the key change challenge. To accomplish this, we must first learn to be alert to our thoughts and feelings.

Did your client experience any positive outcomes in any of his examples?

A counter-example can illustrate how the Big Assumption’s negative prediction does not come to be, and that is progress for a client to see. It’s also possible that the outcome was positive, the opposite of what his Big Assumption would predict. (E.g., in the example above, your client’s Big Assumption is that giving immediate feedback to people on the team will lead to being punished. He brings in an example of someone in his team who commented on the leader’s shift of topic, and how the result was unexpected: the leader said, “You’re absolutely right” and the meeting resumed with more coherence. Not only was the commenter not punished, he was confirmed by the leader and the meeting improved.) That new and different meaning can be very exciting and liberating for your client. When a client sees surprising positive outcomes, he may feel like there is more where that came from, and seek to create that reality! (He may also believe that this was an unusual incident and want to minimize any excitement. That’s fine too. He will have more opportunities to explore whether there is anything to generalize from this counter-example when he begins to explicitly test his Big Assumption). We want to learn about positive outcomes to fuel the client’s motivation to stay focused on developing a more informed,

reality-based relationship to his Big Assumption and in the process, have raw material to reformulate his assumed cost-benefit ratio. The more your client enjoys the current upshot of situations that run counter to his Big Assumption, the better!

Can you identify any patterns? Counter-examples provide an additional benefit, which is that they can generate information your client can use to explore his hunches about what activates his assumption (the “if” in his Big Assumption), or the outcomes (the “then” portion). For example, let’s say the person with the BA, “I assume that if I am not directly involved in the work, the quality will suffer” hypothesized that this assumption is activated with everyone in her department. Her counter-example suggests that the hypothesis is too general and that there is at least one person whom she can trust to meet her standards of performance. Sharing an example of what you mean here will help anchor this abstract idea.

If your client named patterns from observing his Big Assumption in action, it’s worth reviewing as you debrief the counter-examples. Again, comparing and contrasting will be useful. A mix of types of questions, from very general (e.g., “What does the outcome in this counter-example say about working hypotheses?”) to very specific (e.g., “What does the fact that Mary met your expectations for successful work say about our working hypotheses that your BA gets activated whenever you work with anyone in your department?”) can work well in this move.

Can any of your client’s observations and reflections enhance her Continuum of Progress? Observing what we are thinking and feeling while we are not captive to our Big Assumptions is likely to be rich material for a Continuum of Progress. This is especially the case if your client wasn’t able to imagine what it could be like, internally, if she were free of her Big Assumption. Does your client’s CoP capture and build on the kinds of thoughts and feeling revealed in this exercise? Ask your client whether she sees any connections.

Tips and Pitfalls

Coach's Tips for "Observing Naturally Occurring Counters to the Big Assumption"



1. Keep the purpose and intended results in mind when introducing and de-briefing the exercise: the most important outcome is that your client better know his Big Assumption, *specifically when it is inaccurate or not applicable*. In the process, your client learns the core ITC skill of self-observation, especially regarding his thoughts and feelings.
2. Remember that the purpose is not to get better or make progress directly on a column 1 goal.
3. Remember the Coach's "Two Hats": an "Appreciative Receiver" (letting your Coachee know you get what she is saying before you start pressing: be sure to empathize first) and a "Probing Inquirer" (making sure the ITC criteria below are met).
4. The ITC thresholds for this exercise:
 - Your client's examples are instances that challenge his Big Assumption and you follow the logic.
 - You understand your client experiences—his thoughts, feelings and costs in these examples .
 - You understand the particulars within the examples, any patterns across them, and any thematic exceptions to the Big Assumption's accuracy.
 - You notice whether anything informs your client's Continuum of Progress.
5. Appropriately leverage your "real-time" relationship with the client.



Potential Pitfalls

Coach	Client
Loses sight of the immunity-to-change dimension of the exercise (connection between mindset and behavior change). Doesn't ask client how the observation reflects his/her BA in action.	Observation isn't about his Big Assumption. Or client very focused on behavior and column 1 commitment and loses sight of how it is connected to his BA.
Doesn't caution client about risks in spontaneously changing behavior. Doesn't recognize that client is moving into testing (vs. observing) his BA.	Sees the intention of the exercise as an opportunity to behave differently.
Fails to inquire about the nature of client's thoughts and feelings or doesn't probe when client discusses.	Has a hard time knowing what he thinks and feels.
Fails to help client imagine possible settings or circumstances to observe or doesn't probe when client discusses.	Cannot identify any naturally-occurring counters to the BA.
Fails to probe and show client the importance of providing particulars and linking these closely to interpretations.	Offers only headlines or generalities (doesn't describe particulars). Makes large inferential leaps from what happened to what that means.
Fails to ask client to look across examples for themes, similarities, key contributors. Fails to suggest potential patterns to client.	Has difficulty identifying patterns across instances.
Loses sight of the purpose of focusing on what is within one's own capacity to change – one's self.	Directs attention outward (focusing more on what others are doing and saying and their responsibilities than on own contributions).

In-depth Examples of Self- Observations: Jackson & Amanda

Jackson's Observations

Jackson was beginning to see how much the ITC work was centered on his Big Assumptions, and he was needing less help from his coach to focus his attention on them rather than on his column one goal or his behaviors. When he began the Observations exercise, he decided to write his Big Assumptions on note cards which he kept inside his desk for handy reference. On top of his desk, he kept one card that said “BIG ASSUMPTIONS” as a reminder to be watching for them. Over the course of the two weeks he was observing, he identified two situations of his Big Assumptions at work that seemed very important to them and which he wanted to discuss with his coach.

Jackson's Big Assumptions: *“I assume that saying anything about my accomplishments is bragging. And I assume that if I am bragging, I am just like Kurt (also selfish, arrogant, etc.)”*

**Observing the Big Assumption
in Action: Situation & Costs**



Describe situation where Big Assumption got in your way	Describe costs to you ("What did it block, prevent or impair?")
Situation #1: I had lunch with some clients last week. Two pretty senior guys from XXX were at the lunch too. After the lunch, I could have found a way to walk back over to our building with the two guys – to talk casually with them and let them know what I have been doing for these clients. I hung back and didn't take that opportunity. I let them go ahead while I used the restroom, made some calls. I figure they don't want to be bothered, would see through my comments to find what I was doing to be bragging and pestering.	Situation #1: I missed an opportunity for them to hear what I have been doing.
Situation #2: Colleague who is generally assumed to be on the fast track here told me that he keeps a list of things he wants key people (like senior management) to know about. He updates the list regularly, and reviews it every Friday. Then he makes a plan for how during the following week he is going to let key people know about what's on the list. This kind of thing would never occur to me.	Situation #2: Well, I guess that's why he is on the fast track and I'm not!
Situation #3:	Situation #3:
Situation #4:	Situation #4:

Observing the Big Assumption in Action: Reflections

Reflection Question	Your Response
What stands out to you? What do you notice most of all?	It takes a lot of work for me to identify opportunities I don't take. Even when they occur to me, I have a really hard time imagining me doing them.
What does your BA do to you? What thoughts, feelings, perspectives, actions, and choices do you experience as a consequence of your BA?	It keeps me from having to make myself uncomfortable, from worrying that I'm annoying other people and myself.
Do you see patterns, i.e., are there particular types of people, content areas, circumstances (inside yourself or in the environment) that activate your BA?	Senior management. Self-promoters.
Any "ah ha"?	
Do you notice any additional Big Assumptions you are making? If so, add these to your 4-column map.	
What are your key take-aways? Any implications for your Continuum of Progress? If so, add these.	

Observing Counter Examples of the Big Assumption

Describe situation that casts doubt on your Big Assumption (including your thoughts & feelings)	How does what happened cast doubt on the absolute truth of your Big Assumption?
Counter Observation #1: Didn't really notice anything like this.	Counter Observation #1:.
Counter Observation #2:	Counter Observation #2:
Counter Observation #3:	Counter Observation #3:
Counter Observation #4	Counter Observation #4:

Observing Counter Examples of the Big Assumption: Reflections



Reflection Question	Your Response
What stands out to you? What do you notice most of all?	
What thoughts, feelings, perspectives, actions, and choices did you experience in these instances?	
Do you see any patterns? Is the same doubt about your Big Assumption raised across the different instances? Is there anything in common across the examples that might account for the counter-data? (e.g., particular types of people, content areas, circumstances, inside yourself or in the environment).	
Did you act differently than your Big Assumption would have you act? If so, what did you do? What are your hunches about why you acted differently? Was it because of something “out there,” or something you said to yourself, or some combination of the two, or anything else?	
What does the counter-data suggest to you about your Big Assumption?	
What are your key take-aways? Are there any additions or revisions you’d want to make to your Continuum of Progress based on these observations?	

Jackson’s coach wanted to see if there were additional insights that could be generated when they reflected on the observations Jackson had done. He was particularly struck by how much difficulty Jackson was having imagining doing or thinking in any way different from the status quo. He decided that they should begin their session by reviewing the Continuum of Progress to help remind Jackson how he had imagined a different possibility. Then as they debriefed each observation example, he wanted Jackson to focus on what was happening internally (his thoughts and feelings) that made it hard to see his Big Assumptions as assumptions (and not just the way things are). He was hoping he might also be able

to help Jackson reflect back over the two weeks for any potential examples of counters to his Big Assumptions.

As they debriefed, Jackson began to realize that he tended only to notice self-promotion when it was over-the-top and overly opportunistic. He decided to begin focusing more on what types of self-promoting strategies were appealing to him. In discussing this with his coach he realized that his wife had been suggesting something similar to him (and recorded this exchange as an additional observation). Prompted by his coach, Jackson identified a few people who might serve as this type of “self-promotion role model” for him. He also tried to reconstruct recent interactions with them to see if he could identify what they were doing that he saw as preferable, effective, and worthy of emulation.

Version 2

Observing the Big Assumption in Action: Situation & Costs

Describe situation where Big Assumption got in your way	Describe costs to you ("What did it block, prevent or impair?")
Situation #1: I had lunch with some clients last week. Two pretty senior guys from XXX were at the lunch too. After the lunch, I could have found a way to walk back over to our building with the two guys – to talk casually with them and let them know what I have been doing for these clients. I hung back and didn't take that opportunity. I let them go ahead while I used the restroom, made some calls. I figure they don't want to be bothered, would see through my comments to find what I was doing to be bragging and pestering.	Situation #1: I missed an opportunity for them to hear what I have been doing.
Situation #2: Colleague who is generally assumed to be on the fast track here told me that he keeps a list of things he wants key people (like senior management) to know about. He updates the list regularly, and reviews it every Friday. Then he makes a plan for how during the following week he is going to let key people know about what's on the list. This kind of thing would never occur to me.	Situation #2: Well, I guess that's why he is on the fast track and I'm not!
Situation #3: My wife asked me why I don't read or go to a training on self-promotion. I dismissed this idea immediately.	Situation #3: I could have learned some new skills and strategies.

Observing the Big Assumption in Action: Reflections

Reflection Question	Your Response
What stands out to you? What do you notice most of all?	It takes a lot of work for me to identify opportunities I don't take. Even when they occur to me, I have a really hard time imagining myself doing them.
What does your BA do to you? What thoughts, feelings, perspectives, actions, and choices do you experience as a consequence of your BA?	It keeps me from having to make myself uncomfortable, from worrying that I'm annoying other people and myself.
Do you see patterns, i.e., are there particular types of people, content areas, circumstances (inside yourself or in the environment) that activate your BA?	Senior management. Self-promoters.
Any "ah ha"?	I tend to notice (and think about) self-promotion as always done in a way that is bragging, arrogant. I don't pay attention to situations where it is done more skillfully.
Do you notice any additional Big Assumptions you are making? If so, add these to your 4-column map.	Self-promotion = bragging, arrogance. Other people also hate to see people engage in self-promotion (even though I can clearly see how self-promotion can pay off for others). I've been calling that one into question since reading my survey results.
What are your key take-aways? Any implications for your Continuum of Progress? If so, add these.	

Observing Counter Examples of the Big Assumption

Describe situation that casts doubt on your Big Assumption (including your thoughts & feelings)	How does what happened cast doubt on the absolute truth of your Big Assumption?
Counter Observation #1: There are a few people who do publicize their accomplishments in ways that seem much more elegant and classy. They seem to have a really good sense of when is the right time to do this. Mostly they seem to do it in very matter-of-fact ways – they don't get embarrassed to talk about (or have others talk about) what they did.	Counter Observation #1: I need to watch more carefully what they do and how they do it. Maybe talk to them about how they developed this approach.

Observing Counter Examples of the Big Assumption: Reflections



Reflection Question	Your Response
What stands out to you? What do you notice most of all?	I haven't been looking for instances of when self-publicity is done well. It's like I don't even see it because I'm focusing so much on the bad things.
What thoughts, feelings, perspectives, actions, and choices did you experience in these instances?	
Do you see any patterns? Is the same doubt about your Big Assumption raised across the different instances? Is there anything in common across the examples that might account for the counter-data? (e.g., particular types of people, content areas, circumstances, inside yourself or in the environment).	I've been so focused on what I don't like and don't want to do that I haven't paid attention to what I could be doing better/instead.
Did you act differently than your Big Assumption would have you act? If so, what did you do? What are your hunches about why you acted differently? Was it because of something "out there," or something you said to yourself, or some combination of the two, or anything else?	
What does the counter-data suggest to you about your Big Assumption?	I don't see counter-data! I thought I was working hard to find instances of it, but I have probably been missing tons (and mostly counter-examples).
What are your key take-aways? Are there any additions or revisions you'd want to make to your Continuum of Progress based on these observations?	Add that I should be actively observing for when others publicize their accomplishments in ways I'd like to try on.

Amanda's Observations

Big Assumption: *"I assume that if I don't have lots of options, I will feel resentful, angry, impotent, and stressed. Life will be bleak."*

Observing the Big Assumption in Action: Situation & Costs

Describe situation where Big Assumption got in your way	Describe costs to you ("What did it block, prevent or impair?")
Situation #1: I've been trying to eat better, but whenever I go out with others, I want to order whatever I want. I want to have a beer or two, spend a long time catching up, order appetizers and/or desserts.	Situation #1: I feel like if I can't eat what I want, I won't have as much fun.
Situation #2: When I get home from work, I'm really tired. I just want to put my feet up, watch TV, have a beer and a snack before getting up to make dinner. Sometimes I don't even feel like making dinner, so I'll just order out. The idea of getting home and not eating or starting to make just a healthy dinner and then going to the gym makes me too tired.	Situation #2: I feel like I should be able to relax after a really hard day at work.
Situation #3: My mom called me the other day because she is worried about my brother. She wants me to go over to her house and have dinner with her so we can talk. I want to go but I know I'll just eat a lot there. She doesn't really cook very healthy foods. But I can't tell her I don't want to go – she is already so stressed.	Situation #3: If I don't go, my mom will be more stressed, and I'll feel guilty.
Situation #4:	Situation #4:

Observing Counter Examples of the Big Assumption



Describe situation that casts doubt on your Big Assumption (including your thoughts & feelings)	How does what happened cast doubt on the absolute truth of your Big Assumption?
Counter Observation #1: Yesterday I was really good. I didn't go out to lunch with co-workers, even though I really wanted to. I had brought a salad from home, which was in the fridge. I knew it would go bad if I didn't eat it. But it tasted pretty not-fresh. I felt hungry the rest of the day.	Counter Observation #1: Wished I could have gone with them and just ordered a salad at the restaurant. It would have tasted better!
Counter Observation #2 I've been trying to go to the gym right after work (instead of going home first). It works as long as I remember to bring my gym clothes with me in the morning.	Counter Observation #2: OK – hard to remember to bring the clothes, esp. when I'm in a rush. Sometimes I forget that it's gym-time, and then when I remember, it's like, "Oh no!"
Counter Observation #3:	Counter Observation #3:
Counter Observation #4	Counter Observation #4:

Observing Counter Examples of the Big Assumption: Reflections



Reflection Question	Your Response
What stands out to you? What do you notice most of all?	My life is pretty stressful.
What thoughts, feelings, perspectives, actions, and choices did you experience in these instances?	I get annoyed when I think that I shouldn't eat or drink what I want and when I want.

Observing Counter-Examples of the Big Assumption: Reflections continued

Reflection Question	Your Response
Do you see any patterns? Is the same doubt about your Big Assumption raised across the different instances? Is there anything in common across the examples that might account for the counter-data? (e.g., particular types of people, content areas, circumstances, inside yourself or in the environment).	Friends and family. Maybe certain types of day, when I'm tired.
Did you act differently than your Big Assumption would have you act? If so, what did you do? What are your hunches about why you acted differently? Was it because of something "out there," or something you said to yourself, or some combination of the two, or anything else?	
What does the counter-data suggest to you about your Big Assumption?	
What are your key take-aways? Are there any additions or revisions you'd want to make to your Continuum of Progress based on these observations?	It is hard to diet when I'm stressed!

Amanda's coach could see that the underlying logic of the ITC process was still difficult for Amanda to grasp. Her reflective notes on her observations did not address the "costs" of her Big Assumptions at all. Instead, they seemed like justifications for her behavior. And her observations of natural counters also seemed to focus on ways she had behaved differently but these incidents did not seem to challenge her assumptions. When the two met next to discuss the observations exercise, Amanda's coach knew it would be important to keep bringing Amanda back to focusing on her Big Assumptions and to understand why they were at the center of this whole process. She wanted to keep underscoring the issue of how Amanda was making sense of these incidents in light of her Big Assumptions.

She also wanted to spend some time talking with Amanda about her inclinations to see her choices about what and how much to eat as her own choices, not something that others were responsible for. Was there another Big Assumption here that they had not yet identified?

Version 2

Observing the Big Assumption in Action: Situation & Costs

Describe situation where Big Assumption got in your way	Describe costs to you ("What did it block, prevent or impair?")
Situation #1: I've been trying to eat better, but whenever I go out with others, I want to order whatever I want. I want to have a beer or two, spend a long time catching up, order appetizers and/or desserts. I feel like if I can't eat what I want, I won't have as much fun.	Situation #1: I gained 2 pounds this week. I had fun while we were out, but then later I felt bad because I knew that I had messed up. I also felt too-full and too-buzzed, and I didn't like feeling that way.
Situation #2: When I get home from work, I'm really tired. I just want to put my feet up, watch TV, have a beer and a snack before getting up to make dinner. Sometimes I don't even feel like making dinner, so I'll just order out. The idea of getting home and not eating or starting to make just a healthy dinner and then going to the gym makes me too tired. I feel like I should be able to relax after a really hard day at work.	Situation #2: It gets me off track and then I give up. Once I start drinking and watching TV, I don't want to get up again. It's easier to order out. I don't eat very well and start to feel bad about myself that I can't do better. Then I give up and eat whatever I want, more than I should and things like dessert.
Situation #3: My mom called me the other day because she is worried about my brother. She wants me to go over to her house and have dinner with her so we can talk. I want to go but I know I'll just eat a lot there. She doesn't really cook very healthy foods. But I can't tell her I don't want to go – she is already so stressed. I feel like I should be able to relax after a really hard day at work.	Situation #3: I mix food with other issues – I let my feelings about my mom control whether I eat with her and how much. Then I give up on my diet. I don't consider other ways I could help her – like going to talk but not eating with her, or asking her to help me eat healthier foods.
Situation #4: Yesterday I was really good. I didn't go out to lunch with co-workers, even though I really wanted to. I had brought a salad from home thought, which was in the fridge. I knew it would go bad if I didn't eat it. But it tasted pretty not-fresh. I felt hungry the rest of the day. Wished I could have gone with them and just ordered a salad at the restaurant. It would have tasted better!	Situation #4: I guess my BA got in my way in that I kind of dwelled on this and felt deprived. I felt like I didn't have choices, although I did make a choice, and there were probably different things I could have done.

Observing Counter Examples of the Big Assumption

Describe situation that casts doubt on your Big Assumption (including your thoughts & feelings)	How does what happened cast doubt on the absolute truth of your Big Assumption?
Counter Observation #1: On Thursday I was really busy and didn't have time for a real lunch. I ate a quick and pretty healthy lunch at my desk while reading over Stan's report. I didn't feel terrible because I didn't have time to think about it. Maybe I need to get busier and more stressed! LOL!	Counter Observation #1: I didn't feel resentful, angry or stressed, even though I didn't have any good food options!
Counter Observation #2 I've been trying to go to the gym right after work (instead of going home first). It works as long as I remember to bring my gym clothes with me in the morning.	Counter Observation #2: OK – hard to remember to bring the clothes, esp. when I'm in a rush. Sometimes I forget that it's gym-time, and then when I remember, it's like, "Oh no!" I realize that I can change my familiar patterns and get used to a more active life without feeling like I am making a huge sacrifice.

Observing Counter Examples of the Big Assumption: Reflections

Reflection Question	Your Response
What stands out to you? What do you notice most of all?	My life is pretty stressful. I use food and drink as a way to relieve stress. This may be more of what I'm used to doing and not something I need to do.
What thoughts, feelings, perspectives, actions, and choices did you experience in these instances?	I get annoyed when I think that I shouldn't eat or drink what I want and when I want. I focus my annoyance on other people or circumstances, as if someone else is doing something to me, not like it is me making that decision.

Observing Counter-Examples of the Big Assumption: Reflections continued

Reflection Question	Your Response
Do you see any patterns? Is the same doubt about your Big Assumption raised across the different instances? Is there anything in common across the examples that might account for the counter-data? (e.g., particular types of people, content areas, circumstances, inside yourself or in the environment).	Friends and family. Maybe certain types of day, when I'm tired. Having enough time free and the option to eat/drink. Getting into routines that aren't healthy – they are harder to break because it is easiest just to keep going with them. But I do have a choice. Need to keep thinking about this one to remind myself that I make my own choices!
Did you act differently than your Big Assumption would have you act? If so, what did you do? What are your hunches about why you acted differently? Was it because of something "out there," or something you said to yourself, or some combination of the two, or anything else?	I planned better (brought my workout clothing with me). I ate something I wasn't excited about but it was fine. It wasn't because of something I said to myself, it was because I was so absorbed in my work.
What does the counter-data suggest to you about your Big Assumption?	I have a choice.
What are your key take-aways? Are there any additions or revisions you'd want to make to your Continuum of Progress based on these observations?	It is hard to diet when I'm stressed! I see my decisions to eat or not as my choices. To stay on my diet is my choice. To go off my diet is my choice, NO ONE ELSE!!!!

Practice Time: Over to You

Below are two Observations, written by real people. We've included their maps so you can see what they are working on. Again, let's assume that these people are your clients. In your last session, you gave each one the Observation exercise to do as "homework" and then received these responses via email prior to

their upcoming sessions. Read these, keeping in mind the purpose and criteria for quality Observations. Make notes on another page of where you see their entries as "on track" and "off track" (there's a space for this following the Observations for this purpose).

Practice Exercise Observing the Big Assumption #1: Laurel

Laurel's Immunity Map

1. Commitment/ Improvement Goal	2. Doing/NotDoing	3. Hidden Counter- Commitment	4. Big Assumptions
I am committed to learning how to say no to people.	I am over committing myself.	It might appear like I'm not a team player.	I assume that if people don't think I can handle anything that they give me then people wouldn't think I was dependable and I would be passed over for opportunities.
I am committed to balancing what's important with what is urgent.	I am not thinking through the consequences of taking on additional responsibilities.	It might appear that I'm being stubborn, demanding, or insubordinate.	I assume that if people think I am stubborn, selfish, or demanding then I would feel guilty about imposing on others.
(Note: Learning how to say no is part of balancing what's important.)	I am avoiding conflict by accepting new tasks indiscriminately.	If I'm not accepting new responsibilities, I'm afraid I might get passed over for opportunities.	I assume that if I were not ambitious then I wouldn't be able to support myself and would have to depend on others.
	I am taking on additional tasks without prioritizing them.	I am committed to having people think I can handle anything.	
	I am not addressing and/or communicating my priorities in a way that's effective.	I am committed to not having other people think I'm selfish, stubborn, or demanding.	
	I have a plan, but I am not referring to it regularly to track my progress.	I am committed to being an overachiever.	

Laurel's Observations

Observing the Big Assumption in Action: Situation & Costs

Describe situation where Big Assumption got in your way, including what you were thinking & feeling at the time:	Describe costs to you ("What did it block, prevent or impair?")
Situation #1: My supervisor's supervisor asked me to create an important document for an upcoming conference, which was in 2 weeks. I said I'd be happy to and I'd need info from each division before I could start working on it. I also warned that if it needed to be printed in color, we had a tighter deadline. I suggested black and white, given the timeline. I usually don't voice my concerns, but I was driven to it out of sheer frustration here. I finally got the content information I needed, but later than I'd requested it. And even though we were too late to make the printer deadline, my supervisor still wanted the document in color, so I took over everyone's color printers in our division, and spent a day and a half running back and forth between seven desktop printers, hand feeding the documents and changing out printer cartridges and paper, in order to make enough color copies of the document! I was frustrated – not enough time to prepare quality product in the time! And annoyed with my supervisor for assigning me a project with unrealistic expectations. I was especially frustrated that he didn't stand up for me in telling his supervisor what was realistic even after I explained the challenges and associated deadlines. When my supervisor pushed me to complete the projects, I did it. I was afraid that if I didn't live up to his expectations (and his supervisor's expectations), I'd be seen as undependable, and it would reflect negatively on my job performance and I'd be passed over for opportunities in the future.	Situation #1: I suppose the result here was that for two weeks I dropped everything to make this project a priority. I wanted to see what would happen if I tried to place some limits on what was given to me. In a strange way, I feel like successfully completing this project will impair my future work as well, as I've demonstrated that I am capable and willing to take on projects under these circumstances, and I will be asked to do so again in the future.

Laurel's Observations: Observing the Big Assumption in Action:
Situation & Costs continued

Describe situation where Big Assumption got in your way, including what you were thinking & feeling at the time:	Describe costs to you (“What did it block, prevent or impair?”)
Situation #2: My supervisor assigned me a bunch of menial tasks (preparing mailouts, etc.). I don't mind helping, but I feel like once again, the menial tasks fell to me, vs. being spread around the office. I'm frustrated because I'm working beneath my skill level and too often. I also feel like I am being taken advantage of – these projects seem to always fall to me. I was annoyed with myself for not speaking up and turning down an assignment or asking that it be assigned to someone else. I didn't speak up because I didn't want my supervisor to think that I wasn't a team player. I also didn't want my supervisor or my co-workers to think I was stubborn, selfish or demanding. I knew I'd feel guilty if I refused to work on a project and it became someone else's responsibility.	Situation #2: As a result, I devoted time to the projects as assigned instead of spending time on my own projects. The menial tasks prevented me from working on higher priority tasks in my mind. In these first two scenarios in particular, it seems that maybe I am being too nitpicky about defining what's important – if my supervisor gives me a project, I should view it as important as well. I still think there are things I could do to better communicate and act on my priorities, but I think I just need to be more open-minded and flexible overall.
Situation #3: Over the past two years I've tried to be increasingly ambitious—I accepted a new job in a new field in a new city. And I enrolled in an on-line master's degree program, taking two evening classes a semester. I've also been jumping at every opportunity I can – trainings, workshops, detail assignments, etc. I keep taking on new things because I like feeling challenged and accomplished. And I accomplish more when I'm constantly busy. But I'm starting to feel overwhelmed at times, like I've taken on more than I can handle alone. I don't really have any friends here, and have had a hard time adjusting to living in here. My friends and family live far away, so I often feel isolated and alone. And all of my co-workers are leaving soon (3 next month, and 2 soon thereafter, so it'll just be me and another co-worker). I'm worried that I'm going to be increasingly tasked with additional projects at work.	Situation #3: I'm beginning to realize that I might be one of those people who throw themselves into their work to avoid other problems. I haven't been doing a good job at balancing work, school, and my personal life, and a result, I think my social life, and my health, have both been suffering to some extent. I haven't devoted enough time to trying to fit in or find new friends. I've also been increasingly stressed out, preventing me from sleeping well, and eating healthy, finding time to exercise, etc.

Laurel's Observations: Observing the Big Assumption in Action:
Situation & Costs continued

Describe situation where Big Assumption got in your way, including what you were thinking & feeling at the time:	Describe costs to you ("What did it block, prevent or impair?")
Situation #3 continued: I put pressure on myself to continually be ambitious, especially when little things, like signing my lease or paying my medical bills, remind me that I need to be able to support myself. My worst fear would be in having to move home with my parents again or asking my family for financial support.	Situation #3 continued:

Make notes here of where you see potential pitfalls in Laurel's observation entries – for her or for you as the coach.

Here's how we answered that same question (we encourage you to answer this first for yourself!). First, we provide the Laurel's entries again, this time showing you what the coach was thinking about as he or she listened/read.

What the Client Said/Wrote	What the Coach Was Thinking
Situation #1: <i>Briefly describe the situation, including what you were thinking and feeling at the time:</i> My supervisor's supervisor asked me to create an important document for an upcoming conference, which was in two weeks. I said I'd be happy to and I'd need info from each division before I could start working on it. I also warned that if it needed to be printed in color, we had a tighter deadline. I suggested black and white, given the timeline. I usually don't voice my concerns, but I was driven to it out of sheer frustration here. I finally got the content information I needed, but later than I'd requested it. And even though we were too late to make the printer deadline, my supervisor still wanted the document in color, so I took over everyone's color printers in our division, and spent a day and a half running back and forth between seven desktop printers, hand feeding the documents and changing out printer cartridges and paper, in order to make enough color copies of the document! I was frustrated – not enough time to prepare quality product in the time! And annoyed with my supervisor for assigning me a project with unrealistic expectations. I was especially frustrated that he didn't stand up for me in telling his supervisor what was realistic even after I explained the challenges and associated deadlines. When my supervisor pushed me to complete the projects, I did it. I was afraid that if I didn't live up to his expectations (and his supervisor's expectations), I'd be seen as undependable, and it would reflect negatively on my job performance and I'd be passed over for opportunities in the future.	What assumption is she observing? So, is this an observation of how she normally responds when holding her BA as true? Or is she actually changing her behavior? I wonder what was actually said – were her warnings and suggestions as clear as they appear in her description? Was she worried about appearing stubborn, selfish or demanding? Interesting. She doesn't change that behavior. Some possibilities: her supervisor might be pretty boorish; she was not very clear in communicating her reservations; there are other issues (that she is unaware of) that influenced his decision. Ah ha. She says she worries she'd be viewed as "undependable." That makes me think she is focusing on her first BA: "I assume that if people don't think I can handle anything they give me then people wouldn't think I was dependable and I would be passed over for opportunities." It sounds like maybe her attempt to change her behavior didn't actually lead to different results. Was it a test of her second assumption? She tried to place limits but then was pushed further to accept the assignment. Interesting final reflection: she says, "I've demonstrated that I am capable and willing to take on projects under these circumstances, and I will be asked to do so again in the future." Is she realizing that she may not want to be "dependable" in these kinds of ways? And/or that it is because others see her as dependable that she will need to push back harder to not take on these types of assignments?

What the Client Said/Wrote	What the Coach Was Thinking
Situation #1 continued: <i>What happened as a result – what’s blocked, prevented, or impaired?</i> I suppose the result here was that for two weeks I dropped everything to make this project a priority. I wanted to see what would happen if I tried to place some limits on what was given to me. In a strange way, I feel like successfully completing this project will impair my future work as well, as I’ve demonstrated that I am capable and willing to take on projects under these circumstances, and I will be asked to do so again in the future.	
Situation #2: <i>Briefly describe the situation, including what you were thinking and feeling at the time:</i> My supervisor assigned me a bunch of menial tasks (preparing mailouts, etc.). I don’t mind helping, but I feel like once again, the menial tasks fell to me, vs. being spread around the office. I’m frustrated because I’m working beneath my skill level and too often. I also feel like I am being taken advantage of – these projects seem to always fall to me. I was annoyed with myself for not speaking up and turning down an assignment or asking that it be assigned to someone else. I didn’t speak up because I didn’t want my supervisor to think that I wasn’t a team player. I also didn’t want my supervisor or my co-workers to think I was stubborn, selfish or demanding. I knew I’d feel guilty if I refused to work on a project and it became someone else’s responsibility. <i>What happened as a result – what’s blocked, prevented, or impaired?</i> As a result, I devoted time to the projects as assigned instead of spending time on my own projects. The menial tasks prevented me from working on higher priority tasks in my mind.	What BA is she observing? OK, from her language here, it sounds like she is connecting back to her second BA: “I assume that if people think I am stubborn, selfish, or demanding then I would feel guilty about imposing on others.” She focuses a good deal on what others (her supervisor and her colleagues) will think of her. Their opinions seem to determine her sense of whether she is behaving appropriately or not.

What the Client Said/Wrote	What the Coach Was Thinking
Situation #2 continued: In these first two scenarios in particular, it seems that maybe I am being too nitpicky about defining what's important – if my supervisor gives me a project, I should view it as important as well. I still think there are things I could do to better communicate and act on my priorities, but I think I just need to be more open-minded and flexible overall.	Hm, is she second-guessing her first column commitment? Has she lost sight of what initially motivated her to choose that goal (which she evaluated as “extremely important to me”)? I need to talk with her about that.
Situation #3: <i>Briefly describe the situation, including what you were thinking and feeling at the time.</i> Over the past two years I've tried to be increasingly ambitious—I accepted a new job in a new field in a new city. And I enrolled in an on-line master's degree program, taking two evening classes a semester. I've also been jumping at every opportunity I can – trainings, workshops, detail assignments, etc. I keep taking on new things because I like feeling challenged and accomplished. And I accomplish more when I'm constantly busy. But I'm starting to feel overwhelmed at times, like I've taken on more than I can handle alone. I don't really have any friends here, and have had a hard time adjusting to living in here. My friends and family live far away, so I often feel isolated and alone. And all of my co-workers are leaving soon (3 next month, and 2 soon thereafter, so it'll just be me and another co-worker). I'm worried that I'm going to be increasingly tasked with additional projects at work. I put pressure on myself to continually be ambitious, especially when little things, like signing my lease or paying my medical bills, remind me that I need to be able to support myself. My worst fear would be in having to move home with my parents again or asking my family for financial support.	What assumption is she observing? “Ambitious” – sounds like her 3rd BA: “I assume that if I am not ambitious then I wouldn't be able to support myself and would have to depend on others.” Wonder what she means by “ambitious”. In the past, she's talked about it more as getting good performance evaluations that can lead to salary advances. Here, it sounds like she may have some sense that she needs to be challenging herself to achieve as much as possible, to take on as much as she can...? This one seems less like an observation of an event and more like a generalized reflection (about the last two years). She sees a pattern. Is she wondering whether that the “ambitious” choice may not always be the right one? I'm not sure how this last part connects to ambition. Just... “I made the ambitious choice, but it may not make me happy...?”

What the Client Said/Wrote	What the Coach Was Thinking
Situation #3 continued: <i>What happened as a result – what’s blocked, prevented, or impaired?</i> I’m beginning to realize that I might be one of those people who throw themselves into their work to avoid other problems. I haven’t been doing a good job at balancing work, school, and my personal life, and a result, I think my social life, and my health, have both been suffering to some extent. I haven’t devoted enough time to trying to fit in or find new friends. I’ve also been increasingly stressed out, preventing me from sleeping well, and eating healthy, finding time to exercise, etc.	What would be worst about that? How likely is that? Is she prone to feeling like that is much more likely than it really is? OK, here I see it coming together more. Blind ambition at work has actually caused her some problems. There are important costs of being ambitious.

Summary of Potential Pitfalls for Laurel's Observations:

- ✓ If the coach has interpreted her correctly, Laurel is on track in that she indicates which BA. she is observing, and the coach thinks she can see how these are examples of Laurel’s BAs. However, the coach is aware of a potential pitfall – that she may have misinterpreted Laurel’s words and filled in too many blanks. There seem to be two assumptions at play in the first situation. Had Laurel been more explicit about which ones she was observing, the coach would not have to guess/assume/wonder as much.
- ✓ Laurel identifies the costs to her of holding her BAs. However, the coach identifies a potential pitfall – that Laurel may feel less motivated by her first column commitment. The coach needs to address this possibility with Laurel to see if she can maintain (or even increase) her motivation for making change.
- ✓ Laurel relates that she did change her behavior in Situation #2.
- ✓ Situation #3 does not focus on a specific instance but instead describes a pattern Laurel is seeing. It is great that she sees this pattern. Are the costs of these “ambitious” decisions only apparent to her when she looks at the whole pattern? Because she is focusing on the pattern, there are fewer particulars (who, what, where, when). It would be useful to know something of what Laurel was thinking and doing in making each of these decisions to see how her BA actually operates as she weighs alternatives.

Here is space for you to make notes of what you would think to say to this person:

What I might say to this client:

Practice Exercise Observing the Big Assumption #2: Cesar

Cesar's Immunity Map

1. Commitment/ Improvement Goal	2. Doing/NotDoing	3. Hidden Counter- Commitment	4. Big Assumptions
I'm committed to seeing the new center "succeed." I am therefore committed to communicating to Michaela that we need an overall vision.	I don't tell Michaela that I think she should do this. I focus on my worry about her reaction. I tell myself it's not my business; she's the boss.	I fear that I won't tell her correctly – I'll seem too rigid, dogmatic, defensive – have a porcupine reaction. I fear she'll be offended, take it quite hard. I fear her associate isn't able to help her design a vision. I am committed to having people like me. I am committed to seeing myself as a free-thinker, as open-minded, able to work with other people's input and ideas. I am committed to not telling others what to do, not bullying them to get my way.	I assume that if I am not able to see myself as a free-thinker, as open to others' ideas, then I'm not modeling what I believe, I'm arrogant, hypocritical, aggressive. I assume that if I'm not able to see myself as a free-thinker and open to others, then I'll feel guilty, childish, and manipulative.

Cesar's Observations

**Observing the Big Assumption
in Action: Situation & Costs**

Describe situation where Big Assumption got in your way, including what you were thinking & feeling at the time:	Describe costs to you (“What did it block, prevent or impair?”)
Situation #1: I got an email from Steve asking for feedback on a guide we were looking to publish. I felt like there was some information in it that was not accurate, or at least not in agreement with materials we have published (or publically advocated) elsewhere. I responded to Steve’s email, letting him know that I have given quite a few presentations on related subjects, so I am familiar with this process, though I don’t consider myself an expert. Then I told him which particular pieces in his guide were incorrect and where he could find the correct versions. I also told him I was sending my email to several other people who were knowledgeable about these issues, so that they could confirm. Steve replied with another email, apologizing all over himself and asking some more questions. I figure he resented my opinion and wished he had never asked me for it!	Situation #1: I suppose the result here was that for two weeks I dropped everything to make this project a priority. I wanted to see what would happen if I tried to place some limits on what was given to me. In a strange way, I feel like successfully completing this project will impair my future work as well, as I’ve demonstrated that I am capable and willing to take on projects under these circumstances, and I will be asked to do so again in the future.
Situation #2: I had a “conflict” with a fire ecologist on the phone, though I think I handled it well.	Situation #2:
Situation #3: I received a phone call from a woman who was being very critical and pushy. I get these phone calls a lot. I remained polite and didn’t take her comments personally, which was good. I did give her my own viewpoint though, and then she got angrier, even though I didn’t. Sometimes, with these calls, I don’t even let them know if I agree or disagree with what they are saying. But I wasn’t really passionate in this case. When I really argue passionately and with my deepest convictions, that’s what causes other people to see me as emotional, arrogant, vain, a know-it-all.	Situation #3:

Make notes here of where you see potential pitfalls in Cesar's observation entries – for him or for you as the coach.

Here's how we answered that same question (we encourage you to answer this first for yourself!). Once again, we provide the client's entries along side of the coach's thoughts as he or she listened/read.

What the Client Said/Wrote	What the Coach Was Thinking
Situation #1: I got an email from Steve asking for feedback on a guide we were looking to publish. I felt like there was some information in it that was not accurate, or at least not in agreement with materials we have published (or publically advocated) elsewhere. I responded to Steve's email, letting him know that I have given quite a few presentations on related subjects, so I am familiar with this process, though I don't consider myself an expert. Then I told him which particular pieces in his guide were incorrect and where he could find the correct versions. I also told him I was sending my email to several other people who were knowledgeable about these issues, so that they could confirm. Steve replied with another email, apologizing all over himself and asking some more questions. I figure he resented my opinion and wished he had never asked me for it!	What assumption is he observing? What exactly did he say? Is he changing his behavior, or would have done this anyway? Is that a controversial thing to do in this organization? What did Steve do or say? What does it mean to be "apologizing all over himself?" What causes him to feel that Steve resented his opinion and wished he had never asked for it?" Are there alternative, plausible interpretations? Here, he seems to suggest the observation confirmed his BA (although I'm still not clear which BA). Does not identify any costs to the BA. What fundamentally bothers him here – how Steve sees him or how he sees himself? Also, what about costs?
Situation #2: I had a "conflict" with a fire ecologist on the phone, though I think I handled it well.	Situation #2: What assumption is he observing? What happened (e.g., what was said or done)? What does it mean to have "handled it well?" Was he changing his behavior or just observing what he would typically do? Did he experience any costs here?
Situation #3: I received a phone call from a woman who was being very critical and pushy. I get these phone calls a lot. I remained polite and didn't take her comments personally, which was good. I did give her my own viewpoint though, and then she got angrier, even though I didn't. Sometimes, with these calls, I don't even let them know if I agree or disagree with what they are saying. But I wasn't really passionate in this case. When I really argue passionately and with my deepest convictions, that's what causes other people to see me as emotional, arrogant, vain, a know-it-all.	Situation #3: What assumption is he observing? What happened (e.g., what was said or done)? What does it mean to have "remained polite"? So, it sounds like he could be noticing that his BA might be triggered when he feels a great deal of passion. I wonder if he sees as downsides to this.

Summary of Potential Pitfalls for Cesar's Observations:

- ✓ Cesar doesn't explicitly note which Big Assumption he is observing, and it is difficult to see if/how each instance he lists is an example of a Big Assumption.
- ✓ In situation 1, Cesar interprets what Steve does and says in a way that may confirm his Big Assumption. However, it is quite possible that there are alternate and potentially more likely ways of interpreting Steve's email.
- ✓ Cesar may need some skill development around how to express his disagreement effectively and appropriately.
- ✓ Except for situation 3, there is little indication of what Cesar was thinking or how he felt.
- ✓ He hasn't identified costs for any situation.

What would you think to say to this person?

Practice Exercise Observing the Naturally-Occurring Counters to the Big Assumption #1: Maryann

Maryann's Immunity Map

1. Commitment/ Improvement Goal	2. Doing/NotDoing	3. Hidden Counter- Commitment	4. Big Assumptions
I am committed to: Listening to my own wants and needs and expressing who and how I am (my personality) around my mom and others.	I give up what I want to make others happy and have what they want. I don't set boundaries, especially with my daughter and then cave in if I do. I don't communicate to anyone who I am or what I need and want. I get depressed. I avoid social contact.	Fear of being rejected for being selfish; fear of not being good enough; fear of the unknown, of stepping out into the dark; fear of not being in control. I give my decision-making powers away to others. I may also be committed to not finding out how other people really feel about me. I don't want to feel insecure.	If I am not who my family and friends want me to be (to make them happy) then they would abandon me. I have to make sure this does not happen by buying their love and affection by always giving up what I want and always deferring to them and their needs. If I find out how other people feel about me then I am set free. If I am set free then I am afraid that I won't have any excuses left to hide behind and find out that I am really a loser.

Observing Counter Examples of the Big Assumption



Describe situation that casts doubt on your Big Assumption (including your thoughts & feelings)	How does what happened cast doubt on the absolute truth of your Big Assumption?
Counter Observation #1: I met with a client of three years to discuss continuing our monthly retainer contract in 2011. I've been resentful at times this year how they've taken advantage of me (we have a signed agreement that they are to use up their 2 days /mo. in the given month or they lose it, but they typically ask me to let them use the unused portion of the time the following month. Because of our deal, they get a really good monthly retainer rate that saves them \$300/mo.). As a result, I've lost a lot of money. I went into this meeting and I offered them a more flexible retainer contract with a very minor increase in the monthly fee – it still offered them a savings and me a slight increase for the change in structure of the contract. He seemed amenable to carrying on with the more flexible contract and is willing to review the increase in the fee. I feel confident at this point that they will accept the increase in fee since they still save money by signing a one year retainer contract. A win, win – I get a base paycheck each month and they get to pay less for my services than on a per use basis. I just got so sick of getting abused by my client (they played dumb every other month by asking for an exceptions to the contract) that I decided I could no longer offer them the discount they have been getting for the past three years.	Counter Observation #1: Going into this situation, I was not afraid to ask. I knew that they could still say no but I also knew that I was going to be asking for the raise as this was the only way I could really see myself working with them again. I have asked and it seems likely that I will get. Even if we negotiate the increase, it will definitely be an increase for me and I will feel happier working with them as a result. I seem to take a lot of abuse before I've had enough and then I am able to make a quick and clean break. I seem to set up hidden agreements with some people that allow them to abuse me to a certain degree so long as I get what I want out of it – that is, to be liked. The relationship shifts for me when the other party does not keep their end of the silent bargain.
Counter Observation #2 Anne, the CFO of my difficult client, asked me to have lunch regularly with her a long time ago (mostly non-business lunches), and we got to know each other better. At first, I wondered what she wanted from me. I was already working for them, and we had a contract (even if they did often abuse it!) so I was confused why she wanted to spend time with me without really wanting anything from me.	Counter Observation #2: Anne has initiated continued efforts to seek a friendship with me for the past 15 to 18 months. When we go for lunch, we try very hard to not discuss business about 90% of the time.

Observing Counter Examples of the Big Assumption continued

Describe situation that casts doubt on your Big Assumption (including your thoughts & feelings)	How does what happened cast doubt on the absolute truth of your Big Assumption?
Counter Observation #2 continued: She has even literally cried in my presence at her frustrations within the organization. As a client, she has asked that I wait until February/March to see if they can sign up my company for another year long retainer. They are awaiting funding news from a source. As a friend, she has made the effort to ask to see me during the holiday season for lunch. Since I was frustrated at not getting a decision regarding the contract right away, the thought did go through my head that maybe she is having lunch with me to soften the blow and for no other reason.	Counter Observation #2 continued:. She has also shown that she does not do things that would waste her time. She cancelled her attendance at a networking event when I was not able to verify what type of business persons were going to be in attendance but did come another time when I was able to provide a guest list for her. This shows that she does not consider her contact with me on a monthly basis a waste of time. Plus she often instigates these lunches. I still wonder sometimes if she is being nice to me to keep me happy so the company can get those regular favors to overstep our contract. Now that they have not yet signed the 2010 contract, I did wonder if she was going to have lunch with me to soften the blow. But when I think about it, she is a busy executive and she would not make time to see me during her holiday time to just soften the blow. She just wants to be my friend. That feels a little uncomfortable and hurts a little in the heart region but I am going to have to deal with the fact that someone wants to be my friend for no other reason than that they like me. I am getting there but not quite there yet.
Counter Observation #3 I met my Immunity to Change coach, Andy, in March and when I saw him demonstrate this model of coaching, I knew this was the right model for me – It just resonated with me so strongly. I was so intrigued and initiated contact with him to learn more. When I learned that he was accepting new coaching clients, I immediately approached him.	Counter Observation #3: There is a doubt cast upon my Big Assumption in this particular case as Andy did not know me, and he is a very busy coach. In lieu of payment he accepted my advertising skills to help him promote his coaching practice. A win, win for us both. When I really allow myself to be helped, help always arrives. In general, I see I let fear of possible rejection rule me most of the time, so I offer the “candies” – not allowing for most scenarios to play out to show me that things could/would work out anyway. I am beginning to see that I do have a lovely personality that attracts people. I do have more than just candy to offer and I feel somewhat empowered by this knowledge.

Make notes here of where you see potential pitfalls in Maryann's counter observation entries
— for her or for you as the coach.

Here's how we answered that same question (we encourage you to answer this first for yourself!). Once again, we provide the client's entries along side of the coach's thoughts as he or she listened/read.

What the Client Said/Wrote	What the Coach Was Thinking
Counter Situation #1: I met with a client of three years to discuss continuing our monthly retainer contract in 2011. I've been resentful at times this year how they've taken advantage of me (we have a signed agreement that they are to use up their 2 days /mo. in the given month or they lose it, but they typically ask me to let them use the unused portion of the time the following month. Because of our deal, they get a really good monthly retainer rate that saves them \$300/mo.). As a result, I've lost a lot of money. I went into this meeting and I offered them a more flexible retainer contract with a very minor increase in the monthly fee – it still offered them a savings and me a slight increase for the change in structure of the contract. He seemed amenable to carrying on with the more flexible contract and is willing to review the increase in the fee. I feel confident at this point that they will accept the increase in fee since they still save money by signing a one year retainer contract. A win, win – I get a base paycheck each month and they get to pay less for my services than on a per use basis. I just got so sick of getting abused by my client (they played dumb every other month by asking for an exceptions to the contract) that I decided I could no longer offer them the discount they have been getting for the past three years. <i>How does it cast doubt on the absolute truth of the Big Assumption?</i> Going into this situation, I was not afraid to ask. I knew that they could still say no but I also knew that I was going to be asking for the raise as this was the only way I could really see myself working with them again. I have asked and it seems likely that I will get. Even if we negotiate the increase, it will definitely be an increase for me and I will feel happier working with them as a result.	Counter Situation #1: What BA is she observing for naturally occurring counter data? Do the clients know they are taking advantage of her? (Or that this is how Maryann sees it). Was she deliberately trying to change her behavior? Why? Did she explain this to the client? What leads her to think they are “playing dumb”? Is it possible that their intention is not to abuse her? What BA? I am very curious about her use of the term “silent bargain.” I wonder if she has also been assuming that clients: Agree to abide by some unspoken rules of the relationship. Should know when she feels she has allowed herself to be exploited. Should not ask for what they want.

What the Client Said/Wrote	What the Coach Was Thinking
Counter Situation #1 continued: I seem to take a lot of abuse before I have had enough and then I am able to make a quick and clean break. I seem to set up hidden agreements with some people that allow them to abuse me to a certain degree so long as I get what I want out of it – that is, to be liked. The relationship shifts for me when the other party does not keep their end of the silent bargain.	Counter Situation #1 continued:
Counter Situation #2: Anne, the CFO of my difficult client, asked me to have lunch regularly with her a long time ago (mostly non-business lunches), and we got to know each other better. At first, I wondered what she wanted from me. I was already working for them, and we had a contract (even if did often abuse it!) so I was confused why she wanted to spend time with me without really wanting anything from me. She has even literally cried in my presence at her frustrations within the organization. As a client, she has asked that I wait until Feb/Mar to see if they can sign up my company for another year long retainer. They are awaiting funding news from a source. As a friend, she has made the effort to ask to see me during the holiday season for lunch. Since I was frustrated at not getting a decision regarding the contract right away, the thought did go through my head that maybe she is having lunch with me to soften the blow and for no other reason How does it cast doubt on the absolute truth of the Big Assumption? Anne has initiated continued efforts to seek a friendship with me for the past 15 to 18 months. When we go for lunch, we try very hard to not discuss business about 90% of the time. She has also shown that she does not do things that would waste her time. She cancelled her attendance at a networking event when I was not able to verify what type of business persons were going to be in attendance but did come another time when I was able to provide a guest list for her. This shows that she does not consider her contact with me on a monthly basis a waste of time. Plus she often instigates these lunches.	Counter Situation #2: Which BA is she observing for naturally occurring counter data? It sounds like she is not (they are not?) 100% clear about how to regard these dual roles – working relations and friend relations. Have they ever had an explicit conversation about this? Would that run counter to MaryAnn’s BA? OK, so this example seems related to her BA: “If I am not who my family and friends want me to be (to make them happy) then they would abandon me. I have to make sure this does not happen by buying their love and affection by always giving up what I want and always deferring to them and their needs.” Perhaps the connection she is making is that Anne is her friend, and Maryann has not had to buy her love and affection? There are no strings? Perhaps the related assumption here is that people will only like her if there is something Maryann can clearly do or give for them?

What the Client Said/Wrote	What the Coach Was Thinking
Counter Situation #2 continued: I still wonder sometimes if she is being nice to me to keep me happy so the company can get those regular favors to overstep our contract. Now that they have not yet signed the 2011 contract, I did wonder if she was going to have lunch with me to soften the blow. But when I think about it, she is a busy executive and she would not make time to see me during her holiday time to just soften the blow. She just wants to be my friend. That feels a little uncomfortable and hurts a little in the heart region but I am going to have to deal with the fact that someone wants to be my friend for no other reason than that they like me. I am getting there but not quite there yet.	Counter Situation #2 continued: Why does this feel uncomfortable and “hurts a little in the heart region?” Is this related to these BAs?: “If I find out how other people feel about me then I am set free. If I am set free then I am afraid that I won’t have any excuses left to hide behind and find out that I am really a loser.” I still don’t fully understand what Maryann means by those. We need to talk more about those.
Counter Situation #3: I met my Immunity to Change coach, Andy, in March and when I saw him demonstrate this model of coaching, I knew this was the right model for me – It just resonated with me so strongly. I was so intrigued and initiated contact with him to learn more. When I learned that he was accepting new coaching clients, I immediately approached him. <i>How does it cast doubt on the absolute truth of the Big Assumption?</i> There is a doubt cast upon my Big Assumption in this particular case as Andy did not know me, and he is a very busy coach. In lieu of payment he accepted my advertising skills to help him promote his coaching practice. A win, win for us both. When I really allow myself to be helped, help always arrives. In general, I see I let fear of possible rejection rule me most of the time, so I offer the “candies” – not allowing for most scenarios to play out to show me that things could/would work out anyway. I am beginning to see that I do have a lovely personality that attracts people. I do have more than just candy to offer and I feel somewhat empowered by this knowledge.	Counter Situation #3: Which BA is she observing for naturally occurring counter data? OK, here is where I need to be aware of how her immunities may be playing out in our relationship. Hm, this one doesn’t really seem directly connected to any of the BAs listed in her map. It does seem like it could be connected to the previous observation she made, maybe to the idea that people will only like her if there is something Maryann can clearly do or give for them? Here, she seems to be suggesting that what she is giving me is not fair payment for my services? That’s not how I see it. Some possibilities I need to be aware of as her coach. Maryann could be: • Looking to me for confirmation that I like her. • Looking to me for confirmation (or otherwise) that her advertising help is valuable. • Feeling like she has to give me “candies” for me to like her. • Very attuned to any possibility that I will abandon her.

Summary of Pitfalls

- ✓ Maryann's related assumptions (which she seems to be unaware of as assumptions) about how clients should understand her relationship with them contribute to how she interprets their behavior toward her.
- ✓ It is not always clear how the observations are related to Maryann's stated Big Assumptions. The coach must clarify these relationships with Maryann.
- ✓ There are places where the coach will need more particulars (who said/did what) to help Maryann interpret these observations.
- ✓ Maryann may need some skill development around how to express her disagreement effectively and appropriately.
- ✓ The coach needs to be aware of the ways that Maryann's immunities are showing up in their relationship. Clearly, there is the potential for Maryann to feel like the coach's approval, friendship, and willingness to stay in the relationship (as opposed to abandoning her) are important issues.

What would you think to say to this person?

Practice Exercise Observing the Naturally-Occurring Counters to the Big Assumption #2: Emile

Emile's Immunity Map

1. Commitment/ Improvement Goal	2. Doing/NotDoing	3. Hidden Counter- Commitment	4. Big Assumptions
I want to be more an advocate for what I stand for, what I believe in as a way to increase my leadership influence and have a greater impact on others. I want to be better at: • Taking clear positions. • Setting clear expectations. • Challenging others. • Giving concrete feedback based on my view (and the previously set and communicated expectations).	Doing: I hold back clear and strong opinions that are based on my beliefs. I say things in a very soft and diplomatic way. I ask questions and make hints to suggest what I mean. I talk about options rather than my own view. I accept other views as equally relevant and valuable. Not doing: I don't communicate clear expectations based on what I believe. I don't challenge other's views e.g. "I disagree, I see this differently...or may I challenge you". I don't usually give enough clear feedback based on my beliefs. I rarely say "I want you...I expect from you..." I don't usually ask people to behave in specific ways that are preferable to me.	Worries: I'll be rejected. I could "hurt" or confuse someone with my own stand. I'll be questioned about my view/opinion. My view could make someone else feel upset. I could provoke negative emotions. My reputation (I'm a really good guy) could be at risk. I'm committed to... Not being questioned on my deepest beliefs, values. Not being rejected or not valued. Not being exposed. Not taking license (to speak up with my voice) that I haven't been granted. Not being fully accepted, appreciated. Not assessing others (as good or bad...).	I assume that if I'm questioned/rejected, it questions my right to have my own identity, value, nature even if quite different from all others, and it would impact my self-esteem. I assume that if I expose myself too much, I'll feel weak, confused.

Observing Counter-Examples of the Big Assumption



Describe situation that casts doubt on your Big Assumption (including your thoughts & feelings)	How does what happened cast doubt on the absolute truth of your Big Assumption?
Counter Observation #1: I held a meeting last week with a new line manager and 3 other colleagues. One colleague was expressing his opinion to another. He was very quick to state his view, very clear and direct – perhaps too quick and too exaggerated in his response. I was very aware that his way of reacting was very different than my own tendencies, and I also assumed that the woman would likely have a negative reaction to his confrontational style. However, it actually did not create a real problem.	Counter Observation #1: I found myself wondering what to make of this. For him, having a more direct approach may not cause a negative reaction (even though his own behavior was perhaps too exaggerated).
Counter Observation #2: On Friday, I needed to make some unpopular announcements to employees regarding bonuses and compensation issues. One employee (Bertrand) was esp. unhappy with the decisions and told me so in no uncertain terms. I scheduled a meeting to discuss the decisions with him. My goals were to try and listen to understand his perspective, and to be clear with him about my own position regarding the decisions. (In fact, I agreed – for the most part – with the decision that had been made).	Counter Observation #2: In the past, I would've been more likely to focus on Bertrand's perspective and be less clear about stating my own. Now, I feel like it is part of the leader's role – to take responsibility for my opinions and communicate them as clearly as possible. While others might feel uncomfortable or disagree with those decisions and my opinions, it is still important for me to state my own beliefs. Bertrand was not likely to be confrontational with me in the meeting, and I knew that from the start. If he had been that sort of person, it might have been harder for me to have this conversation. In fact, though, he responded rather well to the conversation.
Counter Observation #3:	Counter Observation #3:

Make notes here of where you see potential pitfalls in Emile's counter observation entries – for her or for you as the coach.

Here's how we answered that same question (we encourage you to answer this first for yourself!). Once again, we provide the client's entries along side of the coach's thoughts as he or she listened/read.

What the Client Said/Wrote	What the Coach Was Thinking
Counter Situation #1: I held a meeting last week with a new line manager and three other colleagues. One colleague was expressing his opinion to another. He was very quick to state his view, very clear and direct – perhaps too quick and too exaggerated in his response. I was very aware that his way of reacting was very different than my own tendencies, and I also assumed that the woman would likely have a negative reaction to his confrontational style. However, it actually did not create a real problem. <i>How does it cast doubt on the absolute truth of the BA?</i> I found myself wondering what to make of this. For him, having a more direct approach may not cause a negative reaction (even though his own behavior was perhaps too exaggerated).	Counter Situation #1: What BA is he observing for naturally occurring counter data? What does that mean? How does he know it did not create a problem? Is he aware of the ways that these data are limited? It seems to me that he is referring to an assumption that is not directly stated in column 4, but which seems to underlie his map – that if he is direct in stating his opinion, others will respond negatively
Counter Situation #2: On Friday, I needed to make some unpopular announcements to employees regarding bonuses and compensation issues. One employee (Bertrand) was esp. unhappy with the decisions and told me so in no uncertain terms. I scheduled a meeting to discuss the decisions with him. My goals were to try and listen to understand his perspective, and to be clear with him about my own position regarding the decisions. (In fact, I agreed – for the most part – with the decision that had been made). <i>How does it cast doubt on the absolute truth of the Big Assumption?</i> In the past, I would've been more likely to focus on Bertrand's perspective and be less clear about stating my own. Now, I feel like it is part of the leader's role – to take responsibility for my opinions and communicate them as clearly as possible. While others might feel uncomfortable or disagree with those decisions and my opinions, it is still important for me to state my own beliefs. Bertrand was not likely to be confrontational with me in the meeting, and I knew that from the start. If he had been that sort of person, it might have been harder for me to have this conversation. In fact, though, he responded rather well to the conversation.	Counter Situation #2: Which BA is she observing for naturally occurring counter data? How did Emile feel when Bertrand did this? Did he have a negative reaction? Could this be counter data? Interesting that Emile wants to listen and to advocate. Suggests he may have some skill in communicating? Is Emile standing by the organization's decision and communicating that? Or is he communicating his own opinion as his own? That's not clear to me. To what extent does he feel that the leader is operating on behalf of the organization vs. operating from his own philosophy? Interesting conclusion.

Summary of Pitfalls

- ✓ Emile does not seem to have enough data to draw definitive conclusions in the first example. The coach needs to help him see that it is possible there were no negative effects, but that we don't have all the information to know that absolutely.
- ✓ The coach needs to help Emile make explicit some related assumptions he may be holding which connect to these observations.
- ✓ The coach should recognize the possibility that Emile may not react negatively when others are direct with him. (Of course, maybe he does!) That possibility could also present evidence counter to his Big Assumption.

What would you think to say to this person?

Appendix A

Self-Observations Exercises (Part One & Part Two)

What happens, and fails to happen, as a result of holding your Big Assumption *as true*? The idea in the first part of this exercise is to keep track of situations where you can see (or have recently seen) your Big Assumption at work, e.g., influencing how you look at things, feel about things, take action (or not take action), make choices, spend your energies, etc. These situations may be so abundant that it will make sense for you just to keep track of the several most salient instances. Or, there may only be a few such situations that occur. Feel free to confine your observations to the work sphere or make note of *wherever* you see your Big Assumption influencing you.

Directions: For the next two weeks, do not attempt to change your behavior or your Big Assumption. Do attend to its influence in your life. Specifically: What do you notice does or does not happen as a result of holding your Big Assumption as TRUE? Write two things down: 1) what happened (including inside of you, what you were thinking and feeling), and 2) what costs did you incur?

Your Workspace:

Describe situation where Big Assumption got in your way	Describe costs to you ("What did it block, prevent or impair?")
Situation #1:	Situation #1:
Situation #2:	Situation #2:
Situation #3:	Situation #3:
Situation #4:	Situation #4:

Once you have a few examples of seeing your Big Assumption in action (three or more), you can start to look for patterns and themes. Take a look across all your examples and ask yourself the following kinds of questions:

**Observing the Big Assumption
in Action: Reflections**



Reflection Question	Your Response
What stands out to you? What do you notice most of all?	
What does your BA do to you? What thoughts, feelings, perspectives, actions, and choices do you experience as a consequence of your BA?	
Do you see patterns, i.e., are there particular types of people, content areas, circumstances (inside yourself or in the environment) that activate your Big Assumption?	
Any “ah ha”?	
Do you notice any additional Big Assumptions you are making? If so, add these to your 4-column map.	
What are your key take-aways? Any implications for your Continuum of Progress? If so, add these.	

Self-Observations Exercise: Observing Naturally-Occurring Counters to the Big Assumption

In addition to looking for examples of your Big Assumption in action, we invite you to be on the lookout for experiences that lead you to question the truthfulness or widespread applicability of your Big Assumption. Because of the “certainty” quality of our Big Assumptions (our difficulty in considering how things could be any “other” than this), our Big Assumptions actually inform what we see and how we see the world. They lead us to attend systematically to certain data and to systematically avoid or ignore other data.

Directions: Actively search for data and experiences—in your professional or personal life—that would counter or cast doubt on the absolute quality of your Big Assumption. Take notes about specific situations, interactions, feelings, etc. *Do not intentionally change anything you do or think relative to your Big Assumption, only take account of any spontaneously occurring experiences that might cast doubt on their absolute quality.* Explain how you see the situation and what happened as potential evidence that your Big Assumption is not 100% accurate.

Your Workspace:

Describe situation that casts doubt on your Big Assumption (including your thoughts & feelings)	How does what happened cast doubt on the absolute truth of your Big Assumption?
Counter Observation #1:	Counter Observation #1:
Counter Observation #2:	Counter Observation #2:
Counter Observation #3:	Counter Observation #3:
Counter Observation #4:	Counter Observation #4:

Once you have at least three observations of challenges and counters to your Big Assumption, it's time to step back to see what you can learn from these about your Big Assumption and your mindset, more generally. Take a look across all your examples and ask yourself the following kinds of questions:

**Observing Counter-Examples of
the Big Assumption: Reflections**

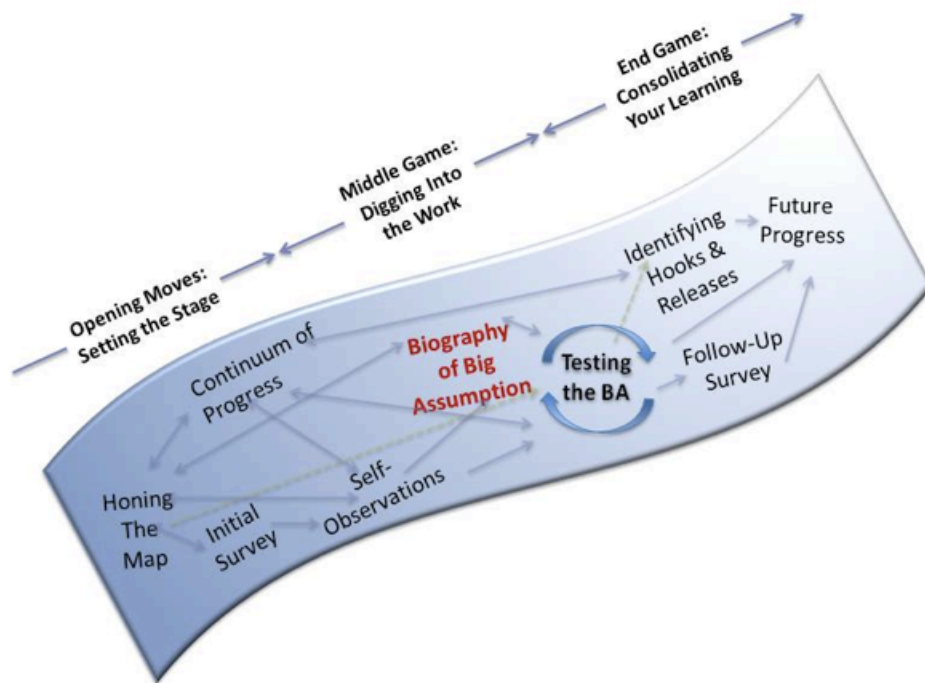
Reflection Question	Your Response
What stands out to you? What do you notice most of all?	
What thoughts, feelings, perspectives, actions, and choices did you experience in these instances?	
Do you see any patterns? Is the same doubt about your Big Assumption raised across the different instances? Is there anything in common across the examples that might account for the counter-data? (e.g., particular types of people, content areas, circumstances, inside yourself or in the environment).	
Did you act differently than your Big Assumption would have you act? If so, what did you do? What are your hunches about why you acted differently? Was it because of something "out there," or something you said to yourself, or some combination of the two, or anything else?	
What does the counter-data suggest to you about your Big Assumption?	
What are your key take-aways? Are there any additions or revisions you'd want to make to your Continuum of Progress based on these observations?	

Chapter 5

The Biography of the Big Assumption

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Context for this Exercise

The Biography of the Big Assumption is part of the Middle Game: Digging into the Work. As in the observation exercises, the invitation for a client to “dig into the work” here comes from asking him to actively work on getting to know his Big Assumption(s) better. It does not ask him to change his behavior to better accomplish his initial improvement goal.

To do one version of this exercise, your client needs to be clear which Big Assumption(s) he wants to pursue in his work with you. This is another reason why we place this exercise in the Middle Game, and following Observations of the Big Assumption exercise. It is also perfectly fine to give your client this exercise after or during the time he is testing his Big Assumption(s). Deciding when to do this exercise often depends on a client’s eagerness to get to changing his behavior. If he has had enough of what he sees as “preparation for action” and wants to “get to work,” it is best to hold off on the Biography. You may well find a better time for it down the road.

Overview

The Biography exercise invites your client to an earlier point in his experience to explore the origins and key moments in the life of his Big Assumptions. This exploration can help your client to recognize that while his assumptions may have been true at an earlier time in his life, in different circumstances the foundation upon which they rest may no longer be appropriate to his current situation.

The idea behind this exercise, then, is that your client may discover a different relationship to his Big Assumption if, now that he is looking back with his current capabilities as an adult, he revisits its earliest and most tender state (before the Big Assumption systematically re-confirmed its truth). This new relationship can be the consequence of novel thoughts (e.g., he knows that he's no longer the same person he was when he took on that assumption, so he considers that he might not need it any longer, or as it is) and/or feelings (e.g., he feels tenderly towards his earlier self, appreciates that he was doing his best to take care of himself).

Clients engage this exercise with a range of enthusiasm and intensity. Depending on the nature of the client's immunities and inclinations, the Biography exercise can take different forms and cover different ground. There are several variations on the "Biography" exercise for you (and your client) to choose from so that he can get the most out of mining the history of his Big Assumption. Your job as a coach is to help your client make the best decision possible about whether and how it makes best sense to regard this exercise. Ideally, this exercise gives the client another tool for developing more space between himself and his Big Assumptions, so that he can examine them and consider testing them.

Purpose and Benefits

- ✓ To develop understanding of the initial reasons for and purpose of the Big Assumptions in his life.
- ✓ To consider whether and how those reasons and that purpose are still relevant (or not) to the realities of the present day and his present self.
- ✓ To increase motivation to test his Big Assumption(s).
- ✓ To increase ownership over the work and progress.

Three General Points about the Origins of the Big Assumptions

1. Big Assumptions have been living with us for a while (sometimes, for a very long while), and have become part of our skin without our realizing it. They may have been born out of a single, significant event or over a series of experiences. They are the consequence of conclusions we unconsciously drew at the time about how to operate as safely as possible in the world then.

2. While Big Assumptions usually get their start in families of origin, when we were children with little power, and the world in which we were seeking to thrive was a world largely defined by our families, we can also form them in adolescence and adulthood. It may well be that there are precursors in our earliest years to those Big Assumptions we form later in life, but that the powerful hold they have over us did not get activated until our later years. The most important point is that we are able to look back with our current self to see that we drew a conclusion which we have been re-truing ever since.

3. A limiting Big Assumption embedded in most people's Big Assumptions is this: "I am still the person I was when I drew this conclusion." As adults, we have considerably greater power and authority than we did as children and adolescents. That is a precious resource for our continued growth. For some adults, it is also the case that the world in which they live is considerably less shaped and defined by their parents and families of origin.

Brief Examples of a Biography of a Big Assumption

Before we detail the different versions of the bio-examples, here's a quick example of what the exercise is intended to generate:

Marcos' Column 1 improvement goal was to relax, celebrate life, and stop constantly striving for more, for perfection. After completing Columns 2 & 3, he identified several assumptions. The one he chose to focus on that he thought would make the biggest dif-

ference to opening up his immune system was this: "I assume I must always be strong and in control or people will think I am vulnerable and weak."

Here's his response to the biography of his Big Assumption: *"I had a very painful and unanticipated end of a romantic relationship in my early 20s that reverberated through many aspects of my life and left me feeling exploited, betrayed, and shattered. My coping strategy*

was to bury my feelings. Looking back, I see that those feelings didn't go away, but that I converted them into anger, which I've been carrying for years. I definitely see that the way I've been trying to act strong and in control is a way to protect myself, as if I can somehow pretend that the way I act will change the way I feel."

Marcos found this exercise quite liberating. Not only did he understand how he had created this Big Assumption, he also began to have bigger doubts about its usefulness in his life. He could see that acting strong and in control had been a strategy he adopted to cover – and try to change – his true feelings. The fact that his underlying feelings had not changed, no matter how he acted, was evidence to him that his Big Assumption was quite flawed. Notice, too, that he didn't need to write a detailed history to make the connection between the demise of that relationship and his Big Assumption.

Help your client understand the context for the assignment. Again, your job is to help your client to understand how this exercise is connected to those he has already completed and to the core ideas of the immunity-to-change concept (especially the connection between making progress on his column one goal and making changes to the Big Assumptions he currently holds). You can also highlight for your client the importance of this step in the process of overturning one's immunities.

Engaging your Client in this Exercise

What are the connections that you see between the Biography exercise and those that have come previously?

Which exercises do you see the Biography of the Big Assumption as most connected to and why?

Here are the connections we see:

This exercise is directly connected to the ITC Map, particularly to the Big Assumptions that your client has identified. If your client has discovered new Big Assumptions since honing his map, they should be reflected in an updated map. The bio exercise should also connect to your client's Observations, since he was hopefully observing instances of his focused Big Assumption in action. If he did this, he may well have a richer set of prompts to take to doing the bio of that assumption (e.g., if his Observations lead him to see that his Big Assumption gets activated when he is being asked to explain something a second time, he can then ask himself if/when he was asked to do this in his past, or if he has clear memories of others having to explain themselves).

Before we describe the process of inviting your client to write the Biography of his Big Assumption(s), we want to invite you to consider the potential challenges and pitfalls to avoid. In what ways might your client be drawn to or feel resistant to this exercise? What might you actually say to your client to help him make a good choice about how/whether to complete this exercise?

Here are our responses to that same question: For many clients, looking back over their lives for specific information about and instances of their Big Assumption provides them with new insights. They may understand some of the events or circumstances of their early years in new ways, uncovering how they internalized messages about who they were, what they could and couldn't do, what was discussable and what wasn't, and what they could expect from those around them as well as what they could not. They may also learn something new about their Big Assumption, specifically, how it came into being. Some clients find this learning to be cathartic. Having seen in their maps, their CoPs, and their observations, how their Big Assumptions have gotten in their ways and held them back from their goals, they may come to feel only frustration and annoyance for their Big Assumptions. Exploring the biography can help them be a little more forgiving. Nearly always, there are very good reasons why we have developed and held onto our Big Assumptions. They may have protected us from the dangers of a toxic environment. They may have actually brought us a certain amount of success.

However, when they see the Biography exercise, some clients will feel a strong aversion to this type of exploration. This can occur especially when clients are given Version 1, the Deductive Approach, to explore the biography. They can feel the exercise is too personal and too closely related to therapy rather than coaching. Or, they may dread the emotions and difficult memories they expect to uncover in the exercise. Where their aversions are particularly strong, clients may elect to skip this exercise altogether. Or you may suspect that your client is likely to have such a reaction and this would be a good reason to consider Version 2 or 3 (see below for descriptions of all versions). Your job as a coach is to help your client make the best decision possible about whether and how it makes best sense to regard this exercise.

Give your client the exercise, “Writing the Biography of the Big Assumption.”

If your client has not completed (or necessarily even started) his assignment. If you invite your client to the Deductive Approach (Version 1), it is not impossible that she will be unable to complete this assignment because she could think of *nothing*. Uncovering the Big Assumption's biography can be very illuminating for some people, and not at all for others. While our best guess is that there surely is a history to his Big Assumption (it came from somewhere), overturning one's immunity *does not depend* on knowing or understanding it. Sometimes a client's reticence is because he has interpreted the assignment to mean more than it asks of him. It is worth taking some time to see whether he might be able to conjure up even one image or a brief story, scene or episode that brings his biography to life. Alternatively, consider introducing the Inductive Approach used in Version 2. If he cannot and you need to bring this step to a close, make sure you communicate that his progress does not depend on being able to do this assignment (while also communicating that this doesn't let him off the hook for coming prepared to any other session!)

Your client may have a different reason why he is not prepared for this session. While his explanations need to be respected at face value, is it worth being alert to the possibility that self-protection is also at play. Various forms of self-protection may come up at different times throughout these sessions. It can be valuable to name this and make it a discussable topic in your work.

Three Approaches to Writing the Biography of the Big Assumption

In this chapter, we illustrate several different ways that clients have completed and benefitted from the biography exercise. The range of approaches illustrates how much or how little clients may choose to share, what they focus on (as well as what they leave out), and how they tell their stories. *What is most important, regardless of whatever style or approach the client takes, is that there is a clear connection between the biography and the Big Assumptions.*

The order in which we present the different versions of the bio exercise below reflects how frequently clients use each. The first two are used equally.

Version 1: Childhood Origins: *The Deductive Approach*

This first version is the one we developed around 2005, when we were designing exercises to help our own clients to develop greater objectivity towards their Big Assumptions. It is simple and straight-forward, and people can write as little or as much as they want about key events from their childhood and adolescence that led to forming and reinforcing their Big Assumptions. This version has two parts. Part 1 includes questions to the client to help prompt his exploration of the history of his Big Assumption, and Part 2 asks a set of reflective questions. Expect that it will take between 30 – 45 minutes for a client to do both parts of the exercise.

Some clients who feel they have fully explored their earliest childhood memories and feel quite clear about the role of these events in the formation of their Big Assumption may elect to focus their ITC exploration on the more recent events in their lives, especially when those events have not been explored as fully.

Directions: Explore the history of your Big Assumption: When was it born? Are there specific situations, feelings, important events or “moments” you can recall? How long has it been around? What were some of its critical turning points? Perhaps there is one “story,” event, “snapshot” or episode that captures something from your past that may have gotten your Big Assumption started or served to emphasize its importance? *Again, do not intentionally change anything you do or think relative to your Big Assumption.*

Kate Example

Kate's Big Assumption:

*"I assume that if people discover that I am not as good as I seem to be,
they will not love me."*

This is a very old assumption. I think it was born when I was a small child. My grandparents, who were very present in my life, were very religious—in a very traditional, Old Testament kind of way. Original sin and all that. So, I grew up believing that there was something fundamentally wrong with me that I had to try and deny. I tried to be as good as possible—to please others, be quiet and well-behaved, especially in public. But I always felt like that was an act, not really who I was, and that nobody could see the real me.

When I was seven, my sister was born. In retrospect, I think she might have been a surprise, and my parents were not planning to have another child. Also, Ellen was kind of a difficult baby – sick maybe or just really fussy. I remember it being an awful time at home – my mom was screaming all the time, my dad withdrawing. At first I was confused about how to feel toward Ellen, but as she grew into a toddler, I remember that I began to love her deeply and admire her stubbornness and independence. She's always been like that – always done whatever the hell she wanted.

But my parents didn't seem to love her. At least that's how it seemed to me at the time. They were always yelling at her, always in a bad mood or mad at each other (or me) about something she had done. To me, the message was clear – to be like Ellen was to risk losing my parents' love. And I didn't have the confidence in myself, the self-love maybe, to risk losing theirs. Ellen didn't seem to care what they thought of her, although I know now that of course she did.

I was never popular at school, never excelled really in anything that would attract much positive attention. And I think I liked flying under the radar, doing what I was supposed to do – because standing out in any way would possibly annoy someone, cause someone to dislike me.

When I was 16, I was really focused on going to the prom. I wanted to go so bad and was worried that no one would ask me. Or that the "wrong" boy would ask me. I did get asked by a pretty normal guy – a fairly quiet but not too nerdy boy who was in some of the same classes that I was. I remember, though, that my friends began to tease me about dating him. They made him out to be a real player, someone who would expect certain things from me or would reject me (publically and in a humiliating way). I got obsessed with worry about what to do – certain that I would not please him or them, that I would risk public humiliation. The week of the prom, I pretended I was sick and broke off the date. I felt terrible – probably made myself sick. But I was too concerned about what everyone wanted of me. I think part of it was that I felt I had no idea what people really did want – so that made it

likely that I would screw up, not know what to do to please them. Very bizarre, as I think of it now.

College really was a big step for me – a move away from home and a chance to experiment a bit with my identity. Actually, though, I suppose I was just learning to fit into a different type of setting and was absorbing new messages about what was “good” and how to keep people from rejecting me. Still, I did form some close friendships there, and I still keep in touch with those girls. Because we spent so much time together, they knew me pretty well – knew who I was and still liked me. I guess we were all pretty much the same, in a way. I felt more comfortable with myself, although I never had to risk doing anything that threatened their liking me. I just “belonged.”

As a physical therapist, I get to focus a lot on helping people, on being with them when they are struggling or in pain. I’m good at that. I can be calm and patient – I don’t know what they were like before their injury or illness, so I can just meet them and take them as they are. I think that’s freeing for them. But I also see how doing this type of work keeps me safe – I have my nice job, and my nice apartment, and my nice friends. And lately, I guess I feel like I want more than that. Now that I’m back in school, and doing really well, I see that there might be more out there for me, that I want to succeed, want to shine. And I have lots of fears about that – fears that that I will rock the boat, will make others (friends, co-workers) annoyed, that people won’t want me to succeed, or that in succeeding I’ll be standing out more, inviting criticism. They are the same fears I had as a child. I’m just tired of having them now.

Reflection Question	Your Response
In what ways do the lessons learned connect to your Big Assumption?	I feel like my grandparents, parents, and friends in some ways all “sent” me the message that I was not good enough as I was, that I needed to act as other than who I was to be acceptable/loveable to them.
Does your biography (or biographic moment) illuminate any additional Big Assumptions you might be making? Do you notice any definitive, i.e., this - always-happens, quality?	I assume that to stand out, take risks, call for attention is to risk (or to invite?) disapproval.
To what extent do you believe and feel the situation or events from your biography (or biographic moment) apply to your current life? If you think they do, how so?	Yes, they do. It is still so hard for me to believe that just being myself is enough for others. I also still have a hard time “celebrating” something about myself that I see as good, that I want others to see as good.

Version 2: Childhood Origins: *The Inductive Approach*¹

In general, the biography exercise is a more right-brained, associative approach to studying the Big Assumption compared to the other exercises (such as observation and testing). It invites people to use their intuitions, to tap into images, and to free associate.

This second version of the biography exercise is even more right-brained than our original version (where clients *start with their Big Assumption* in mind and deductively work backwards to search for events that could explain how and when it was born). In this version, we do not ask clients to begin with any of their Big Assumptions in mind. The connections they will make to their Big Assumptions come *at the end* of the exercise, not at the beginning. We even ask them to suspend, for the moment, *why* we are even asking them to partake in the exercise. The exercise asks them to cast back in their memories of childhood, to retrieve a handful of experiences that had a negative charge. They then look for connections to their Big Assumption(s). This inductive approach, where clients start with the specific memories and then move to the broader question of if and how any of those connect to their Big Assumption, often stimulates clients to generate more and richer material than our original version (where some people are unable to complete the exercise because they can think of *nothing*).

On the next page are the directions for this second version, followed by an example of a completed exercise. Expect that it will take between 30 – 45 minutes for a client to do the entire exercise.

1. We have adapted this approach from Learning as Leadership (<http://www.learnaslead.com/>) and use it with their permission.

Starting prompt: Thinking back over the first 15 or 16 years of life, identify a handful (5-6) memories that continue to stick with you and that were in some way negative (disturbing, puzzling, made you angry, upsetting, scary) in quality. They don't have to be events that were momentous – include events that may now seem tiny, mundane, common for many young people to experience in their lives. If these events were called up for you in your reflection, include them in your list. Record these events in column one below.

Events (the headlines)	What I was thinking (at that time)	What I was feeling (at that time)	Lessons learned/conclusions drawn (at that time)

Directions continued: Once you have listed the headlines of these events in column one, complete columns 2-4. Column 4 is asking what you think you (that child who was 4 or 7 or 13) concluded at that time about yourself and the world. What were the lessons you learned then from those experiences?

When the table is complete, look at the lessons learned to see if there are any connections you can make between them and your Big Assumptions from your immunity map.

Kaleb Example

Kaleb completed the chart as instructed, starting first with writing headlines of his memorable childhood events.

Events (the headlines)	What I was thinking (at that time)	What I was feeling (at that time)	Lessons learned/ conclusions drawn (at that time)
1. (Age 7 on) From the beginning I was always a good student. And my parents always pushed me to do more – be involved in more clubs, earn high grades, etc.	I want to please my parents. I want them to continue to think highly of me.	Fear of disappointing my parents and pleasure when I made them happy.	How I do in school is a reflection of my abilities and my future potential.
2. (Throughout childhood) My sisters and brother were very competitive with me. Often we didn't have enough for everyone to do all they wanted to do (eat what they wanted, get the music lessons they wanted, buy the clothes or toys they wanted). I often seemed to get more than they did, and they didn't like this.	I should get more because I do the right things.	I am afraid that I don't really deserve more than they do. I am afraid that my parents will change their minds and stop giving me things. Stop loving me?	I must work even harder to show that I deserve what I get and so that I will continue to get rewards and love.
3. (Age 12) I quit taking piano lessons because I overheard my teacher telling my mother that I wasn't very talented.	I don't want to do anything that I can't be good at.	I was afraid that my mom would see me differently – as someone who may not be as talented as she had thought. I suppose I was also afraid that was true.	I must hide any parts of myself that are not fully successful, talented, superstar material.
4. (Age 13?) My brother started swimming competitively. It was immediately clear that he was a very good swimmer, and he won many competitions.	My status in the family is in jeopardy. I can't compete with him, athletically.	Fear of losing.	I must be an even bigger success than he is if I want to keep the love, attention, and other rewards.

Kaleb Example continued

Events (the headlines)	What I was thinking (at that time)	What I was feeling (at that time)	Lessons learned/ conclusions drawn (at that time)
5. (Age 16) I started working to earn money for college and extra money to spend. I had a little bit more independence to make my own decisions because now I could pay for what I wanted. I never used any of this money to buy something for someone else (e.g., my parents or siblings).	I deserve this money because I earned it.	Insecure, I guess, that the money wasn't enough.	If I freely give what I have, I will run out. There will be not enough for me. Others should get their own.

To complete the last part of this exercise, Kaleb reminded himself of the key Big Assumptions he had been exploring in the last exercises.

Kaleb's Big Assumptions:

"I assume that if people think I couldn't handle something then people wouldn't think I was dependable and I would be passed over for opportunities."

"I assume that the path to success is by looking out for myself."

"I assume that I am successful if I can support myself and not depend on others."

Reflection Question	Your Response
In what ways do the lessons learned connect to your Big Assumption?	The connections are really clear. I grew up feeling like my value as a person came from what I could accomplish. If I don't/can't produce, I'm unworthy and unloveable
Does your biography (or biographic moment) illuminate any additional Big Assumptions you might be making? Do you notice any definitive, i.e., this - always-happens, quality?	Yes, I think the idea that my "abilities" might be a hoax, transitory, or even only evident when compared with those who are less able. Also, I think the way that limited financial resources fueled the whole thing and spilled over into limited emotional resources.
To what extent do you believe and feel the situation or events from your biography (or biographic moment) apply to your current life? If you think they do, how so?	Very applicable now to my sense that I am constantly running a race that continues to get harder. Also my distrust of ongoing support from others (even my wife) who might lose interest in me if I fail to perform.

Version 3: Abbreviations of the Original Biography Exercise

Clients who are uncomfortable with the more personal or therapy-like aspects of the Biography exercise can always choose not to do this exercise. You, and your client, should both know that his overall progress in this work *does not depend* on being able to do this assignment. You should also keep in mind that a more suitable opportunity to do the exercise may arise at a later point in the coaching journey. However, it is easy to modify the original biography exercise by circumscribing the arena for reflection so it doesn't pull for anything deeply personal. You can offer these to your client as alternatives and discuss with him where his comfort zone is.

“Just the Work History” Biography

While reflecting solely on their work history can limit what the client is able to learn, there are often incidents just in the work domains of clients' lives that can shed light on how their big assumptions were formed and/or fueled.

Gerard Example

The Big Assumptions Gerard is exploring in the example below are: *“I assume that if I assert my own view, I may be questioned/rejected (which challenges my right to have my own identity, value, nature). It would impact my self-esteem,”* and *“I assume that if I expose my true feelings and thoughts, I may realize that they are wrong, and I'd feel weak, confused.”*

Years ago I was a resident teacher in a private school. At that time I was doing some volunteer work with a homeless shelter and had tried to convince people at the school that they should become involved. I think I was too enthusiastic in my efforts, and this created some trouble in the school. Students who looked up to me as a kind of leader may have felt pressure to be involved. The Head of School believed that I was a bad influence I think, putting the students in danger, not doing the right thing. He confronted me in front of the students, tried to convince them that I was a bad guy.

This was a huge blow to my self-esteem, and I took it very personally. I felt that I had not been aware enough of what the Head would think and was not aware enough of what the students were potentially feeling. I think that is why I feel like I must always try to be so empathetic, to try always to stay tuned to what others might be feeling. I am more likely to question and withhold my own opinion. As a result, it has been hard to learn how to balance expressing my own view with the importance of being aware of and making space for others.

Reflection Question	Your Response
In what ways does the biography (or biographic moment) explain your Big Assumption?	This incident made me doubt my own judgment about how and when (and why) I assert my own view. It also showed me how dangerous it can be to have bad judgment in this way.
Does your biography (or biographic moment) illuminate any additional Big Assumptions you might be making? Do you notice any definitive, i.e., this - always-happens, quality?	I guess it just made me think that there might always be the possibility that my views, if asserted, can be oppressing to others.
To what extent do you believe and feel the situation or events from your biography (or biographic moment) apply to your current life? If you think they do, how so?	I much prefer to ask questions, allow others to assert their own views, to learn more from others than what I state myself.

“Just the Headlines” Biography

Here clients focus on only the most general headlines of the incidents that shaped their Big Assumptions. Rather than providing specific details or stories, and leaving out attention to their emotions or psychological states, these Biographies focus much more generally on what the client learned or took away from his experiences.

Nicki Example

Nicki is exploring a cluster of Big Assumptions in the example below are: *“I assume that in interpersonal relationships at work, there are winners and losers and that I might be on the losing side.” “I assume that I am not really part of the group. I assume that I am inconsequential to the group’s performance. If I don’t stay invisible and at a safe distance, then I might be in the losing position.”*

I come from a large family. I was the youngest living in a world that was "comfortable" (more or less) and me being more or less irrelevant (concerning the organizational issues of family life). Because things just tended to go well, I did not need to insist, intervene, or take an active role in making sure that things in the family ran smoothly. It didn’t matter if I didn’t do something, it would get done anyway. This experience may have helped shape an assumption that things will just run smoothly without my explicit effort or organization of

them. That may be an assumption I bring to my current work role. Perhaps my assumption (about each interaction being one of win/lose, in which I lose) could also be related to the fact that I was the youngest in my family – the one with the least experience, the smallest physically, the least developed mentally. There was some competitiveness among my family members. I may have assumed that if there was going to be a “loser” in situations with my other family members, I would be the one.

Reflection Question	Your Response
In what ways does the biography (or biographic moment) explain your Big Assumption?	As the youngest, I may have often been rather inconsequential and also maybe the predictable “loser” in some situations.
Does your biography (or biographic moment) illuminate any additional Big Assumptions you might be making? Do you notice any definitive, i.e., this- always-happens, quality?	Not that I can see now.
To what extent do you believe and feel the situation or events from your biography (or biographic moment) apply to your current life? If you think they do, how so?	I see everything at work as a competition, in which some will win and some will lose. I assume that I am likely to lose.

Tips and Pitfalls

Coach's Tips for Writing the Biography of the Big Assumption

- Overall Tips
1. Keep the purpose and intended results in mind throughout the process of presenting this exercise to your client and debriefing it. The purpose of the Biography is for your client to develop understanding of the initial reasons for and purpose of the Big Assumptions in his life and to consider whether and how those reasons and purposes are still relevant (or not).
 2. Try to anticipate how your client may react to the idea of exploring the Biography of the BA. If you think he might be resistant, consider how you can help him make the best decision possible about whether, how, and when it makes best sense to regard this exercise. You may need to illustrate for him the range of different ways that clients have completed and benefitted from the biography exercise.
 3. Remember the coach's "Two Hats": listening as an appreciative receiver and as a probing inquirer.
 4. Be alert to the ways that your meetings with your client provide you with information relevant to your coaching. The ways in which his immunities do and don't show up with you are an important source of data as well.

Potential Pitfalls



Coach	Client
Loses sight of the purpose of exploring the Biography of the Big Assumption). Gets pulled into the interesting or perhaps sensational details of a client's childhood experiences.	Experiences the Biography as exciting and even powerful, but not because he is gaining insight into his Big Assumptions and his immune system.
Pushes client to explore and reveal painful, personal memories in order to come to "deeper" level of self-understanding or insight.	Feels manipulated, overwhelmed, judged, and/or resistant.
Gets overly focused on connecting sensitive experiences to the client's Big Assumptions, not carefully listening to (and so getting disconnected from) client's own meaning, understanding, and/or experience.	Feels misunderstood or unsupported emotionally.

In-depth Examples of Biography: Jackson & Amanda

Let's return to Jackson, and then Amanda, to illustrate the value a coach adds to what a client can learn from the biography exercise. Often, clients find the biography exercise fairly straightforward, and coaches can focus on understanding the client's experiences, as she describes them. In such cases, the coach may not suggest that the biography be changed much. Changes and additions that Jackson and Amanda made after speaking with their coaches appear **in red**.

Jackson's Biography

Jackson's improvement goal is to publicize his accomplishments with senior management. In considering which version of the exercise to offer Jackson, his coach was confident that Jackson would be game for looking into his childhood. Given that, plus his experiences with other coachees' success with the more open-ended approach (V. 2, Inductive version), he decided to try that version with Jackson during their next session. The coach figured that if Jackson didn't get anywhere significant with this version, that he could offer him the original version to do as homework.

Jackson jumped right into describing events from his childhood, and took it from there.

Events (the headlines)	What I was thinking (at that time)	What I was feeling (at that time)	Lessons learned/ conclusions drawn (at that time)
1. (Age 6-16) Kurt and I are close in age and are often compared to each other within the family and by others. Kurt is very smart, charismatic, athletic. He likes showing people what he has done/can do. I constantly hear from people about how talented Kurt is.	I am not talented. I should be more like Kurt. I am a disappointment. People expect more from me.	Fear of disappointing my parents and pleasure when I made them happy.	How I do in school is a reflection of my abilities and my future potential.
2. (Age 14) Our family moves out of state. Kurt is quick to make new friends in school, to join new clubs, sports teams. It takes me a long time to make new friends. I wish Kurt would include me more in what he does but I never ask.	I understand this means that I am unlikeable to many people. I don't want Kurt to see how unlikeable I am.	I am afraid that I don't really deserve more than they do. I am afraid that my parents will change their minds and stop giving me things. Stop loving me?	I must work even harder to show that I deserve what I get and so that I will continue to get rewards and love.
3. (Age 15) My best friend Jim and I get caught cheating on a test. Jim is expelled from the "honors" classes and enrolled in "regular" courses. I remain in the honors classes because I don't have a reputation for being a troublemaker like Jim has.	I know I was just as responsible for the cheating as Jim was, but I am afraid to tell anyone that.	I feel like I have character flaws that I cannot control. I don't like myself. I also don't like Kurt because I don't think he deserves to have everything come so easily.	I must hide any parts of myself that are not fully successful, talented, superstar material.

Having completed this, Jackson thought about whether any of these conclusions related to his Big Assumptions (“I assume that saying anything about my accomplishments is bragging. I assume that if I am bragging, I am just like Kurt (also selfish, arrogant, etc.), and “I assume that if I publicize my successes, I’ll believe what I say.”)

Reflection Question	Your Response
In what ways do the lessons learned connect to your Big Assumption?	I had forgotten about the Jim/cheating incident until I started filling this out... seems powerfully related to me now. I can also see how I developed a whole personality around being the guy who doesn’t stand out and sort of trying to claim that as cool. Looking back in this way, I see how much I didn’t think it was cool at all.
Does your biography (or biographic moment) illuminate any additional Big Assumptions you might be making? Do you notice any definitive, i.e., this- always-happens, quality?	Well, it makes me wonder if I am also constantly contrasting myself with people who are better at self-promotion – kind of assuming we are opposite types (not just in terms of whether we tend to sell ourselves or not).
To what extent do you believe and feel the situation or events from your biography (or biographic moment) apply to your current life? If you think they do, how so?	I can see that I am still comparing and contrasting myself with Kurt and that the self-sellers at work are just different versions of Kurt. But I don’t see myself as so flawed, immoral or unlikeable anymore. In fact, I kind of think the fact that I don’t see myself that way should make me more likeable. Hmm, somehow it has gotten turned around.

Amanda’s Biography

Recall that Amanda’s general improvement goal is to improve her health (she wants to lose weight and thereby lower her blood pressure and improve her cholesterol). Amanda chose to do the original version of the biography exercise, and the Big Assumption she explored in this exercise is: *“I assume that if I don’t have lots of options, I will feel resentful, angry, impotent, and stressed. Life will be bleak.”* Her initial responses to the exercise, and then her updated responses based on her conversation with her coach are below.

Biography

- Growing up, my family always made food important. We ate big meals together, and if you ate everything on your plate, you got dessert. My mom always made really yummy desserts, so everyone wanted to make sure to get one.

- I remember my family always saying proudly that I was a good eater – not picky like my brother. I liked to please my parents, so I liked that they saw me as good at something.
- I started gaining weight in college. I didn't like the food in the cafeteria, but I think I ate more of it than I did at home! I liked to eat with my friends and take a break from studying by ordering pizza or making popcorn. I also started going to parties and happy hours and started liking to drink beer. I also started going on diets for the first time. I would starve myself on the weekdays so I could eat whatever I wanted and party on the weekends. I hated the end of the weekend, and every Sunday night I would stuff myself because I knew that the next day I could only eat toast or something. I would say it's my farewell to food.
- I gained weight after college too, but not too much. It wasn't until I started having kids that the weight really came on. I felt like being pregnant meant I could eat anything, and then the weight would just come off after that. But it didn't, and having little babies made it really hard to diet. My mom told me the same thing happened to her. At first I just kind of thought oh well, I'm married, who cares if I get fat? But then my doctor started getting on me to lose, and some of my girlfriends have stayed thin, and my husband makes some comments sometimes about how I don't want to do anything but sit on the couch. So I keep trying, but it's really hard to do now! I remember how easy it was when I was younger!

Reflection Question	Your Response
In what ways does the biography (or biographic moment) explain your Big Assumption?	It tells me how it came to be in my life and shaped me.
Does your biography (or biographic moment) illuminate any additional Big Assumptions you might be making? Do you notice any definitive, i.e., this- always- happens, quality?	??
To what extent do you believe and feel the situation or events from your biography (or biographic moment) apply to your current life? If you think they do, how so?	I still feel like eating and drinking are part of the best things in life.

Before you read Amanda's revisions to her responses, take a moment to assess the quality of her work. If you choose to have your client do the exercises and send them in advance of your coaching session, this is just the situation you will be in: with your "ITC" hat on, you'll be prepared for your upcoming session by asking what you see as the strengths of the solo work your client sends you. What are the opportunities for greater depth? What needs clarification?

In Amanda's case, her coach felt as though Amanda had identified some key incidents but hadn't yet been very explicit about what she had learned from these incidents or how they connected directly to her Big Assumptions. The goal in discussing this exercise with Amanda was to help make these connections more explicit.

Version 2

- *"I assume that if I don't have lots of options, I will feel resentful, angry, impotent, and stressed. Life will be bleak."*
- *"I assume that if I don't reward myself with food or drink, then I will be less motivated at work and in my personal life."*

Biography

- Growing up, my family always made food important. We ate big meals together, and if you ate everything on your plate, you got dessert. My mom always made really yummy desserts, so everyone wanted to make sure to get one. *I saw dessert as a reward, and thought of eating to feel good about myself and to enjoy being with others.*
- I remember my family always saying proudly that I was a good eater – not picky like my brother. I liked to please my parents, so I liked that they saw me as good at something. *The more people praised me for eating, the more I liked eating. Eating became a way to feel good about myself.*
- I started gaining weight in college. I didn't like the food in the cafeteria, but I think I ate more of it than I did at home! I liked to eat with my friends and take a break from studying by ordering pizza or making popcorn. I also started going to parties and happy hours and started liking to drink beer. I also started going on diets for the first time. I would starve myself on the weekdays so I could eat whatever I wanted and party on the weekends. I hated the end of the weekend, and every Sunday night I would stuff myself because I knew that the next day I could only eat toast or something. I would say it was my "farewell to food." *I saw two choices: eat lots and lots and have fun or eat almost nothing and feel deprived. Nothing in*

between. The less I ate during the week, the more I could eat during the weekend. And vice versa.

- I gained weight after college too, but not too much. It wasn't until I started having kids that the weight really came on. I felt like being pregnant meant I could eat anything, and then the weight would just come off after that. But it didn't, and having little babies made it really hard to diet. My mom told me the same thing happened to her. At first I just kind of thought oh well, I'm married, who cares if I get fat? But then my doctor started getting on me to lose, and some of my girlfriends have stayed thin, and my husband makes some comments sometimes about how I don't want to do anything but sit on the couch. So I keep trying, but it's really hard to do now! I remember how easy it was when I was younger! I was thinking like being on a diet took so much energy, was hard work, starting feeling like I didn't have any extra energy or motivation to diet. I felt like I was giving all my energy to work and family and didn't see any extra that would keep me on a diet. I also started feeling like being thin only mattered in terms of attracting people, and since I was married, it didn't matter if I wasn't.

Reflection Question	Your Response
In what ways does the biography (or biographic moment) explain your Big Assumption?	It tells me how it came to be in my life and shaped me. I see eating and feeling good as the same thing because that's how my family taught me. I also developed some unhealthy ideas about how to lose weight or keep weight off that only made my habits worse. Made me even more likely to want to eat as much as I could, all the time. Ugh! I wish I knew then how it would turn out...
Does your biography (or biographic moment) illuminate any additional Big Assumptions you might be making? Do you notice any definitive, i.e., this- always-happens, quality?	My diets were so strict that I would always fail at them. Actually the way I thought of them is that they always would fail – at the end of the week. Diets were never a different way to eat every day. (Potential BA: Changing your eating habits by going on a diet is a temporary, drastic change and not a long-term way to change your lifestyle.)
To what extent do you believe and feel the situation or events from your biography (or biographic moment) apply to your current life? If you think they do, how so?	I still feel like eating and drinking are part of the best things in life. I also still feel like I need to eat and drink a lot when I'm with family and friends if I'm going to have a good time, and if other people are going to have fun too. If I don't eat, it's like, "what's with her?" Even my husband says this to me, even though he wants me to lose weight.

Practice Time: Over To You

Compared with other exercises in the ITC arc, there are relatively few criteria for writing a good Biography of the Big Assumption. Fundamentally, you want to make sure that you are seeing a clear connection between the events/learning your client describes in his Biography and one or more of his Big Assumptions. The most common way, then, that the Biography can get off track is when that connection is not clear. Given the more straightforward nature of this exercise, we haven't included practice examples in this chapter.

Appendix A

WRITING THE BIOGRAPHY OF THE BIG ASSUMPTION EXERCISES

Writing the Biography of the Big Assumption: *The Deductive Approach*

Our Big Assumptions, typically, have been living with us for a while (sometimes, for a very long while), and have become part of our skin without our realizing it. They may have been born out of a single, significant event or over a series of experiences, typically at a time when we were young and in a different relationship to power and authority than we are as adults. The idea behind this exercise is that we may discover a different relationship to our Big Assumption if, now that we are adults, we revisit their earliest and most tender state (before they systematically re-confirmed their truth).

Read the “Biography” question below and sleep on it. It might be helpful to know that people tend to have one of two experiences with this exercise: Blah or wow! Some people find it very difficult to uncover a history of their Big Assumption, or if they do, they tend not to find anything interesting about it, whereas other people find this is a very clear “ah ha” moment. They feel excited by discovering a key source of what has allowed their Big Assumption to thrive all these years. So read the question now and unless something immediately comes to mind, come back to this exercise tomorrow. If this is a “blah” for you, skip it.

Directions: Explore the history of your Big Assumption: When was it born? Are there specific situations, feelings, important events or “moments” you can recall? How long has it been around? What were some of its critical turning points? Perhaps there is one “story,” event, “snapshot” or episode that captures something from your past that may have gotten your Big Assumption started or served to emphasize its importance? *Again, do not intentionally change anything you do or think relative to your Big Assumption.*

Your workspace:

If you wrote a biography, here are a few questions you might find useful:

Reflection Question	Your Response
In what ways does the biography (or biographic moment) explain your Big Assumption?	
Does your biography (or biographic moment) illuminate any additional Big Assumptions you might be making? Do you notice any definitive, i.e., this - always-happens, quality?	
To what extent do you believe and feel the situation or events from your biography (or biographic moment) apply to your current life? If you think they do, how so?	

Writing the Biography of the Big Assumption: *The Inductive Approach*

Thinking back over the first 15 or 16 years of life, identify a handful (five or six) memories that continue to stick with you and that were in some way negative (disturbing, puzzling, made you angry, upsetting, scary) in quality. They don't have to be events that were momentous – include events that may now seem tiny, mundane, common for many young people to experience in their lives. If these events were called up for you in your reflection, include them in your list. Record these events in column one below.

Events (the headlines)	What I was thinking (at that time)	What I was feeling (at that time)	Lessons learned/ conclusions drawn (at that time)

Directions continued: Once you have listed the headlines of these events in column one, complete columns 2-4. Column 4 is asking what you think you (that child who was 4 or 7 or 13) concluded at that time about yourself and the world. What were the lessons you learned then from those experiences?

When the table is complete, look at the lessons learned to see if there are any connections you can make between them and your Big Assumptions from your immunity map.

Reflection Question	Your Response
In what ways does the biography (or biographic moment) explain your Big Assumption?	
Does your biography (or biographic moment) illuminate any additional Big Assumptions you might be making? Do you notice any definitive, i.e., this - always-happens, quality?	
To what extent do you believe and feel the situation or events from your biography (or biographic moment) apply to your current life? If you think they do, how so?	

